

The God Who Is Not Nice

Recovering the Weight of God in a Sentimental Age

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LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

*What comes into our minds when we think about God is
the most important thing about us.*

— A. W. Tozer, *The Knowledge of the Holy*, 1961

Introduction: The God I Keep Preferring

I need to tell you something about myself before I tell you anything about God, because the two are more tangled than I would like them to be. The God I preach on Sunday is not always the God I want on Tuesday. The God I want on Tuesday is smaller. He is more agreeable. He fits in the palm of my afternoon and does not ask me to rearrange my life around him. He affirms the decisions I have already made. He is proud of me for reasons I have not earned. He is, in a word that has quietly become the highest compliment my culture can pay to anyone or anything, nice.

I came to faith late, and I came to it from the outside. I was an atheist not as a pose but as a settled conviction, a man who had done the reading and reached what he believed was the honest conclusion. When I finally could not hold that ground any longer, when the God I had denied turned out to be real in a way that undid me, I did not meet a nice God. That is the first thing I want you to know. The God who broke into my unbelief was not warm the way a blanket is warm. He was terrible the way a sunrise is terrible if you have spent your whole life underground. He was not comfortable. He was true, and the truth of him rearranged everything, and there was a period of weeks where I could not sleep because I had spent my adult life being confidently wrong about the most important thing there is. That God did not affirm me. That God saved me, which is a different and heavier act.

And yet within a year of my conversion I had started to sand him down. I did it without deciding to. It happens the way water finds the low place. I began to prefer the parts of God that consoled me and to grow quiet about the parts that unsettled me. I built, in the privacy of my own devotional life, a God who was mostly agreeable, occasionally sad about the world's suffering, and reliably on my side. I preached the big God on Sunday and lived with the small one the rest of the week. I suspect you have done the same thing, though your version has different features than mine. We are, all of us, in the business of God management, and business is good.

This is a book about the God we have lost and the God we keep trading him for. My thesis is simple and I will state it plainly so you can decide right now whether you want to keep reading. We have exchanged the holy, weighty, dangerous God of the Bible for a sentimental one who exists to affirm us and keep us comfortable. We have made a God who is nice. And nice is not holy. Nice is a small, thin, domesticated thing, a virtue for dinner parties, and we have draped it over the Ancient of Days and told ourselves we were being loving. We were not being loving. We were being cowardly, and we were being bored, and we were, though we would never say it this way, trying to make God safe.

Let me be precise about what I am not saying, because the false alternative will kill this book in your hands if I do not kill it first. I am not arguing for a mean God. That is the trap, and it is the trap everyone falls into the moment you criticize the sentimental one. They assume that if you take away the nice God you must be reaching for the cruel one, the angry deity of the worst sermons any of us have sat through, the God who is basically disappointed in you and looking for a reason to strike. That God is a heresy too. He is the sentimental God's evil twin, and he is

just as false, and he is just as much a projection of the human heart, only this time the fearful, self-hating part of it. I am not offering you that God. I am asking you to consider that the true God is neither nice nor mean, because both of those words belong to the world of the small and the manageable. The true God is holy. And holiness is a category we have almost entirely lost the ability to feel.

Rudolf Otto, writing in 1917 in a book called *The Idea of the Holy*, reached for a word that did not exist because the thing he was describing had fallen out of Christian speech. He called it the numinous. He said that when human beings encounter the holy they encounter a *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*, a mystery that makes you tremble and that draws you in at the same time, a reality so far above you that it overwhelms your capacity to hold it and yet so compelling that you cannot look away. That is the God of the burning bush, the God who tells Moses to take off his shoes because the ground itself has become dangerous with holiness. That is the God who fills the temple with smoke until Isaiah is undone. We do not have a category for that anymore. We have replaced *tremendum* with pleasant. We have taken the God who made Moses hide his face and turned him into a God who is glad you came to church and hopes you have a nice week.

I want to be honest about why we did this, because it was not stupidity and it was not simply the arrogance of a comfortable age, though it was partly both. It was fear, and it was grief, and it was a real wound that the church helped inflict. Many people were handed the mean God first. They were raised on the angry deity, the one who was keeping score, and they fled him, and they were right to flee that particular lie. But in fleeing him they did not run toward the holy God. They ran toward the nice one,

because the nice one felt like the only alternative to cruelty. That is the tragedy at the center of this whole thing. We have offered a wounded generation two false gods and told them to pick one, and they picked the kinder lie, and I do not entirely blame them. But a lie is a lie even when it is kind. And the nice God, for all his warmth, cannot do a single one of the things you actually need God to do.

That is the hinge of this book, so let me press on it now. The nice God cannot save you, because a God who was never going to hold anything against you did not have to do anything costly to forgive you, and a forgiveness that costs nothing is worth exactly what it costs. The nice God cannot comfort you in real suffering, because a God who is merely sympathetic, a God who feels bad alongside you but wields no terrible authority over death, is finally just another sufferer, and drowning men do not rescue each other. The nice God cannot be worshiped, because worship is the response of a small thing to a vast one, and you cannot worship something you can manage. You can only appreciate it. And appreciation, my friends, is what we have. We have a congregation full of people who appreciate God. Worship is a lost art because weight is a lost experience.

Dietrich Bonhoeffer, writing from inside a church that had made its peace with Hitler, gave us the phrase that names the whole disease. He called it cheap grace. Cheap grace, he wrote in 1937, is grace we bestow on ourselves. It is the preaching of forgiveness without repentance, communion without confession, grace without the cross. Cheap grace is the deadly enemy of the church, he said, and we are fighting for costly grace. What I want to show you across these chapters is that cheap grace and the nice God are the same object seen from two angles. A cheap grace requires a nice God to dispense it, a God with no holiness

that had to be satisfied, no wrath that had to be borne, no cost. And a nice God can only ever offer cheap grace, because he has nothing weightier to give. They stand or fall together. And in most of our hearts, most of the time, they are standing tall.

So here is what I am going to do. I am going to walk you back into the throne room. I am going to take you to Sinai, where the mountain burned and the people begged Moses to make it stop. I am going to stand you in front of Isaiah as the seraphim cry holy, holy, holy, and the doorposts shake, and a grown man, a good man, a prophet, comes apart at the seams and says woe is me, for I am undone. I am going to bring you to Job in the whirlwind, where a suffering man demands an answer and instead receives God himself, and finds that this is more than enough. I am going to walk with you through the wrath of God, which we have been taught to be embarrassed about, and I am going to try to show you that it is nothing other than the love of God turned toward everything that is destroying what he loves. I am going to sit you down in front of Aslan, and remind you, as a beaver once reminded a nervous English child, that he is not a tame lion. Of course he is not safe. But he is good. C.S. Lewis wrote that in 1950, and it may be the most important sentence about God written in the last century, because it holds the two things together that we keep tearing apart.

And I am going to keep confessing, all the way through, that I am the man who prefers the small God. I am not writing this from above you. I am writing it from inside the same failure. Every argument in this book is an argument I have had to have with myself, usually more than once, usually losing the first several rounds. The sentimental God is not a mistake other people make. He is the God I reach for when I am tired, when I am afraid, when I would rather be soothed than saved. I know his

features intimately because I keep drawing them. What I have found, and what I am asking you to find with me, is that every time I have let the small God die, the great God has proven to be the only one who could carry the weight I actually brought him. The holy God turns out to be the only comfort that holds. The dangerous God turns out to be the only safety worth having. This is the strange discovery at the end of the whole thing. We ran from the weight of God because we thought it would crush us. It is the only thing that can hold us up.

You picked the kinder lie. I did too. Let us go and find the harder truth, and see if it is not, in the end, the only thing gentle enough to save us.

Chapter One: The God We Would Prefer

Let me describe the God I would build if the building were left to me, because I suspect you have built one very like him, and it will help us both to see him clearly in the daylight, laid out on the table where we can look at what our hands have made. My God, the one I construct when no one is watching and I am not being careful, is warm. He is endlessly warm. He has the emotional temperature of a good therapist who also happens to like me personally. He is interested in my flourishing. He wants me to become the best version of myself, and he defines the best version of myself in terms I would have chosen anyway. He is not, if I am honest, terribly interested in my sin, because my sin embarrasses him a little the way it embarrasses me, and we have a tacit agreement not to bring it up. He is proud of me. He affirms my choices. And above all, above every other quality, he is comfortable to be around. I never leave his presence shaken. I never leave undone. I leave, if anything, a little more pleased with myself than when I arrived.

That God is an idol, and I made him, and I keep making him, and the fact that I made him out of nice materials instead of gold does not make him any less of an idol. This is the thing we have to get clear before we can go any further. An idol is not necessarily an ugly thing. The golden calf was beautiful. The idols of the ancient world were often the most refined artistic achievements of their cultures. An idol is simply a god of our own construction, a deity shaped to our specifications, a divinity we can predict and manage and, when necessary, put back on the

shelf. And by that definition the nice God is the most successful idol the modern West has ever produced, precisely because he does not look like an idol. He looks like kindness. He looks like the mature, non-judgmental, inclusive faith that we flatter ourselves for having achieved. He looks like progress. But strip away the flattering language and you find the oldest sin there is, which is the sin of making God in our own image, of reaching up into heaven and pulling God down to a size we can carry in one hand.

Why did we build him. That is the real question, and it deserves a real answer, not a sneer. We did not build the nice God out of pure laziness, though laziness played its part. We built him for reasons that were, in their origins, often sincere and sometimes even holy. Consider the person who was raised under the mean God, the angry father-deity of the fundamentalist childhood, the God who was always disappointed, always watching for the failure, always ready with the belt. That person grew up and could not breathe under that God, and one day they walked away, and I will not condemn them for it, because the God they walked away from was a lie about God, a slander against his character dressed up as reverence. The problem is what they walked toward. They did not walk toward the true God. They walked toward the opposite of the God who hurt them, and the opposite of a cruel God, in a therapeutic age, is a nice one. So the nice God was built, in part, as a refuge from cruelty. That is a sincere motive. It is also a catastrophe, because it means an entire generation now defines God primarily by contrast to their worst experience of religion, which is like defining marriage by contrast to the worst divorce you ever saw.

There is a second builder, and this one is me, and maybe you. This builder was not fleeing cruelty. This builder was fleeing

weight. Because the holy God, the real one, makes demands, and the demands are total, and there is a part of every human heart that would rather have a manageable relationship with a small God than a life-consuming one with a great one. The holy God will not let you keep the compartments. He will not accept the ninety percent while you wall off the ten. He wants the whole territory, every room, including the rooms you have not opened in years, and there is something in us that recoils from that not because it is cruel but precisely because it is not, because it is love, and love at full strength is the most demanding thing in the universe. So we shrink him. We prefer the God who wants a manageable slice of us to the God who wants all of us, and we call our preference spiritual maturity, and we congratulate ourselves for having outgrown the intense faith of our youth, when in fact we have simply negotiated God down to a comfortable minimum.

Charles Taylor, the philosopher, published a book in 2007 called *A Secular Age*, and in it he described what he called the buffered self, the modern person who lives with a kind of protective shell against the transcendent, insulated from the powers and terrors that our ancestors felt pressing in on them from every side. The ancient person lived in a world thick with God, thick with spirits, thick with meaning that came from outside the self and could not be controlled. The modern person lives in a world where the self is the center and the transcendent, if it exists at all, has to knock and wait to be admitted, and mostly we do not answer the door. The nice God is the God of the buffered self. He is the God who has agreed to stay outside the shell, to be present only when summoned, to respect our boundaries, to never overwhelm us. He is a God who has been buffered, domesticated, brought inside the manageable circle of the modern self, and there he sits, warm and useless, because a God who cannot overwhelm you cannot

save you either.

And here I have to name what the nice God costs us, because we talk about him as though he were a gain, as though we had matured past the frightening God into a gentler and truer faith. He is not a gain. He is an amputation. When we lost the holiness of God we lost, in the same stroke, the thing that made grace astonishing. Think about it plainly. If God was never really holy, if his standard was never truly high, if his justice was never actually going to fall, then what exactly was forgiven at the cross. What was the cost. Why the blood. Why the agony in the garden, the sweat like drops of blood, the cry of dereliction. If the Father was always basically nice, always going to let it slide, then the cross is not a rescue, it is a piece of grotesque and unnecessary theater, God torturing himself to solve a problem that did not exist. The nice God empties the cross of its meaning. He turns the central event of the universe into a sentimental gesture. And a church that has quietly adopted the nice God will find, sooner or later, that it has nothing left to say about the cross except that it shows how much God cares, which is true, and infinitely thin, and not remotely enough to build a life on.

I watched this happen to a man in my church, and I will not give you enough detail to identify him, but I will tell you the shape of it, because it is the shape of the thing itself. He was a pleasant man, a believer of a certain modern kind, and his faith was almost entirely composed of the nice God. God loved him, God wanted good things for him, God was walking beside him, and all of that was, as far as it went, true. Then his daughter died. She died young and she died wrong, the way it is always wrong, and I sat with him in the worst weeks, and I watched his faith come apart, and it did not come apart because his God was too harsh. It came apart because his God was too small. The nice God had

nothing to say to him. The nice God could only stand there beside the grave and feel sad, and a God who can only feel sad is no better than the rest of us feeling sad, and worse, because we expected more from him. What that man needed, and did not have, was the holy God, the God of terrible sovereignty and terrible mercy, the God who is Lord even of the grave, the God whose ways are not our ways and whose refusal to explain himself is somehow, in the whirlwind, more comforting than any explanation. He had traded that God away years earlier for a warmer one, and when the cold came, the warm God evaporated, and he was left standing in the dark holding nothing.

That is what the nice God cannot do. He cannot stand in the dark with you, because he is a fair-weather deity, a God for the days when things are basically fine. He was built during good times, out of the surplus of a comfortable society, and he has no equipment for catastrophe. The holy God, by contrast, was forged in the fire of Sinai and revealed most fully at Golgotha, which is to say he was revealed most fully at the exact site of the worst suffering the universe has ever contained. He is not a fair-weather God. He is a God who has been to the bottom, who has tasted death, who reigns from a cross, and precisely because he is heavy enough to have borne that, he is heavy enough to bear you. Weight, it turns out, is not the enemy of comfort. Weight is the precondition of comfort. Only a heavy God can hold you when everything else gives way.

So this whole book is, in one sense, an invitation to grief, and I want to be honest about that. To recover the holy God we are going to have to let the nice God die, and the nice God has been a comfort to us, a real one, in the way that a lie can be a comfort right up until you need the truth. Letting him die will feel, at first, like a loss. It will feel like giving up warmth for cold, like

exchanging the friendly deity for a frightening one. I felt that. I still feel it, in the low hours, when I reach again for the small God and find him gone. But I have learned something on the other side of that grief, and it is the thing I most want to give you in these pages. The warmth of the nice God was the warmth of a candle. The warmth of the holy God is the warmth of the sun, and if it frightens you at first, that is only because you have been living in a small room and have forgotten what real fire feels like. We are going to leave the small room now. Take off your shoes. The ground out here is holy, and it has been waiting for us the whole time.

Chapter Two: Holiness as Otherness

We have used the word holy so often and so carelessly that we have worn it smooth, and a worn word is a dangerous thing, because it slides through the mind without catching on anything. When most people hear the word holy they think of moral goodness, and they are not entirely wrong, but they are starting at the wrong end and they will never reach the center that way. Holiness in Scripture is not first of all a moral quality. It is, before it is anything else, a category of separation. The Hebrew word *qadosh*, the word the seraphim cry in Isaiah's temple vision, carries at its root the sense of being cut off, set apart, other. To say that God is holy is to say, first, that he is not like us. He is not a bigger version of us. He is not the best of us extended to infinity. He belongs to a different order of being entirely, and everything we call his moral perfection flows from that prior and more staggering fact, that he is other, wholly other, other all the way down.

Rudolf Otto understood this better than almost anyone in the modern period, and I keep returning to him because he had the nerve to say the thing the theologians of his day were too embarrassed to say. In 1917, in the middle of a war that was making a mockery of every comfortable idea about God and man, Otto published *The Idea of the Holy*, and in it he argued that the essence of religious experience is not moral, not rational, not even primarily loving, but something he had to invent a word for because the word had gone missing. He called it the numinous, from the Latin *numen*, a divine power. The numinous is what you feel, not when you contemplate God's ethics, but

when you are confronted with God's sheer otherness, his overwhelming and unaccountable reality. And Otto said this experience always has two faces at once. It is *mysterium tremendum*, a mystery that makes you tremble, that fills you with awe and even dread, that reduces you to nothing before it. And it is at the same time *fascinans*, fascinating, magnetic, drawing you in with an attraction you cannot resist even as it terrifies you. Tremble and be drawn. Dread and desire. Both at once, and neither cancelling the other. That is the signature of an encounter with the holy.

Now hold that description next to the God most of us carry around, and feel the distance. When was the last time your experience of God made you tremble. When was the last time you were, in Otto's sense, filled with dread, not the neurotic dread of a guilty conscience but the clean, overwhelming awe of a small creature before an immense reality. For most of us the honest answer is that we cannot remember, and many of us have never had such an experience at all, and we have quietly concluded that this must mean the descriptions in Scripture are exaggerations, poetic license, the overheated language of a more primitive time. But what if it is not the ancients who are exaggerating. What if it is we who have gone numb. What if the mountain still burns and we have simply built our houses far enough away that we can no longer feel the heat, and we have mistaken our distance for sophistication.

Consider Moses at the bush. He is a shepherd on an ordinary day in an ordinary place, the back side of the desert, and there is a bush on fire that does not burn up, and he turns aside to look, and then the voice comes. Take off your sandals, for the place where you are standing is holy ground. Notice what the holiness has done to the geography. This is a patch of dirt in the wilderness,

indistinguishable from every other patch of dirt for a hundred miles. But the presence of God has made it dangerous. It has become ground you cannot approach casually, ground that requires you to remove the barrier between your skin and the earth, ground that demands a change in how you hold your body. The holiness of God is not an abstraction here. It is a physical fact with physical consequences, and Moses, who will later stand before Pharaoh without flinching, hides his face, because he is afraid to look at God. This is the man we hold up as the great mediator, the friend of God who spoke to him as a man speaks to his friend, and even he cannot look. That is otherness. That is holiness before it becomes a moral category. That is the God we have covered over with the word nice.

The reason this matters, the reason I am not merely conducting a word study, is that everything about how you relate to God depends on whether you have grasped his otherness. If God is simply a large and improved version of a human person, then your relationship with him will be a relationship between peers, a friendship between similar beings, and friendship between peers is a relationship you can manage, negotiate, and if necessary walk away from. But if God is other, if he belongs to a wholly different order of being, then the relationship is asymmetrical in a way that changes everything. You did not choose it into being and you cannot dissolve it. You are the creature and he is the Creator, and that gap is not a gap of degree but of kind. A creature does not stand before its Creator the way one man stands before another. It stands the way a painting would stand before the painter if the painting could somehow become aware, which is to say it stands in a relation of total and asymmetrical dependence, owing its very existence, moment by moment, to the will of the one who made it. We have lost this. We have flattened the vertical into the horizontal. We have made

God our peer, and a peer, however admirable, is not a thing you can worship.

I have felt the loss of this in my own preaching, and I will confess it here because confession is the price of writing a book like this honestly. There have been whole seasons where I preached a God who was, functionally, a very good friend. I preached his kindness, his nearness, his tenderness, his understanding, and none of that was false, but I left out his otherness, and the result was a congregation that liked God, that found God relatable, that thought of God as being basically on their level and basically on their side. And I watched what it produced. It produced a casual faith. It produced people who prayed the way you text a friend, who treated the presence of God as a pleasant background hum, who could not understand why anyone would fall on their face or fear or tremble, because you do not tremble before a friend. I had preached the otherness out of God, and in doing so I had preached the awe out of my people, and awe, it turns out, is not an optional extra. Awe is the emotional shape of a creature that has correctly perceived its Creator. Where there is no awe, something has gone wrong at the root.

The recovery of holiness begins, then, not with trying harder to be good, but with trying to see truly, with asking God to restore to us the perception of his otherness that sin and sentimentality together have destroyed in us. And I want to be clear that this is a gift, not an achievement. You cannot manufacture awe by an act of will. You cannot decide to tremble. The numinous is not summoned by technique. It comes, when it comes, as a disclosure, a lifting of the veil, a moment when the buffered self is unexpectedly pierced and the transcendent floods in. What we can do is stop actively resisting it. We can stop filing down the

edges of God. We can read the passages we have been skipping, the fire and the smoke and the trembling mountain, and we can refuse to explain them away, and we can ask the God they describe to be, for us, the God he actually is. That prayer is more dangerous than it sounds. Be careful praying it. You may get what you ask for, and it will not leave you where it found you.

Because here is the thing about otherness that the sentimental age has entirely forgotten. The otherness of God is not cold. This is the great misunderstanding, the thing that keeps people fleeing the holy God for the nice one. We assume that a God who is wholly other must be a God who is wholly distant, that transcendence and intimacy are opposites, that the further above us God is the further away from us he must be. But it is exactly the reverse. The God who is infinitely other is also the God who is nearer to you than you are to yourself, because a God who is merely a bigger person could only be near you the way another person is near you, from the outside, at a distance, across the unbridgeable gap that separates one self from another. But the God who is wholly other is not bounded by that gap. He is not another object in the universe competing for space with you. He is the ground of your being, closer than your breath, more intimate than your own thoughts. Augustine saw this in the fourth century when he cried out that God was more inward to him than his most inward part, interior intimo meo. The otherness of God is the very thing that makes his nearness possible. Only because he is not one thing among many can he be wholly within you and wholly beyond you at once. Lose the otherness and you lose the intimacy too, and you are left with the nice God, who is near you the way a helpful neighbor is near you, and just as easily gone.

So we begin here, at otherness, because everything else stands on

it. The wrath, the jealousy, the fear of the Lord, the whirlwind, the consuming fire, the cross itself, all of it makes sense only if you have first grasped that God is not like you, that he belongs to another order, that the ground where he stands is holy and your shoes must come off. Take them off now. We are only at the beginning, and already the ground is warm.

Chapter Three: Woe Is Me

There is a moment in the sixth chapter of Isaiah that I think may be the single most important passage in the Bible for a sentimental age, and I want to walk through it slowly, because we have heard it so often that we have stopped hearing it at all. Isaiah tells us the date. In the year that King Uzziah died. This is not decoration. Uzziah had reigned for fifty-two years. He was the only king Isaiah had ever known, the fixed point, the stable center of the national life, and now he is dead, and the throne of Judah is empty and the future is uncertain and the ground is shifting under everyone's feet. It is in that year, the year the earthly throne emptied, that Isaiah is shown the throne that never empties. I saw the Lord, he says, seated on a throne, high and lifted up, and the train of his robe filled the temple. The earthly king is dead. The heavenly King is enthroned. Isaiah looks up from a grave and sees a throne.

And around the throne are the seraphim, the burning ones, for that is what the word means, creatures of fire, and each of them has six wings, and with two they cover their faces and with two they cover their feet and with two they fly. Stop there and consider it. These are unfallen creatures. These are beings who have never sinned, who have stood in the immediate presence of God since before the foundations of the world, and even they cannot look. Even the sinless burning ones veil their faces before the holiness of God. This is the detail that should end forever our casual approach to the throne. If the seraphim cover their faces, what business have we sauntering in. We speak of coming boldly to the throne of grace, and rightly, for the New Testament tells us

we may, but we have turned boldness into casualness, and they are not the same thing. The seraphim are bold. They fly. But they veil their faces, because boldness in the presence of holiness is not the same as familiarity, and we have confused the two so thoroughly that we have lost the capacity to be properly afraid.

And they are crying, one to another, and the cry is the great cry, the only threefold repetition of any divine attribute in all of Scripture. Holy, holy, holy is the Lord of hosts. The whole earth is full of his glory. In Hebrew, repetition is intensification. To say a thing twice is to emphasize it. To say it three times is to raise it to the highest possible degree, to the superlative beyond the superlative. God is never called love, love, love. He is never called mercy, mercy, mercy, though he is merciful beyond all telling. He is called holy, holy, holy, and this threefold cry is the deepest word the Bible has about the character of God. His holiness is the attribute of his attributes, the quality that qualifies all the others. His love is a holy love. His mercy is a holy mercy. His wrath is a holy wrath. Holiness is not one item on a list of divine perfections. It is the flame that burns through all of them and makes each of them what it is.

And the sound of the cry shakes the building. The foundations of the thresholds shook at the voice of him who called, Isaiah says, and the house was filled with smoke. The temple, the most sacred structure in Israel, the place built precisely to house the presence of God, cannot contain that presence when it manifests. The doorframes shake. The whole edifice fills with smoke, the same smoke that covered Sinai, the visible sign of a holiness too great for the space to hold. And Isaiah, standing in the middle of it, does the only thing a human being can do in the presence of the thrice-holy God, the thing we have almost entirely lost the capacity to do. He falls apart.

Woe is me, he cries. For I am undone. For I am a man of unclean lips, and I dwell in the midst of a people of unclean lips, for my eyes have seen the King, the Lord of hosts. I want you to feel the force of this, because it is the exact opposite of everything the sentimental age has trained us to expect from an encounter with God. Isaiah does not feel affirmed. He does not feel that his best self is being called forth. He does not feel seen and validated and understood. He feels destroyed. The word translated undone means to be disintegrated, to come apart, to be ruined and silenced. This is a good man. This is a prophet, a man called by God, and probably as righteous as anyone in the nation of Judah. And the moment he sees the holy God, all of that righteousness turns to ash in his mouth, and the first thing he becomes aware of, of all the things he could have said, is his lips. My unclean lips. The instrument of his calling, the very thing he does for God, the speaking, and even that is defiled, even that cannot bear the light.

This is the thing the nice God can never give us, and it is the very thing we most need, though we would never ask for it. The nice God tells you that you are basically fine, that your instinct toward goodness is trustworthy, that you should follow your heart, that you are already, in the deepest place, whole. And this feels wonderful, and it is a lie, and it leaves you exactly where you were, which is undone, only now you do not know it, and a man who is undone and does not know it is in far worse condition than a man who is undone and has seen it clearly. The holy God, by contrast, undoes you on purpose, not to destroy you but to save you, because the destruction of your false wholeness is the only door to your true one. Isaiah has to fall apart before he can be sent. The woe comes before the here am I. There is no shortcut around the undoing. Every counterfeit spirituality promises you the sending without the woe, the

calling without the collapse, the glory without the smoke, and every one of them is selling the nice God, and none of them can make a prophet.

And then, only then, after the collapse, comes the grace, and notice how it comes, because this is everything. Isaiah does not fix himself. He does not resolve to do better. He does not make himself worthy. He lies there undone, and one of the seraphim flies to him, and in its hand is a burning coal taken with tongs from the altar, tongs because even the burning one will not touch the coal directly, and the seraph touches the coal to Isaiah's mouth, to the unclean lips, to the exact place of the confessed defilement, and it burns. Understand that it burns. The cleansing of the holy God is not a soothing thing. It is a coal against the lips. It hurts, the way the surgeon's work hurts, the way setting a broken bone hurts, because the removal of what is killing you is not a gentle procedure and the God who is not nice does not pretend that it is. And with the burning comes the word. Behold, this has touched your lips, and your iniquity is taken away, and your sin atoned for. The undoing is answered by atonement. The collapse is answered by grace. But the grace comes through fire, and it comes after the woe, and there is no other order in which it can come.

I have to sit with my own lips here, because I preach, and Isaiah's confession is a preacher's confession. I am a man of unclean lips, and I dwell in the midst of a people of unclean lips, and I have used my lips, the very lips God called, to preach a smaller God than the one who called me. I have stood in pulpits and spoken of God in tones I would never dare to use if the smoke were actually filling the room, if the doorframes were actually shaking, if the seraphim were actually crying holy over my shoulder. Familiarity is the preacher's chief occupational hazard.

You handle holy things so often that they stop being holy in your hands. You discuss the throne room the way a man discusses his office. And Isaiah stands as a rebuke to every one of us who has grown casual with the coal, who has learned to talk about the fire without ever again being burned by it. The mark of a true encounter with the holy God is not that you leave able to describe him. It is that you leave unable to speak, and then, if grace is merciful, able to speak again, but never the same way, never casually, never without the memory of the coal.

The sentimental age wants the sending without the woe. It wants Isaiah's commission, here am I, send me, printed on the coffee mug and the worship slide, and it has quietly deleted the eleven verses of terror that come before it. But you cannot have the one without the other. The man who says here am I is the same man who a moment before said woe is me, and it is the woe that qualifies him. It is the collapse that makes the sending possible. A man who has not been undone before the holy God has nothing to say from God, because he has not yet met God, only his idea of God, only the nice deity of his own construction, and that god cannot commission anyone because that god does not exist. Isaiah met the real one. The building shook. He came apart. The coal burned. And out of the ruins, a prophet stood up who would speak for God for the rest of his life, and whose words we are still reading twenty-seven centuries later, and it all began with a man on the floor of a shaking temple, saying the truest words a human being can say. Woe is me. I am undone. I have seen the King.

Chapter Four: The Wrath That Is Love

I am going to write now about the wrath of God, and I know that some of you have been dreading this chapter, and I know it because I have been dreading writing it, because the wrath of God is the single hardest thing to say to a sentimental age without being misheard. So let me begin by clearing the ground, hard period at the end of each false idea. The wrath of God is not a divine temper. It is not God losing control. It is not the petulance of a touchy deity who cannot stand to be crossed. It is not the arbitrary rage of the pagan gods, who struck men down for slights and had to be appeased with blood so they would calm down. Every one of those is a slander, and every one of those is what the modern person hears when you say the word wrath, and so the modern person recoils, and the modern person is right to recoil from what they are hearing, and wrong about what the Bible actually means.

Take away the wrath of God and you have not made him more loving. You have made him indifferent, and indifference is the one thing love can never be.

Here is what the Bible means. The wrath of God is the settled, holy, and personal opposition of God to everything that destroys what he loves. Read that again slowly. It is not opposition to us. It is opposition to what is killing us. Wrath is not the opposite of love. Wrath is what love feels when it confronts the thing that is murdering the beloved. And once you see it that way, you realize

that a God without wrath is not a more loving God but a less loving one, in fact a God who does not love at all, because love that is indifferent to the destruction of the beloved is not love. It is sentiment. It is the greeting-card feeling that costs nothing and protects no one. The nice God, the God with no wrath, watches the beloved be devoured and murmurs that he understands, that everyone is doing their best, that it will all work out, and he does nothing, because he feels no fury, because he does not love enough to be furious.

Let me make this concrete, because in the abstract wrath will always sound like cruelty, and only in the concrete does it reveal itself as love. Imagine a father who discovers that a man has been abusing his child. Imagine the exact moment the knowledge lands. If that father feels nothing, if he shrugs, if he says that the abuser is on his own path and who is he to judge, we do not call that father loving. We call him a monster. We understand, instinctively, at a level below argument, that the absence of wrath in the presence of that evil is itself a kind of evil, a failure of love so total that it curdles into complicity. The father who loves his child rightly is a father who becomes, in that moment, terrible. His love for the child and his wrath against the abuser are not two things. They are one thing. They are the same fire, and the fire is love, and the wrath is what love looks like when it turns to face what is destroying the one it loves. Take away that father's capacity for wrath and you have not made him gentler. You have made him someone who does not really love his child.

Now lift that up to the scale of God, and lift it up to the scale of all the evil there has ever been, and you begin to understand why the God of the Bible is a God of wrath, and why his wrath, far from being an embarrassment to be explained away, is one of the most reassuring things about him. The sentimental age has

taught us to want a God with no wrath, and we have not understood what we were asking for. We were asking for a God who does not care what happens to us, a God who watches the machinery of evil grind up the innocent and feels no fury, a God who is unmoved by the trafficking of children and the slaughter of the weak and the slow murder of the poor, a God so relentlessly nice that nothing, no atrocity, no matter how vast, can disturb his placid affirmation of everyone. That is the God with no wrath. That is the God we said we wanted. And that God is a horror, and we did not see it, because we were only ever thinking of our own small sins and wanting them overlooked, and we never stopped to think that a God who would overlook our sins would also overlook the sins committed against us, and against everyone we love, and against every victim who has ever cried out for justice and found, in the God of the sentimental age, nothing but a shrug.

The prophets understood this, and it is why the prophets, who are the most terrifying writers in the Bible, are also the writers most consumed with justice for the oppressed. It is no accident. Walter Brueggemann has spent a career, most powerfully in his 1978 book *The Prophetic Imagination*, showing that the prophetic announcement of God's wrath is inseparable from the prophetic passion for the widow, the orphan, and the stranger. The God who thunders in Amos, who says he despises their feasts and will not accept their offerings, is thundering because they have sold the righteous for silver and the needy for a pair of sandals, because they trample the poor into the dust. The wrath is for the sake of the crushed. Silence the wrath and you have not protected the poor. You have abandoned them, because you have made a God who will let their oppression stand forever, world without end, with no reckoning, no justice, no day when the accounts are settled and the victims are vindicated and the

predators are stopped. The wrath of God is the poor man's only hope. It is the guarantee that evil does not get the last word, that the powerful do not win in the end simply because they won in the meantime.

And here is where it cuts back toward me, toward us, because the comfort of God's wrath against the evil done to us is inseparable from the terror of God's wrath against the evil done by us, and we do not get to have the one without the other. This is the hardest turn in the whole thing, and I will not soften it, because softening it is exactly how we got the nice God in the first place. The same holiness that makes God furious at the abuser makes him furious at every abuse, including mine, including the ways I have used and diminished and wounded other people, including the cutting word and the withheld mercy and the pride that treats other souls as instruments of my comfort. If I want a God whose wrath protects the weak, I have to reckon with a God whose wrath includes me, because I have not always been on the side of the weak. Sometimes I have been the strong one doing the trampling, and I would rather not think about that, and the nice God exists precisely so that I never have to. The nice God lets me be furious at everyone else's sins while excusing my own. The holy God's wrath is no respecter of persons. It burns against evil wherever it is found, and it is found in me.

This is the crisis that only the cross can resolve, and I am getting ahead of myself, because we will come to the cross in its own chapter, and it deserves to be reached, not rushed. But I have to gesture at it here, because otherwise the wrath of God simply crushes and leaves us with no gospel, and that would be its own kind of lie. The staggering claim at the center of Christianity is that the God whose wrath we rightly fear did not stand at a distance and pour that wrath out on us. He took it into himself.

The Judge stepped down from the bench and stood in the place of the guilty and absorbed, in his own body, the full weight of the wrath that our evil had earned. The fire that should have fallen on us fell on him. That is what the cross is, and you cannot understand it, you cannot even see it, until you have first taken the wrath of God with total seriousness, because a cross that answers no wrath is a cross that solves no problem, a piece of pointless suffering, a God torturing himself for no reason. Remove the wrath and you have not saved the cross. You have destroyed it. You have made it meaningless. The nice God has no cross, because the nice God has no wrath, and a religion of the nice God is a religion with an empty symbol at its center, a cross drained of everything that made it the hinge of history.

So I will not apologize for the wrath of God, and I will not explain it away, and I will not preach a God whose love is so thin that nothing can provoke it. I want a God who is angry, because I want a God who loves, and I have finally understood that these are the same wanting. I want a God who is furious at what evil has done to this world and to the people in it and to me. I want a God whose fury is the guarantee that the last chapter is not written by the predators. And I want, though it terrifies me, a God whose fury includes my own evil, because a God who would wink at my sin is a God who would wink at every sin, and I have wept too many times with victims of sins that God had better not be winking at. The wrath of God is not the dark side of his love. It is the heat of it. It is love at the temperature required to burn away everything that is destroying the beloved, and if you have never felt it as terrible, you have also never felt it as good, and it is time we felt it as both.

Chapter Five: The Jealousy of God

There is a sentence in the twentieth chapter of Exodus that ought to stop us cold every time, and it does not, because we have heard it too often and filed it under the archaic. God, in the giving of the commandments, in the very act of forbidding idolatry, says of himself, I the Lord your God am a jealous God. Not I was jealous once. Not I can be jealous under certain provocations. It is a name. It is an attribute. It is offered as a reason, as the ground of the commandment. You shall have no other gods before me, for I the Lord your God am a jealous God. And later, in the thirty-fourth chapter, the statement becomes almost unbearable in its directness. The Lord, whose name is Jealous, is a jealous God. His name is Jealous. Not merely one who is sometimes jealous, but one whose very name, whose deepest identity, is bound up with this fierce and possessive love. We have no idea what to do with this, and so we do nothing with it, and in doing nothing with it we lose one of the most important things there is to know about the God who made us.

A love that does not care whether it is returned is not a higher love. It is no love at all.

Our problem is that jealousy has become, in our vocabulary, a wholly negative word, a synonym for petty insecurity, the green-eyed monster, the possessive and controlling impulse of a small and frightened soul. And there is such a thing as sinful jealousy, the jealousy of the man who cannot bear his neighbor's success, the jealousy that is really envy, the jealousy that wants to control what it has no right to. But there is another jealousy, and it is not

a lesser form of the same thing but a wholly different thing that happens to share a name, and it is the jealousy of covenant love, the jealousy that is the exact and necessary shape of a love that has given itself entirely and rightly asks to be entirely received. Consider the marriage. A husband who feels nothing when his wife gives herself to another man is not a model of enlightened non-attachment. He is a husband who does not love his wife. The jealousy of a faithful spouse is not a defect in the love. It is the proof of it. It is what exclusive covenant love feels like from the inside when the covenant is broken. To love someone with your whole self and to ask for their whole self in return, and to be wounded to the depths when that self is given to another, this is not insecurity. This is love that has taken itself seriously.

And this is precisely the image the Bible uses, again and again, more than any other, to describe the relationship between God and his people. It is a marriage. The covenant at Sinai is a wedding. The idolatry of Israel is adultery, and the prophets do not use the word gently. Hosea is commanded to marry a woman who will betray him, to love a wife who runs to other men, so that the nation can see, in the anguish of one faithful husband, the anguish of God over a people who take the love he has poured out and lavish it on idols. Ezekiel, in his sixteenth chapter, tells the story of God finding Israel as an abandoned infant, bloody and unwanted in a field, and raising her, and clothing her, and adorning her with jewels, and making her beautiful, and then watching her take every gift he gave her and use it to purchase the affections of her lovers. The jealousy of God is the jealousy of a husband who rescued a bride from death and finds her selling herself in the street with the jewelry he bought her. If that does not move you, you have not understood it. And if it does move you, you are beginning to understand that the jealousy of God is not the opposite of his love but the

intensity of it.

The nice God is not jealous, and we thought this made him better, and it makes him worse. The nice God does not mind if you divide your heart. He is content to be one option among many, one interest among your interests, one relationship in your portfolio of relationships, wheeled out on Sundays and holidays and returned to the shelf. He asks for nothing exclusive. He does not care if you love the world more than you love him, if you give your deepest devotion to your career or your comfort or your reputation or your children or your own reflection, so long as you keep a pleasant corner of your life reserved for him. And we call this freedom. We call it a mature and non-controlling spirituality. But it is not freedom and it is not maturity. It is the indifference of a God who does not love you enough to want all of you, and there is nothing to celebrate in being loved by a God who does not much care whether you love him back.

Because the jealousy of God, terrible as it is, contains a truth about our worth that the nice God can never offer. To be the object of God's jealousy is to be wanted with an intensity that staggers the imagination. It means God is not indifferent to where your heart goes. It means your devotion actually matters to him, that he is not a self-sufficient abstraction who would be equally content whether you loved him or forgot him, but a lover who has set his heart upon you and will not share you and will not let you go without a fight. We say we want to be loved unconditionally, and we do, but we have confused unconditional love with indifferent love, and they are opposites. Indifferent love makes no demands because it feels no stakes. Jealous love makes total demands because the stakes are everything. When you understand that the God of the universe is jealous over you, you understand that you matter to him in a way that should undo

you, that your wandering heart causes him something like grief, that he wants you the way the faithful husband wants the wife, wholly, exclusively, and forever. That is not a diminished love. It is the highest love there is.

And it explains something about our idolatry that nothing else explains, which is why it is so serious, why the Bible treats it not as a minor error but as the root sin, the sin beneath all sins. If God were merely a lawgiver, idolatry would be a technical violation, worshiping the wrong deity, checking the wrong box. But God is a husband, and so idolatry is not a technicality. It is adultery. It is the betrayal of a covenant of love. It is taking the heart that was pledged to God and giving it to a thing that cannot love you back, a career that will discard you, a reputation that will not survive you, a comfort that cannot save you, a child who was never meant to bear the weight of your worship and will be crushed by it. Idolatry is not just wrong. It is unfaithful, and it is self-destructive, because it pours the wine of the heart into cups that hold nothing, and it leaves the God who actually loves you standing outside, jealous, wounded, and waiting. The jealousy of God is his refusal to accept the arrangement. It is his insistence on the whole of you, not because he needs you but because he loves you, and love at full strength cannot be content with a portion.

I have to confess my own idolatries here, because a chapter on the jealousy of God written by a man who pretends he has none would be a lie, and this book has promised not to lie. I know the pull of the divided heart. I have given to my ministry, to the good and holy work of the church, a devotion that at times has crowded out the God the ministry was supposed to serve. I have loved being useful more than I have loved the Master I was being useful to. I have loved the approval of people, the sense of being

respected, the small kingdom of my own competence, and I have felt, when I was honest, the jealousy of God pressing against those loves, refusing to be one option among them, refusing to share the throne of my heart with the idol of my own reputation. It is uncomfortable to be loved that fiercely, because a fierce love will not leave you alone. The nice God would have left me alone. He would have let me keep my little idols and been glad for the corner I gave him. The jealous God will not, and though it costs me constantly, I have come to see it as the deepest mercy, because the God who will not share me is the only God who is actually saving me from the things that were tearing me apart.

So do not wish the jealousy of God away. It is the fire of a love that will not let you go. It is the guarantee that you matter, that your heart is wanted, that you are not adrift in the indifferent affection of a God who would be equally content to lose you. His name is Jealous, and if you have ever been loved by someone who wanted your whole heart and would not settle for a fragment, you have felt, however dimly, the edge of what it means. Now lift that to the scale of God. Lift it to the scale of the One who made you and rescued you and will not, at any cost, let you be divided from himself. That is not a God to flee. That is a God to fall down before, undone that you should be wanted so completely by the only One whose wanting could ever be enough.

Chapter Six: The Fear of the Lord

The Bible says, and says repeatedly, and says as a kind of foundational axiom on which everything else is built, that the fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom. It is in the Psalms and it is in the Proverbs and it is assumed everywhere else. The fear of the Lord is the beginning of knowledge. The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom. And a sentimental age, which has worked so hard to make God unfrightening, does not know what to do with a sentence that makes fear the doorway to everything worth having. So we have developed a strategy, and the strategy is to redefine the word until it no longer means what it says. We explain, in gentle tones, that the fear of the Lord does not really mean fear. It means reverence. It means respect. It means a kind of awed admiration that has nothing frightening in it at all. And there is a grain of truth in this, and the grain of truth is being used to bury the mountain.

A God you have entirely stopped fearing is a God you have entirely stopped seeing.

Because here is what is true. The fear of the Lord is indeed more than terror, and it is not the cringing dread of a slave before a tyrant, and it is not incompatible with love, and in fact the mature fear of the Lord and the mature love of God grow together and deepen together rather than cancelling each other out. All of that is true. But notice what the redefiners do with it. They use the truth that the fear of the Lord is more than terror to conclude that it contains no terror at all, and that does not follow, and it is not true, and it is precisely the move the sentimental age

needs to make in order to keep God comfortable. The fear of the Lord is more than dread, but it is not less. It includes the dread and passes through it and comes out the other side into something richer, but it never leaves the dread behind entirely, because you cannot leave behind a true perception of what God actually is. If you have stopped trembling at God, it is not because you have matured past trembling. It is because you have stopped seeing him.

Consider what happens to the people in Scripture who actually encounter God, not the idea of God but the living presence, and ask whether reverence in the modern watered-down sense captures what they feel. Isaiah comes apart. Ezekiel falls on his face. Daniel says all his strength drained out of him and he became like a dead man. The disciples on the mountain of transfiguration fall down in terror. John, on Patmos, the disciple whom Jesus loved, the one who had leaned on his chest at the supper, sees the risen Christ in glory and falls at his feet as though dead. These are not people experiencing polite reverence. These are people experiencing the collapse of the whole self before a reality too great to endure. And notice that this happens even to those who love God most and are loved by him most. John's intimacy with Jesus did not exempt him from falling as though dead. It is not that fear is for the immature and love is for the advanced. It is that the closer you come to the real God, the more of both you feel, the fear and the love together, deepening in the same motion, each making the other truer.

I think we have lost the fear of the Lord because we have lost the sight of the Lord, and we have lost the sight of the Lord in part because we have worked so hard to make him safe, and now we reap what we have sown, which is a Christianity almost entirely without awe. Look at how we approach God. Look at how I

approach God, because I am not exempt and this book does not let me be. I come to God casually. I come with my list. I come the way you approach a helpful institution, expecting service, mildly disappointed when the service is slow. There is no trembling in my prayers, most days. There is no sense that I am addressing a fire. And I have wondered, in my more honest moments, whether the flatness of so much of my prayer life, the boredom that creeps in, the sense that nothing much is happening, is directly downstream from the loss of fear. You cannot be bored in the presence of something you find terrifying and beautiful at once. Boredom is the emotion of a soul that has decided God is safe, and a soul that has decided God is safe has decided something false, and the falseness has drained the life out of the encounter.

The fear of the Lord, rightly understood, is not the enemy of joy but its precondition, and this is the thing the sentimental age cannot grasp because it has set fear and joy against each other as opposites. But go to the people who have actually feared God and ask them about joy, and you will find the two braided together in a way that makes our comfortable, fearless, joyless faith look thin by comparison. The deepest joy is not the joy of the person who finds God manageable and pleasant. It is the joy of the person who has seen God as overwhelming and terrible and beautiful, who has felt the ground shake, who has known themselves to be a small and sinful creature before an infinite holiness, and who has discovered, on the far side of that terror, that this God, this actual God, this consuming fire, has bent down in love to rescue them. That joy has depth because it has been earned through terror. It is not the shallow cheerfulness of a faith that never trembled. It is the deep gladness of a soul that trembled all the way to the bottom and found, at the bottom, not destruction but mercy, and the mercy is a thousand times sweeter

for having been feared.

There is a passage in Exodus, right after Sinai, where the people are terrified by the thunder and the smoke and the trumpet blast, and they beg Moses to speak to them instead of God, because they are afraid they will die. And Moses says something that our translations struggle with because it sounds like a contradiction. Do not fear, he says, for God has come to test you, that the fear of him may be before you, that you may not sin. Do not fear, so that you may fear. Do not be afraid, in order that you may be afraid rightly. Moses is distinguishing two fears, and the distinction is the whole of the spiritual life. There is the fear that drives you away from God, the raw terror that makes the people beg for distance, and this fear is not the goal, and Moses tells them to set it aside. And there is the fear that draws you toward God in reverence and keeps you from sin, the fear that is the beginning of wisdom, and this fear is the goal, and it is meant to remain before you all your days. The nice God has neither fear. He has no terror to overcome and no reverence to grow into. He is simply pleasant, all the way through, and pleasantness is not wisdom and never has been.

C.S. Lewis wrote, in his 1940 book *The Problem of Pain*, that we want not so much a father in heaven as a grandfather in heaven, a senile benevolence who liked to see the young people enjoying themselves, and whose plan for the universe was simply that it could be said at the end of each day that a good time was had by all. That is the nice God exactly, a full generation before the phrase existed. A grandfather who wants a good time had by all. And Lewis saw that this is not love but a contemptible substitute for it, because real love, the love of a father rather than a doting grandfather, wants not merely the comfort of the beloved but their perfection, their holiness, their becoming what they were

made to be, and that kind of love is demanding, and being loved that way is more than a little frightening, because it will not leave you as you are. The fear of the Lord is the fear of being loved by a God who is not content to leave you as you are. It is the trembling of the clay before the potter who intends to reshape it entirely, and the trembling is right, because the reshaping is real, and it will cost you everything, and it is the best thing that will ever happen to you.

So I want to recover the fear of the Lord, in myself first, and I want to warn you that it cannot be recovered by trying to feel afraid. Fear is not something you can generate by effort, any more than awe is. It comes from sight. Fear the Lord means see the Lord, see him as he actually is, in his holiness and his otherness and his terrible love, and the fear will come of its own accord, because it is nothing other than the appropriate response of a creature that has correctly perceived its Creator. The reason we do not fear is that we do not see, and the reason we do not see is that we have spent a generation covering God's face with the veil of niceness so that we would never again have to feel small. Tear the veil. Ask to see. And when the trembling comes, do not flee it, and do not explain it away, and do not reach for the nice God to make it stop. Stay in it. It is the beginning of wisdom. It is the beginning of everything.

Chapter Seven: Not a Tame Lion

In 1950 a middle-aged Oxford don who had come to faith reluctantly and late, much as I did, published a children's book that has done more to teach grown adults the true character of God than most of the theology written in the same century. C.S. Lewis wrote *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe*, and in it he gave us Aslan, the great Lion who is the Christ figure of that world, and he gave us, in a single exchange between a talking beaver and some nervous English children, the most important thing anyone has said about God in modern times. The children have just learned that Aslan is a lion, and Susan, sensibly, asks whether he is safe. And Mr. Beaver replies, Safe. Who said anything about safe. Course he isn't safe. But he's good. He's the King, I tell you.

He is not safe. But he is good. Everything the sentimental age gets wrong about God is the confusion of those two words.

I want to sit inside that exchange for a while, because it contains, in nine words, the exact correction the sentimental age most needs, and because Lewis, who was a genius, knew precisely what he was doing when he put safe and good in opposition. We assume the two words go together. We assume that a good God must be a safe God, that goodness and safety are near synonyms, that the better something is the less dangerous it must be. And this assumption is the whole engine of the sentimental error. Because if good means safe, then a God who is not safe cannot be good, and a God who terrifies, a God before whom Isaiah

collapses and John falls as dead, a God who is a consuming fire, must be to that extent less than fully good, and the more we emphasize his goodness the more we must file down his danger, until we arrive at the nice God, who is perfectly good precisely because he is perfectly safe, perfectly manageable, perfectly unthreatening. Lewis saw the error and named it and killed it in a sentence. Safe and good are not the same thing. They are not even close. And the confusion of them is the confusion at the heart of everything we have gotten wrong about God.

Because the truth is nearly the opposite of the assumption. The things that are most good are frequently the least safe, and their goodness and their danger are not in tension but are two aspects of the same greatness. The ocean is good and it is not safe. Fire is good and it is not safe. Love, real love, the kind that will change you, is the least safe thing in the world, and it is the best. A great teacher is not safe, because a great teacher will unsettle everything you thought you knew. A true friend is not safe, because a true friend will tell you what you do not want to hear. The safest people are the ones who do you the least good, the ones who affirm you and never challenge you and leave you exactly as you were. Safety and goodness pull in opposite directions more often than they run together, and the highest good of all, the living God, is for that very reason the least safe reality in the universe, and his danger is not a qualification of his goodness but an expression of it, because he is good enough to refuse to leave you as you are.

Lewis returns to this again and again through the Narnia books, and each time he presses the point deeper. Aslan is not tame. He is not predictable. He does the same thing twice, one character notes, only rarely, and you can never be sure what he will do next. He is on the move, and no one can put a leash on him.

When the children want to summon him or use him or fit him into their plans, they discover that he cannot be summoned or used or fitted into anyone's plans, that he comes when he comes and does what he does and answers to no one. He is, in Lewis's word, wild. And this wildness is not a flaw in Aslan that his goodness has to overcome. It is part of his goodness. A tame God, a domesticated God, a God who came when summoned and did what he was told and fit neatly into the plans of the people who worshiped him, would not be worth worshiping, because he would not be God. He would be a pet. He would be an instrument. He would be exactly the manageable deity the sentimental age has constructed, and his tameness would be the proof that he is false.

There is a scene near the end of the last Narnia book, and Lewis wrote it in 1956, where the characters find that Aslan has grown larger, and one of them remarks on it, and Aslan says that he has not grown, but that as she grows she will find him bigger. This is one of the most important sentences Lewis ever wrote about the spiritual life. As you grow, you find him bigger. The God of the mature Christian is not smaller than the God of the new convert, tamed and managed and reduced to comfortable proportions by years of familiarity. He is larger. Every year of real growth ought to reveal more of his immensity, more of his otherness, more of his terrible and beautiful wildness, until the God you knew at the beginning seems, by comparison, like a small sketch of the reality you are only now beginning to perceive. And this is exactly the reverse of what happens to most of us. Most of us find God getting smaller as we age in the faith, more familiar, more predictable, more tame, more nice. And Lewis is telling us that if that is happening, it is not maturity. It is atrophy. It is the slow domestication of God, and it is a sign not that we have grown but that we have stopped growing, because to grow is to

find him bigger, always bigger, world without end.

I have felt the pull toward the tame Aslan more strongly in ministry than I ever did as a new believer, and this is one of the cruel ironies of the pastoral vocation. When you handle holy things professionally, when the immensity of God is your daily subject matter, the standing temptation is to tame him, to reduce him to material, to make him predictable and manageable and useful for the sermon you have to preach on Sunday. I have caught myself treating God as a resource, a source of content, a deity I have figured out and can now explain to others. And every time I catch it, I hear the beaver. Course he isn't safe. And I realize that I have been handling a lion as though he were a housecat, and that the flatness of the sermon I am about to preach is the direct result of my having tamed, in my own heart, the God I am about to describe. You cannot preach a wild God from a tame heart. The people can tell. They can always tell. They come hoping to meet the Lion and they leave having met a very nice man's very reasonable ideas about a lion, and it is not the same thing, and it will never save anyone.

So I want to untame my God, and I want to untame yours, and the way we do it is not by trying to make God more frightening but by refusing to make him less than he is. Stop apologizing for the passages that unsettle you. Stop rushing to reassure everyone, the moment God does something terrible in the text, that he is really very nice underneath. Let the Lion be a lion. Let him be dangerous and good at once, wild and trustworthy at once, terrible and tender at once, and hold the two together without collapsing them, because the whole art of knowing God is the art of holding together the things the sentimental age has torn apart. He is not safe. And he is good. He is not tame. And he is the King. If you can learn to say both halves of that sentence with

equal conviction, and to feel them both at once, and to run toward the danger because you have learned that the danger and the goodness are the same thing, then you have learned more about God than a shelf full of comfortable theology could ever teach you. Aslan is on the move. He was never yours to leash. And the fact that you cannot control him is the best news you have ever heard, because a God you could control could never save you, and a God you cannot control is the only kind worth having.

Chapter Eight: The Severe Mercy

There is a kind of mercy that wounds, and the sentimental age does not believe in it, and this unbelief is one of the deepest reasons we have fled the holy God for the nice one. We have decided, without quite arguing for it, that mercy and pain are opposites, that a merciful God would never hurt us, that the presence of suffering in a life is evidence of the absence of divine kindness. And so when the wound comes, as it always comes, we conclude that God has abandoned us, or that he does not exist, or that he is not, after all, as loving as we were told. We never consider the possibility that the wound is itself the mercy, that the God who loves us is doing to us exactly what a surgeon does, which is to cut, on purpose, in love, for our healing. We do not consider it because the nice God would never cut. The nice God only soothes. And a God who only soothes cannot heal anything, because some things can only be healed by cutting.

The love that never wounds is the love that does not love enough to heal.

Sheldon Vanauken borrowed a phrase from a letter C.S. Lewis wrote him and made it the title of his 1977 memoir, *A Severe Mercy*, and the phrase has stayed in the language because it names something true that we have no other words for. Vanauken and his wife had built a love so complete, so total, so exclusive of everything else, that they called it their *Shining Barrier*, a wall around the two of them that would keep out everything that might diminish what they had. And then his wife died, young, and the *Shining Barrier*, the thing he had made the center of his

existence, was shattered by grief. And Lewis wrote to him and suggested something almost unbearable, that the death itself might have been a severe mercy, that the very love they had built into an idol, a love so total it had begun to crowd out God, had been broken by God precisely because God loved them too much to let them worship each other forever. The wound was the mercy. God had taken away the thing that had become a rival to himself, not out of cruelty, but because he wanted them, finally, wholly, and the only way to have them was to break the idol they had made of each other.

I want to be very careful here, because this is holy ground and it is easy to profane it, and the sentimental age is not wrong about everything. There are people who use the idea of severe mercy as a weapon, who stand at the bedsides of the grieving and announce that God had a reason, that the suffering was a gift, that the loss was a blessing in disguise, and they do damage, real damage, because they say true things at wrong times in cold voices, and they turn a mystery to be trembled at into a formula to be dispensed. I am not doing that. I am not telling you that every wound is a mercy in a way you will be able to see, or that you should be able to trace the loving purpose behind every loss, or that grief should be short because it all works out. The severe mercy is not a formula. It is a mystery, and it is a mystery that can only be spoken from inside your own suffering, never imposed from outside onto someone else's. What I am saying is narrower and harder. I am saying that the God who is not nice reserves the right to wound us in love, and that a God who did not reserve that right, a God who could only ever comfort and never cut, would be a God too weak to save.

Because think about what it would mean if God could never hurt you for your good. It would mean that whenever your good

required pain, God would be helpless, standing by, wringing his hands, unable to act because action might hurt. It would mean that God's love was subordinate to your comfort, that he would always choose your immediate ease over your ultimate healing, that he was, in the end, a God of anesthesia rather than a God of surgery. And a God like that could keep you comfortable, but he could never make you whole, because wholeness, for creatures as broken as we are, requires the setting of bones that have healed crooked, and the setting of a crooked bone requires that it first be broken again, and that is agony, and it is mercy, and it is the two things at once, and only a God strong enough to do the terrible thing is strong enough to do the good thing, because in a fallen world they are frequently the same thing.

The scriptures are unembarrassed about this in a way that startles us. The book of Hebrews, in its twelfth chapter, says plainly that the Lord disciplines the one he loves, and chastises every son whom he receives, and that if you are without discipline then you are not sons at all but illegitimate. Read the logic there, because it inverts everything the sentimental age assumes. The presence of divine discipline, of the wounding, corrective hand of God, is offered not as evidence of God's disfavor but as evidence of his fatherhood. The one God does not discipline is the one God has not claimed. The absence of the wound is the frightening thing, the sign that you are not being treated as a son. And the writer knows this is hard, and he does not pretend otherwise. All discipline for the moment seems painful rather than pleasant, he admits, but later it yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it. Later. Not now. Now it is simply pain, and the writer does not lie about that, does not tell you it will feel good, does not promise you will see the purpose in the moment. He tells you it will hurt now and heal later, which is exactly what a surgeon tells you, and exactly what the nice

God can never tell you, because the nice God has no scalpel.

I have felt the severe mercy of God in my own life, and I will tell you the shape of it without giving you the whole of it, because some wounds are too private even for a book that has promised to confess. There was a thing I wanted, a good thing, or a thing I was sure was good, and I had built my sense of myself around getting it, and God did not give it to me, and worse, God took it away in a manner that felt, at the time, like abandonment, like proof that the affirming deity of my prayers had been a fiction all along. And I was angry with God for a long season, angry the way you can only be angry with someone you believe has betrayed you. And it was years, genuine years, before I could see what I now believe to be true, which is that the thing I wanted had become a rival to God in my heart, that I had made it the source of my worth and my security, that I would have worshiped it if I had gotten it, and that God, in refusing me, was not withholding a good from me but rescuing me from an idol I could not see. It was a severe mercy. It felt like cruelty and it was love, and I could not tell the difference at the time, and I am not sure we are ever meant to be able to tell the difference at the time. That is what makes it faith.

Because this is the thing the severe mercy demands, and it is the thing the nice God relieves us of ever having to do. It demands trust in the dark. It demands that we hold on to the goodness of God precisely when his hand feels like cruelty, that we say, with Job, though he slay me, yet will I trust him, and mean it, in the actual moment of the slaying, when no purpose is visible and no comfort is felt and the only thing to go on is the character of a God we cannot at that moment see. The nice God never asks this of us, because the nice God never wounds, and so the nice God never gives us the chance to trust him in the dark, and so the

faith of a person who worships the nice God is a faith that has never been tested and never grown and never sunk its roots into anything deeper than good feelings. The severe mercy is the making of a real faith. It is the fire in which trust is forged, and it hurts the way fire hurts, and there is no way to have the forged trust without the fire.

So I will not tell you that God will not wound you, because that would be a lie, and it is the central lie of the sentimental age, and it shatters the moment real life touches it. I will tell you something harder and truer. God may wound you, and if he does, it will be a mercy, though you will not be able to see it as a mercy while the wound is fresh, and you should not try, and anyone who tells you to try does not understand what they are talking about. What you can do, in the dark, with the wound still open, is hold on to the character of the God who is not nice, the God who is good without being safe, the God whose severity and tenderness are the same fire. You can trust that the surgeon has not slipped, that the hand that cuts is the hand that loves, that the pain is not the absence of the mercy but the shape of it. And one day, maybe years from now, maybe not until the last day of all, you may look back and see the wound as the door through which the deepest healing came. Or you may not see it, not in this life, and you will have to trust anyway, and that trusting anyway, that holding on to the good Lion in the dark when he has just clawed you, is the highest and hardest and most saving thing a human being can do, and the nice God, who never wounds, will never give you the chance to do it.

Chapter Nine: Cheap Grace

Dietrich Bonhoeffer was twenty-nine years old when he wrote the sentences that have haunted the church ever since, and he wrote them not from a comfortable study but from inside a church that was in the process of selling its soul to Adolf Hitler. It was 1937. The German church, the respectable, historic, theologically sophisticated German church, was making its peace with the Third Reich, was flying the swastika in its sanctuaries, was quietly agreeing that the persecution of the Jews was a political matter outside its concern. And Bonhoeffer, watching this, understood that the church could only do such a thing if its grace had first been hollowed out, if the costly demand of the gospel had been replaced by something cheap, something that asked nothing, something that let you keep your comfortable life and your national loyalties and your averted eyes while still feeling forgiven. He wrote a book called *The Cost of Discipleship*, and he opened it with an assault on what he called cheap grace, and the assault has never stopped being relevant, because the disease he diagnosed is the disease of every comfortable church in every comfortable age, including mine, including, I am increasingly sure, me.

Cheap grace is the grace we preach to ourselves, and it has never saved a single soul, because it was never costly enough to be real.

Cheap grace, Bonhoeffer wrote, is the deadly enemy of our church. We are fighting today for costly grace. And then he defined it in words that ought to be carved over the door of every

sanctuary in the land. Cheap grace means grace sold on the market like a cheapjack's wares. The sacraments, the forgiveness of sin, and the consolations of religion are thrown away at cut prices. Cheap grace is the preaching of forgiveness without requiring repentance, baptism without church discipline, communion without confession. Cheap grace is grace without discipleship, grace without the cross, grace without Jesus Christ living and incarnate. And then the sentence that undoes me every time I read it. Cheap grace is the grace we bestow on ourselves. Not the grace God gives. The grace we manufacture and hand to ourselves, a self-issued pardon, a forgiveness that God never had to purchase because it cost us nothing to receive.

Now I want you to see, and this is the whole burden of this chapter, that cheap grace and the nice God are the same thing seen from two sides. They require each other. They cannot exist apart. Because think about what a grace has to assume in order to be cheap. It has to assume that there was never really much of a problem. It has to assume that God was never truly holy, that his justice was never actually going to fall, that the barrier between us and him was never all that high, and that forgiveness was therefore always going to be easy, a formality, a foregone conclusion. Cheap grace is grace from a God who was always going to let it slide, and a God who was always going to let it slide is the nice God, the God with no wrath, no holiness that had to be satisfied, no fire that had to be answered. The nice God can only ever offer cheap grace, because he has no costly grace to give. He never paid anything, because nothing was ever owed. His forgiveness is free the way a shrug is free, and it is worth exactly what it cost, which is nothing.

Costly grace, by contrast, requires the holy God, the God we have spent these chapters trying to recover. Costly grace is grace

that had to be purchased, and it could only have to be purchased if there was a real debt, and there could only be a real debt if God was really holy and our sin was really an affront to that holiness and his justice was really going to fall. Bonhoeffer says it perfectly. Costly grace is the treasure hidden in the field. It is the pearl of great price, to buy which the merchant will sell all his goods. Above all, it is costly because it cost God the life of his Son, and what has cost God much cannot be cheap for us. The cross is the price tag on grace. It is the proof that grace was never cheap, never automatic, never a foregone conclusion, but was purchased at a cost so staggering that the universe went dark while it was being paid. And a church that has forgotten the holiness of God has, in the same forgetting, lost the ability to see the cross as a purchase, and having lost that, has nothing left but cheap grace, forgiveness on the market at cut prices, the consolations of religion thrown away for nothing.

I have preached cheap grace. I need to confess it, because Bonhoeffer will not let me stand outside his indictment and point, and neither will the God I am trying to describe. I have stood in the pulpit and offered forgiveness in a way that required nothing, that assumed everyone in the room was basically fine, that never once suggested that sin is an offense against a holy God requiring the blood of his Son to answer. I have made grace easy because easy grace fills rooms and comfortable people give generously and no one leaves upset. I have preached the God who understands, the God who accepts, the God who meets you where you are and is content to leave you there, and I have called it the gospel, and it was not the gospel. It was cheap grace. It was the grace we bestow on ourselves, dressed up in biblical language, and it saved no one, because it never asked anyone to die, and the gospel always asks you to die. When Christ calls a man, Bonhoeffer wrote, he bids him come and die. That is the

sentence. That is the cost. And I have too often called men to come and be comfortable, which is a different call from a different god.

The tragedy of cheap grace is not merely that it is theologically thin. It is that it does not work, that it fails at the one thing it promises, which is to give people peace with God. Because a forgiveness that costs nothing convinces no one at the level where conviction matters. Deep down, in the place below our slogans, we know that our sin is real, that we have genuinely wronged and wounded and betrayed, that there is a weight of actual guilt that a cheap pardon cannot lift. And when the church offers cheap grace, it offers a forgiveness so light that the conscience cannot believe it, so free that it fails to reach the real debt, and the person walks away still carrying the weight, now compounded by the suspicion that the church's forgiveness is a pleasant fiction. Only costly grace can actually lift real guilt, because only costly grace takes the guilt seriously enough to have paid for it. The cross does not offer to overlook your sin. It offers to have borne it, absorbed it, answered it in full, and a forgiveness that has been purchased at infinite cost is a forgiveness the conscience can finally, gratefully believe, because it does not ask the conscience to pretend the debt was small. It declares the debt enormous and declares it paid.

So the recovery of the holy God is not the enemy of grace. It is the only thing that makes grace real. This is the great reversal that the sentimental age cannot see, the thing that seems like a paradox and is actually the deepest logic of the gospel. The nicer you make God, the cheaper you make grace, and the cheaper you make grace, the less it can do, until you are left with a warm feeling that cannot lift a single real burden. The holier you understand God to be, the more costly grace becomes, and the

more costly grace becomes, the more it can actually accomplish, until you arrive at a grace so expensive that it can bear the full weight of everything you have done and everything you are, a grace with a cross at the center of it, a grace that cost God his Son. That is the grace that saves. It is not nice. It is not cheap. It is the most expensive thing in the universe, and it is offered to you for free, and the freeness of it to you is possible only because it was not free to him. Do not accept the cheap kind. It will not hold. When the dark comes, and it will come, cheap grace evaporates, and only the costly kind, purchased in blood by a God who was never nice and always good, will still be standing.

Chapter Ten: The God of the Whirlwind

The book of Job is the oldest sustained meditation on suffering in the human record, and it ends in a way that offends almost everyone who reads it honestly, and the offense is the point, and the sentimental age cannot bear it. Here is a man who has lost everything, his children, his wealth, his health, his standing, everything but his wife and his own tormented breath. And he has spent thirty-some chapters demanding an answer from God, wanting to know why, wanting to plead his case, wanting God to explain himself, and his friends have spent those same chapters offering him the cheap theology of their age, which is that suffering is always punishment, that Job must have sinned, that if he would only repent it would all be restored. And Job knows they are wrong, and he holds his ground, and he calls out to the God he cannot see, and he demands a hearing. And then, at last, God answers. God speaks out of the whirlwind. And here is the thing that undoes every reader who was hoping for comfort. God does not answer the question.

Job asked God for an explanation and received God instead, and discovered that God was the answer the explanation could never have been.

He does not tell Job why. He never explains the suffering. He never mentions the wager with Satan in the first chapter, never lets Job in on the cosmic drama that occasioned his agony, never offers the reasons that we, the readers, have been given but that

Job never receives. Instead, God asks Job questions, question after question after question, seventy-some of them, and every one of them is designed to do a single thing, which is to overwhelm Job with the sheer immensity and otherness and unmanageable grandeur of God and the creation he governs. Where were you when I laid the foundations of the earth. Have you entered the storehouses of the snow. Can you bind the chains of the Pleiades. Do you give the horse his strength. Who provides for the raven its prey. On and on, a torrent of creation, the wild goats and the ostrich and the war horse and the great beasts Behemoth and Leviathan that no man can tame. And through all of it God is saying, in effect, one thing. You are not able to understand my government of the universe. You are a creature. I am the Creator. The gap between us is not a gap you can cross by argument.

Now this looks, at first, like a non-answer, even a cruel one. A man is suffering and God shows up and talks about ostriches. But sit with it longer, because Job's response is the key that unlocks the whole book, and Job's response is not resentment. Job's response is peace. I have heard of you by the hearing of the ear, Job says, but now my eye sees you. Therefore I despise myself and repent in dust and ashes. Something has happened to Job that is deeper than an answer. He asked for an explanation and he received a Person. He wanted God to justify himself at the bar of Job's understanding, and instead God simply showed up, in the whirlwind, in overwhelming reality, and Job discovered that the presence of God was worth infinitely more than any explanation of God could have been. The question dissolved, not because it was answered, but because it was swallowed up in something greater. Job did not get his why. Job got his God. And Job, having seen God, no longer needed the why, because the God he now saw was so vast and so real that

Job could trust him with the why, could leave the unanswered question in the hands of a God whose competence to govern the universe had just been made overwhelmingly plain.

This is the exact thing the nice God can never do, and it is the exact thing that suffering people most need. The nice God, the sympathetic deity, can only ever offer explanations or comfort, and in real catastrophe both of them fail. Explanations fail because no explanation is ever big enough, because when your child is in the ground there is no reason that would make it acceptable, and anyone who offers you a reason has not understood the size of what you have lost. And comfort fails, the merely sympathetic kind, because a God who can only feel bad alongside you is a God who is finally as helpless as you are, and helpless sympathy, however sincere, cannot hold the weight of real grief. What the sufferer needs is neither an explanation nor a companion in helplessness. What the sufferer needs is a God so vast, so sovereign, so competent, so utterly beyond the sufferer's comprehension, that the sufferer can rest the unbearable weight of the unanswered question on that God and trust him with it. And only the God of the whirlwind, the God who is not nice, the God whose ways are past finding out, can bear that weight, because only a God that big has shoulders wide enough to carry what you cannot.

I have sat with people in the worst hours, and I have learned, slowly and against my own instincts, that the God of the whirlwind is more comforting than the nice God, though it takes a while and a certain depth of suffering to see it. Early in my ministry I brought the nice God to hospital rooms. I brought the God who understands, the God who is so sorry, the God who feels your pain. And I watched that God fail, watched him prove too small, watched people reach for him in the dark and find

their hands closing on nothing. And over the years I have learned to bring a different God, the God who is Lord even here, even in this room, even over this disease and this loss and this incomprehensible wrong, the God whose sovereignty is so total that nothing has escaped his hand and nothing has surprised him and nothing is outside his government, including this, including this thing I cannot explain and will not try to. And I have watched, again and again, that this bigger God, this less comfortable God, this God who does not explain himself, is the one who actually holds people, because a God who is genuinely Lord of the catastrophe is a God you can lean the whole weight of your grief against, and he does not give way.

There is a real cost to this, and I will not hide it, because the God of the whirlwind demands something the nice God never demands, which is the surrender of our right to an explanation. This is hard. It goes against everything in us. We believe we are owed reasons. We believe that a good God would explain himself, that we have a right to understand, that faith should come with an account of why. And the book of Job stands as a permanent refusal of that demand. God does not explain himself to Job, and God is not thereby shown to be cruel, and this tells us something we do not want to hear, which is that the God who is not nice reserves the right to remain unexplained, to govern a universe we cannot comprehend, to work in ways that are genuinely past our finding out, and to ask us to trust him anyway, without the reasons, in the dark, on the strength of his character alone. This is offensive to the modern mind, which believes it is owed transparency by everyone including God. But it is also, when you finally submit to it, the deepest rest there is, because it means you do not have to understand in order to trust, and since you were never going to understand anyway, the only alternative to trusting the unexplained God is despair.

And here is the final turn, the thing that keeps the God of the whirlwind from being merely a display of raw power crushing a small man into silence. Because a cynic could read the ending of Job as exactly that, God overwhelming Job with sheer size, bullying him into submission, winning by intimidation. But that reading misses the tenderness hidden inside the terror, and the tenderness is this. God came. That is the thing we skip over. God, the God who owed Job nothing, the God who could have remained silent forever, the God whose ways are genuinely beyond Job's comprehension, chose to come, to speak, to show himself, to answer Job's demand not with the answer Job asked for but with the greater gift of his own presence. The whirlwind is terrifying, but the whirlwind is also God bending down, God taking the suffering of one man seriously enough to speak to him personally out of the storm. Job wanted an audience with God, and Job got one, and no other sufferer in the ancient world could say as much. The God of the whirlwind is not nice, but he is not indifferent either. He came. He spoke. And in the coming and the speaking, without a single explanation, he gave Job the only thing that could actually heal him, which was not an answer but himself. And a God who will give you himself in the whirlwind is a God worth trusting even when he will not tell you why.

Chapter Eleven: A Consuming Fire

The nineteenth chapter of Exodus describes the day God came down on Mount Sinai, and if you have only ever encountered God in the sanctuaries of the sentimental age, the description will read like an account of a different deity entirely, a God you were never introduced to, a God the nice churches have quietly stopped mentioning. On the morning of the third day there were thunders and lightnings and a thick cloud on the mountain, and a very loud trumpet blast, so that all the people in the camp trembled. And Moses brought the people out of the camp to meet God, and they took their stand at the foot of the mountain. Now Mount Sinai was wrapped in smoke because the Lord had descended on it in fire. The smoke of it went up like the smoke of a kiln, and the whole mountain trembled greatly. And as the sound of the trumpet grew louder and louder, Moses spoke, and God answered him in thunder. This is not a metaphor the ancients used to describe a warm inner feeling. This is a mountain on fire, a mountain that no one may touch on pain of death, a God so present and so holy that the very ground has become lethal.

The same fire that consumes the stubble warms the hearth. It is not two fires. It is the nearness or distance of the one holy God.

Read the boundaries God sets around that mountain and feel how alien they are to our casual approach. God tells Moses to set limits around the mountain and to warn the people not to touch it, not even the edge of it, and that whoever touches the mountain

shall surely be put to death, and that no hand shall touch him but he shall be stoned or shot, whether beast or man. Even an animal that wanders onto the holy mountain must die. The holiness of God at Sinai is not a mood. It is a consuming energy so intense that mere proximity, mere contact, is fatal to anything unholy that draws near. And this is not because God is cruel or trigger-tempered. It is because holiness and unholiness cannot occupy the same space, the way fire and dry grass cannot occupy the same space, the way the sun and a snowflake cannot occupy the same space. The death is not a punishment arbitrarily imposed. It is a physics, a spiritual physics, the necessary consequence of the finite and defiled drawing too near to the infinite and holy without a mediator, without a covering, without the blood that has not yet been shed.

The writer of Hebrews, centuries later, looking back on Sinai from the far side of the cross, does not soften it. He describes the mountain that could be touched and that burned with fire, and the darkness and gloom and tempest and the sound of the trumpet, and he says that the sight was so terrifying that Moses himself said, I tremble with fear. Moses. The friend of God, the one who spoke with God face to face, trembles. And then the writer of Hebrews, having reminded his readers of all that terror, does something we do not expect. He does not tell them that the New Covenant has made God less holy, that the consuming fire has cooled, that we may now approach casually because Jesus has made God nice. He tells them the opposite. See that you do not refuse him who is speaking, he warns, for if they did not escape when they refused him who warned them on earth, much less will we escape if we reject him who warns from heaven. And then the line that ends the chapter, the line that ought to end forever our domestication of God. Therefore let us be grateful, and thus let us offer to God acceptable worship, with reverence

and awe, for our God is a consuming fire.

Our God is a consuming fire. Present tense. Not was. Is. This is written to Christians, on the far side of the cross, under the New Covenant, to people who have every reason to know the love and the mercy and the nearness of God in Christ, and the writer's conclusion is not that God has stopped being a consuming fire but that precisely because God is still a consuming fire, we must worship with reverence and awe. The cross did not extinguish the fire. The cross gave us a way to draw near to the fire without being consumed, which is a different thing entirely. The nice God has no fire, and so approaching him requires no reverence, no awe, no mediator, no covering, because there is nothing there to fear. But the true God, the God of Sinai who is also the God of Calvary, is still a consuming fire, and the whole miracle of the gospel is not that the fire went out but that a way was made for us to stand in the fire and live, clothed in a righteousness not our own, sheltered under a blood that answers the fire's demand.

Here is what I think we have lost, and it is subtle, so let me say it carefully. We have come to believe that the love of God and the fire of God are opposites, that as we grow in our experience of God's love we should experience less of his fire, that the mature Christian is one for whom God has become gentle and warm and unthreatening. But Sinai and Calvary together tell us something different. They tell us that the love of God and the fire of God are the same thing, that the fire is what the love feels like to everything that opposes it, and that the fire is what the love feels like to us too, only now the fire warms instead of destroys, because we have been brought inside it through the cross. The same fire that consumes the stubble warms the hearth. The same sun that withers also ripens. It is not two different fires, one for judgment and one for love. It is the one holy fire of the one holy

God, and whether it consumes you or warms you depends entirely on whether you are standing in it exposed or standing in it covered, outside the mediator or inside him.

This means that the goal of the Christian life is not to get God to cool down. It is to be brought, in Christ, into the very center of the fire, and to be able to stand there, and even to delight in it, because the fire that would once have destroyed us has become, through the cross, the fire in which we live. The saints in glory are not the people God stopped being a consuming fire toward. They are the people who dwell in the consuming fire and are not consumed, who have become, by grace, the kind of beings who can bear the presence of the holy God and rejoice in it. That is what heaven is. It is not the fire going out. It is us becoming able to live in it. And every experience of God's fire in this life, every time his holiness burns against our sin, every time his presence exposes what we would rather hide, every painful purification, is God preparing us for that, making us into creatures who can dwell in the fire, burning away everything in us that could not survive his presence, so that on the last day we can stand in the full blaze of his holiness and not be destroyed but glorified.

I confess that I have preferred a cooler God, and this is the confession this chapter demands of me. I have wanted a God whose fire I could approach at a comfortable distance, whose holiness I could admire from across the room without ever having to stand in the blaze. I have wanted, if I am honest, the warmth without the burning, the light without the heat, a God whose consuming fire had been turned down to a pleasant glow that would never actually consume anything, least of all the parts of me I have no wish to lose. And every time I have preferred that cooler God, I have preferred a God who could not sanctify me, because sanctification is exactly the burning away of what

cannot survive his presence, and a fire turned down low enough to be comfortable is a fire too weak to purify. The consuming fire is not the enemy of my salvation. It is the instrument of it. And the reverence and awe that Hebrews commands are not the leftover fear of an immature faith but the permanent and appropriate posture of a creature who has been brought, by unspeakable grace, to dwell in the presence of a holy fire that has not gone out and never will. Our God is a consuming fire. Take off your shoes. Do not refuse him who is speaking. And worship, with reverence and awe, the God who is warm enough to save you precisely because he was never cool enough to be safe.

Chapter Twelve: The Holiness That Became the Cross

Everything I have written so far has been building toward this chapter, and I have been afraid of it the whole way, because the cross is the place where all the terrible things I have said about God and all the tender things I have said about God meet in a single event, and no writer is adequate to it, and I am less adequate than most. But we have to come here, because the cross is the answer to the crisis every previous chapter has created. If God is truly holy, if his wrath against evil is real, if his jealousy will not share our hearts, if he is a consuming fire, if he wounds in mercy and will not be tamed, then the question that has been building under every page is the question the whole Bible is asking. How can such a God have anything to do with such creatures as us. How can the consuming fire not consume us. How can the holy God dwell with an unholy people without either compromising his holiness or destroying the people. That is the problem the cross exists to solve, and it is a real problem, and the nice God does not have it, and that is exactly why the nice God has no cross.

At the cross the weight of God fell, and it did not fall on us. That is the whole of the gospel, and it is heavier than we have let ourselves feel.

Because notice what the cross assumes. The cross assumes that there was a barrier so severe that only the death of the Son of God could remove it. Strip away every comfortable evasion and

look at the raw fact of it. God did not simply announce forgiveness from heaven. He could not, or he would not, and the difference between could not and would not takes us into the depths of who God is. A merely nice God could have simply declared us forgiven, waved his hand, let it slide, because for a nice God there was never anything to answer. But the holy God could not do that, not because he lacks power, but because he cannot deny himself, cannot pretend that evil does not matter, cannot treat the murder and the betrayal and the cruelty of the world as though they were nothing, cannot be indifferent to the destruction of what he loves. His holiness will not permit him to wink at sin. And so forgiveness, for the holy God, could not be a simple waiving of the debt. The debt had to be paid. The wrath had to be borne. The fire had to fall. And the staggering, universe-cracking claim of the Christian faith is that God, rather than pour that fire out on us, took it into himself.

This is the thing the sentimental age cannot see, because it has lost the categories that make the cross legible. If you do not believe God is holy, the cross is a mystery at best and an obscenity at worst, God torturing his own Son for no reason, cosmic child abuse, a barbaric ritual we have outgrown. That charge has been made, and it has force, but only if you have first removed the holiness of God, because the moment you restore the holiness the charge collapses. The cross is not the Father venting his rage on an innocent third party. The cross is God, in the person of the Son, stepping into the place of the guilty and bearing, in his own body, the just consequence of our evil, so that we would not have to bear it. The Judge did not condemn a bystander. The Judge came down from the bench, took off his robe, and stood in the dock in our place, and received in himself the sentence that our sin had earned. That is not injustice. That is love at a cost we cannot fathom, and it is only visible, only

intelligible, only glorious, if you have first understood that the sentence was real, that the wrath was real, that the holiness demanded an answer and the answer was the blood of God.

Consider the cry of dereliction, the darkest sentence in the Gospels, the moment when Jesus, hanging on the cross, cries out, My God, my God, why have you forsaken me. We rush past it because it frightens us, because we do not know what to do with a Son of God who feels forsaken. But that cry is the sound of the fire falling. It is the sound of the Son bearing, in that moment, the full weight of what it means for the holy God to turn his face away from sin, the sin that was not his own but that he had taken upon himself, our sin, my sin, laid on him until he became, in Paul's almost unbearable phrase, sin for us, he who knew no sin. The eternal communion of the Father and the Son, the communion that had existed in perfect love from before the foundation of the world, was ruptured, and the Son experienced the God-forsakenness that our evil deserved, so that we would never have to experience it. That is the weight of God, falling. That is the consuming fire, consuming. And it fell on him, and it did not fall on us, and that exchange is the hinge on which the whole gospel turns.

Now here is the thing I most want you to feel, because it is the thing that turns all the terror of the holy God into the deepest comfort available to human beings. The severity and the tenderness of God are not two different things that somehow coexist. At the cross they are revealed to be the same thing. The very holiness that made our forgiveness so costly is the holiness that paid the cost. The very wrath that had to be answered is the wrath that God chose to absorb into himself rather than pour out on us. The very fire that would have consumed us is the fire that consumed the Son in our place. You cannot separate the terrible

God from the tender God at the cross, because at the cross the terrible God is doing the most tender thing that has ever been done, and he is doing it precisely by being terrible, by taking his own terror upon himself, by letting the full severity of his holiness fall on his own heart so that it would not fall on ours. The cross is the severity and the mercy revealed as one fire. And a God who was merely nice, a God with no severity, could never have loved us this much, because he would have had nothing this costly to give.

This is why the cross empties of meaning the moment you remove the holy God, and it is why the recovery of the holy God is not a threat to the gospel but its foundation. Make God nice, and the cross becomes an overreaction, a pointless tragedy, a bewildering excess of suffering to solve a problem that a truly nice God would have solved with a shrug. But restore the holiness, restore the wrath, restore the consuming fire, and the cross becomes the most beautiful thing in the universe, because now you can see what it cost, and you can see who paid it, and you can see that the God who paid it was under no obligation to pay it, that he could have justly let us bear our own fire, and that he chose instead to bear it himself. The more holy you understand God to be, the more astonishing the cross becomes, until it stops you cold, until it undoes you the way Isaiah was undone, until you fall down before a love so severe and so tender that it went to the grave to have you. The nice God's love is cheap because it cost him nothing. The holy God's love is beyond price because it cost him everything, and the everything is measured by exactly how holy he is, by exactly how great the barrier was, by exactly how much fire had to fall.

I have to say something here about my own preference for the nice God, because this chapter exposes that preference for what

it really is. When I reach for the nice God, when I want a God who is easy and warm and undemanding, I am, whether I admit it or not, reaching for a God who did not have to die for me. I am preferring a God whose forgiveness is cheap because I would rather not reckon with a forgiveness that cost him his Son. And do you see what a small and ungrateful preference that is. I am, in effect, trading away the cross for my own comfort, choosing a god who never had to bleed over a God who bled everything, because the bleeding God makes a claim on me that the nice god does not. The cross is a claim. It says, you were bought with a price, therefore you are not your own. The nice god makes no such claim, because he paid no such price, and that is exactly why I prefer him, and that is exactly the shame of my preference. Every time I choose the manageable god, I am walking past the cross, and I am walking past it because the cross is too heavy, and I would rather have a god light enough to fit in my afternoon than a God heavy enough to have died for me.

So I come back to the cross, again and again, because it is the only place where I can hold together the two things I keep tearing apart. It is the place where the holiness that terrifies me and the love that saves me are revealed to be one thing. It is the place where the consuming fire consumed itself for my sake. It is the place where the God who is not nice proved that he is infinitely more than nice, that his love is not the thin warmth of a sentiment but the roaring blaze of a holiness that would rather die than lose me. When I want to know whether God loves me, I do not look inward to my feelings, which shift like weather. I do not look to my circumstances, which lie. I look to the cross, to the weight of God falling on the Son so that it would not fall on me, and I know, with a certainty that no nice god could ever provide, that I am loved, because I can see exactly what my being loved cost him, and it cost him everything, and he paid it

gladly, and he would pay it again. That is not niceness. That is the holiness that became the cross. And it is the only love in the universe strong enough to save.

Chapter Thirteen: Why the Nice God Cannot Comfort

I have circled this claim throughout the book, and now I want to land on it fully, because it is the most practical thing I have to say and the thing that will matter most to you on the day you need it, which is coming, for all of us. The nice God cannot comfort you. Not really. Not when it counts. He can comfort you on the good days, when comfort is a luxury and not a necessity, when you are mildly discouraged and want to be told that everything will be fine. But on the day the floor gives way, on the day the diagnosis comes, on the day the phone rings at three in the morning, on the day you stand at the grave, the nice God has nothing to give you, and you will reach for him, and your hands will close on air. I have watched this happen. I have watched it happen to people I love, and I have felt it happen in my own soul, and I am telling you the truth that the sentimental age does not want told. A comfortable God is a fair-weather God, and the weather is going to turn.

The only God who can hold you when everything gives way is the God heavy enough that nothing can move him. Weight is not the enemy of comfort. Weight is the whole of it.

Think about what comfort actually requires, because we have grown sloppy about this. We tend to think comfort is a matter of warmth, of sympathy, of a kind presence that feels with us in our pain. And there is a place for that. When a friend sits with you in

grief and says nothing and simply weeps alongside you, that is a real gift, and I would not diminish it. But notice its limits. Your grieving friend cannot fix anything. Your grieving friend is as helpless before death as you are. Their sympathy is precious precisely because it is offered from within the same helplessness you feel, a fellow sufferer holding your hand in the dark. And that is enough when what you need is company. But it is not enough when what you need is rescue, and in the deepest sufferings what you need is rescue, and a God who can only offer sympathy is a God who has joined you in the pit without the power to lift you out of it. The nice God is a sympathetic God, and sympathy is the ceiling of what he can offer, and sympathy alone, however warm, cannot raise the dead.

Real comfort, the kind that holds when everything gives way, requires not sympathy but sovereignty. It requires a God who is not merely feeling bad alongside you but who is Lord over the very thing that is destroying you, a God whose hand is not tied, a God for whom your catastrophe is not the final word because he holds a power greater than the catastrophe. When you stand at the grave, you do not ultimately need a God who is sad about death. You need a God who is Lord over death, a God who has authority over the grave, a God who can and will raise the dead, a God whose sovereignty extends into the tomb and out the other side. That God can comfort you, because that God can promise you something, and mean it, and back it with power. The sad, sympathetic, nice God can promise you nothing, because he controls nothing, and a promise from a God who controls nothing is just a nice sentiment offered into the void. Comfort is not the presence of warmth. Comfort is the presence of a power greater than the thing you fear, and only the sovereign God, the God who is not nice, the God of terrible and total authority, possesses that power.

This is why the passages of Scripture that have actually comforted the dying and the bereaved across the centuries are not the sentimental ones but the weighty ones. When people are truly suffering, they do not reach for the verses about God being gentle and kind, though those verses are true. They reach for the twenty-third Psalm, and notice what actually comforts in it, because it is not what we assume. Yea, though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for thou art with me, thy rod and thy staff, they comfort me. The rod and the staff. Those are not soft images. The rod is a weapon, a club for beating off predators. The staff is an instrument of authority and control. What comforts the sufferer in the dark valley is not that God is soft but that God is armed, that God is powerful, that God carries the rod that drives off the wolves and the staff that governs the flock. The comfort is in the weapon. The comfort is in the strength. The comfort is in the sovereignty of a Shepherd who is Lord even of the valley of the shadow of death and walks through it not as a fellow victim but as a King who fears nothing there.

I learned this at a bedside I will never forget, and I will keep the details vague to protect the family, but I have to tell you enough for it to land. A woman was dying, a believer, and she was afraid, and the young version of me wanted to tell her that God was with her and that he loved her and that he was so sorry she was suffering, all of which was true and none of which touched her fear. And an older pastor was there, a man who had buried more people than I had married, and he did not offer her the nice God. He took her hand and he told her, in a voice with iron in it, that the God who was about to receive her was the Lord of heaven and earth, that death had no authority he had not already broken, that the grave she feared was a defeated enemy, that the same power that raised Jesus from the dead would raise her, and

that she was passing not into the dark but into the hands of a King before whom death itself trembled. And I watched the fear leave her face. Not because he had been gentle, though there was tenderness under the iron, but because he had been weighty, because he had preached to her a God big enough to be trusted with her death. The nice God could not have done that. The nice God has no authority over the grave, and so the nice God cannot say a single word that a dying person can lean their whole weight against.

There is a paradox here that the sentimental age has completely inverted, and it is this. The God who is frightening in prosperity is the God who is comforting in catastrophe, and the God who is comforting in prosperity is the God who is useless in catastrophe. On the good days, the weight of God can feel like too much, and the nice God feels like a relief, feels gentler, feels more livable. But the good days are not when you find out what your God is made of. The bad days are. And on the bad days the equation flips entirely. The nice God, so comfortable in the sunshine, evaporates in the storm, and the weighty God, so intimidating in the calm, becomes the only rock large enough to stand on when the flood comes. The very heaviness that made him hard to live with in the good times is the heaviness that makes him unmovable in the bad times, and you discover, too late if you have not prepared, that you needed the heavy God all along, that the comfortable god you preferred was a fair-weather friend who was always going to leave you the moment you actually needed him.

So I plead with you, and I plead with myself, to do the hard work now, before the storm, of recovering the weighty God, because you cannot manufacture him in the crisis. You cannot, on the worst day of your life, suddenly conjure a robust theology of the

sovereignty of God to lean on if you have spent the good years worshipping a sentimental substitute. The God you will reach for in the dark is the God you have been building in the light, and if you have been building the nice God, he will not be there when the dark comes. Build the other one now. Learn the weighty God now, the God of the whirlwind and the consuming fire and the rod and the staff, the God who is Lord even of the valley of the shadow, so that when you walk into that valley, and you will, you will find that you already know the Shepherd who walks through it fearing nothing, and you will be able to fear no evil, not because the evil is not real, but because the God who is with you is realer, and heavier, and stronger than everything you fear. That is comfort. It is the only comfort that holds. And it is available only from the God who is not nice.

Chapter Fourteen: The Beauty of Holiness

I have spent so many chapters on the terror of God that I am afraid I have left you with the impression that holiness is grim, that the recovery of the weighty God is the recovery of a heavy, dour, joyless deity who frowns from a great height and demands that we tremble. And if that is where you have landed, then I have failed, and I have to correct it now, because it is precisely the correction that turns this whole book from a lecture into good news. The holiness of God is not grim. The holiness of God is beautiful. It is the most beautiful thing there is. The Psalms do not merely tell us to fear God's holiness. They tell us to worship the Lord in the beauty of holiness, to behold the beauty of the Lord, and the word beauty is not a decoration on the terror but a description of it, because the terror and the beauty are, once again, the same fire, and I have been describing only half of Otto's *mysterium, the tremendum*, and I have neglected the *fascinans*, and it is time to make it right.

*Holiness is not the absence of beauty made severe.
Holiness is beauty at a magnitude that terrifies.*

Remember Otto's full phrase, because we have only been living in the first half of it. The holy is *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*. *Tremendum*, yes, the mystery that makes you tremble. But also *fascinans*, the mystery that fascinates, that draws you in, that attracts with an irresistible magnetism even as it overwhelms. Otto's whole point was that these two are

inseparable, that the same encounter that terrifies you also allures you, that you cannot look and you cannot look away, that the holy repels and attracts in the same instant. And we in the sentimental age have made a strange mistake. We have kept the fascinans and thrown away the tremendum, we have kept the attraction and lost the awe, and the result is not a God who is beautiful but a God who is merely pleasant, because beauty without awe is not beauty at all, it is prettiness, it is the greeting card instead of the sunrise, and a God who is merely pretty cannot draw the soul the way a God who is genuinely, terrifyingly beautiful can.

Because here is the thing about real beauty, the deep kind, the kind that stops you in your tracks and makes your breath catch. It always has a quality of terror in it. Stand at the edge of the Grand Canyon and feel it. Stand under a sky full of stars in a truly dark place and feel it. Listen to the greatest music, the kind that seems to open a door onto something vast, and feel it. In every case the beauty is not comfortable. It is overwhelming. It makes you feel small. It has an edge of fear in it, a vertigo, a sense of standing before something too large for you, and the fear is not the opposite of the beauty but part of it, is in fact what makes it beauty rather than mere prettiness. The most beautiful things are the ones that frighten us a little, because true beauty is a kind of glory, and glory is weight, and weight, when it is great enough, always carries awe. The beauty of God is not the beauty of a pleasant painting you can admire from your chair. It is the beauty of the sea in a storm, of the mountain wrapped in fire, of the throne room where the seraphim veil their faces. It is a beauty that includes the tremendum, and it is beautiful precisely because it does.

This is why the recovery of the holy God is not the loss of joy

but its restoration, and I want you to feel the reversal here, because the sentimental age has it exactly backward. We fled the weighty God for the nice one thinking we were choosing joy over grimness, warmth over terror, and we have ended up with neither joy nor terror but only a mild and forgettable pleasantness, a God who does not frighten us and therefore does not thrill us either, because the capacity to be thrilled and the capacity to be awed are the same capacity, and when you numb the one you numb the other. The people who have known the deepest joy in God are not the people who found him comfortable. They are the people who found him overwhelming, who trembled before his holiness and then discovered that the holiness was beautiful, that the fire that terrified them was the most glorious thing they had ever beheld, and that to be drawn into it was the highest joy the soul can know. Jonathan Edwards, preaching in the seventeen forties, described the beauty of God's holiness as the very center of what makes God worthy of worship, and Edwards was not a grim man on this point but a man overcome, a man for whom the holiness of God was a beauty so ravishing that he could barely contain it. He had recovered the fascinans by refusing to lose the tremendum.

Consider what we mean when we say that something is holy in the way that a great cathedral is holy, or a moment of true worship is holy, or the birth of a child is holy. We do not mean that it is grim. We mean that it is set apart, weighty, charged with a significance that lifts it out of the ordinary and fills it with a beauty that demands reverence. The holy is the ordinary suffused with glory. And when we call God holy, in the fullest sense, we mean that he is the source and summit of all that beauty, the reality of which every holy moment on earth is only a faint reflection, the glory of which the sunrise and the storm and the starry sky are only the outer fringes. The beauty of holiness is

not a grim beauty. It is the beauty that all other beauties are trying to be. And to have recovered it, to have seen even a glimpse of it, is to be ruined for the pretty little god of the sentimental age forever, because once you have seen the real glory you cannot go back to the greeting card, and you would not want to, because the greeting card, which once seemed comforting, now seems unbearably thin.

I have to confess that I spent years unable to see this, and the inability was not intellectual but spiritual, a blindness of the heart. I could affirm on paper that God's holiness was beautiful, but I did not feel it as beautiful, I felt it as a threat, and I suspect the reason is that beauty of that magnitude requires something of us, requires that we be drawn out of ourselves and lose ourselves in adoration, and there is a part of me, the part that prefers the nice God, that does not want to be drawn out of itself, that wants to stay in the center of its own small world and keep God at a safe and admirable distance. To behold the beauty of holiness is to be undone by it, to be drawn into a worship that decenters the self entirely, and the sentimental self, the buffered self, resists that with everything it has, because it senses, correctly, that the beauty of God is a beauty that will not leave the self on its throne. So it settles for the pretty god, the manageable glory, the beauty it can admire without being consumed by. And it calls this reverence. But it is not reverence. It is the refusal of a beauty too great to be safely admired, the flinching of a soul that wants to keep itself and therefore will not look fully at the glory that would take it.

The great discovery, when it finally comes, and I pray it comes for you, is that the beauty which terrifies is the beauty which satisfies, that the glory too great to be safely admired is the only glory that can actually fill the God-shaped void, that we were

made not for the pretty god but for the terrible and beautiful One, and that nothing less than the full weight of his glory will ever be enough for a soul that was built to worship. C.S. Lewis wrote in 1941, in a sermon called *The Weight of Glory*, that we are far too easily pleased, that we are like a child who wants to go on making mud pies in a slum because he cannot imagine what is meant by the offer of a holiday at the sea. That is exactly it. The nice God is a mud pie. He is a small, safe, manageable pleasure that keeps us content in the slum of our own diminished expectations. And the holy God, the terrible and beautiful One, is the sea, the vast and overwhelming glory we were actually made for, and the reason we settle for the mud pies is not that the sea is too grim but that it is too glorious, too large, too demanding of our whole selves. Recover the tremendum, and you recover the fascinans with it. Recover the fear, and you recover the beauty. Recover the weight, and you recover, at last, the joy, the deep and terrible and satisfying joy of a creature beholding, without flinching, the beauty of the holiness of God.

Chapter Fifteen: Worship as the Only Sane Response

If everything I have written is true, then a single practical consequence follows, and it is the most important consequence in this book, and it is this. Worship is not one activity among many that religious people happen to enjoy. Worship is the only sane response of a creature that has correctly perceived its Creator. It is not optional. It is not a matter of temperament, something suited to the emotional and dispensable for the cerebral. It is simply what happens, what must happen, what cannot help but happen, when a finite being genuinely sees the infinite God. Everything else is a symptom of not having seen. The person who can encounter the holy God and remain unmoved, who can behold the weight and the beauty and the terror and the mercy of the living God and respond with a polite nod, has not encountered God at all. They have encountered an idea, a doctrine, a manageable concept. Worship is the proof that the encounter was real.

You do not decide to worship the way you decide to take up a hobby. You worship the way a struck bell rings. It is not a choice. It is a consequence.

I want to distinguish worship from what usually passes for it, because the sentimental age has counterfeited this too, has produced a thing it calls worship that is really something much smaller and safer. What passes for worship in many places is a pleasant emotional experience, a warm feeling generated by

music and atmosphere and the company of others, a mood that lifts us and comforts us and sends us out feeling better than we came. And there is nothing wrong with feeling better, and music is a gift, and emotion is not the enemy. But that is not worship, or it is only worship by accident, because the center of that experience is us, our feelings, our uplift, our mood, and worship by definition is the decentering of the self, the turning of the whole soul away from itself and toward God, the loss of the self in the contemplation of a glory infinitely greater than the self. Worship that leaves you at the center is not worship. It is religious entertainment. It is the nice God's substitute for the real thing, and it can be very moving, and it can feel very spiritual, and it changes no one, because it never once required anyone to look away from themselves toward the terrible and beautiful holiness of God.

Real worship begins where the self ends, and this is why it requires the weighty God and cannot be produced by the nice one. You cannot lose yourself in the contemplation of something you can manage. You cannot be decentered by a God who exists to affirm you. You cannot fall down before a deity who is basically your peer. Worship requires an object so far above you that beholding it draws you out of yourself entirely, that makes you forget yourself, that swallows your self-consciousness in the sheer overwhelming reality of the One you are beholding. This is why the great moments of worship in Scripture are always moments of self-forgetfulness born of awe. Isaiah does not worship until he sees the throne and comes apart. The elders in Revelation do not admire God from their thrones, they fall down and cast their crowns before him, they surrender the very symbols of their own glory because in the presence of his glory their own has become nothing. Worship is the casting down of crowns. It is the glad surrender of the self before a weight so

great that holding on to yourself becomes unthinkable, even absurd. And the nice God has no such weight, and so before the nice God no crowns are ever cast down, and no self is ever lost, and no worship, in the true sense, ever occurs.

This is why our worship has grown so thin, and I say this as a man who leads worship, who stands at the front of a room every Sunday and tries to help people do the thing this chapter describes, and who fails at it more often than I succeed. Our worship is thin because our God is thin. You cannot get thick worship from a thin God. If the God we present is a comfortable, affirming, manageable deity, then the best we can hope to produce is a comfortable, affirming, manageable feeling, and no amount of skilled musicianship or emotional atmosphere can turn that feeling into worship, because the raw material is wrong. The problem is upstream of the music. The problem is the God. Restore the weighty God, the God of the throne room and the whirlwind and the consuming fire, and worship becomes possible again, not because we have changed our technique but because we have changed our object, and worship follows its object the way a shadow follows the sun. A great God produces great worship. A small god produces a small feeling. It has always been this way, and it will always be this way, and every attempt to generate real worship while preaching a diminished God is doomed before it begins.

There is a self-implication here that I cannot avoid, because I have been complicit in the thinning. I have chosen songs because they moved people rather than because they told the truth about God. I have shaped services to produce an emotional arc, a build and a release, a feeling of uplift, and I have measured the success of a service by how people felt as they left, and this is exactly backward, this is worship centered on the worshiper, this is the

nice God's counterfeit dressed in the clothes of reverence. The measure of true worship is not how the people feel. It is whether God was seen, whether the weight of him fell on the room, whether crowns were cast down, whether anyone left the room more aware of the greatness of God and less aware of themselves. And by that measure I have led many services that were successful entertainments and failed acts of worship, and I have done it because the entertainment fills the room and the worship empties the self, and there is a cowardice in me, the same cowardice this whole book keeps confessing, that would rather fill the room than empty the self, mine included.

Because worship costs the worshiper something, and this is the last thing the sentimental age wants to hear about it. We have been taught to think of worship as something we receive, a source of comfort and uplift, a spiritual resource we draw on for our benefit. But real worship is not something you receive. It is something you give. It is the offering of the self, the casting down of the crown, the surrender of your own centrality, and that surrender is a death, a small daily death, the death of the self as the center of its own universe. Worship is costly the way everything real about God is costly, and the reason we prefer the counterfeit is the same reason we prefer the nice God, because the counterfeit lets us keep ourselves. The real thing asks us to lose ourselves, and losing yourself, even in something infinitely glorious, is a kind of dying, and there is a part of every one of us that would rather have the comfortable feeling than die. But the strange promise at the heart of the gospel is that the self we lose in worship is the self we most truly find, that in casting down our crowns we are given a glory we could never have kept by clutching, that the death of the self at the center is the birth of the self in communion, and that the sanest thing a human being can ever do is the very thing the sentimental self most resists, which

is to fall down before the holy God and lose itself, gladly, in the beauty and terror of his glory.

So I am learning, slowly, to measure worship differently, and to lead it differently, and to want from it the thing it is actually for. Not the comfortable feeling. Not the uplift I can carry out the door. But the sight of God, the weight of God, the loss of myself in the contemplation of a glory that undoes me and remakes me in the same motion. I want to cast down my crown, and I have discovered how hard it is, how the hand closes reflexively around it, how the self resists being decentered even before the glory it was made for. But I have also discovered, in the rare moments when it happens, when the weight actually falls and the self actually forgets itself and the room actually fills with the sense of God, that this is the thing I was made for, that this self-forgetful adoration is not a loss but the deepest gain, that a creature beholding its Creator in worship is a creature doing, at last, the one thing it was created to do. Worship is the only sane response to the weight of God. Everything else is a symptom of blindness. And the recovery of the holy God is, finally, the recovery of the possibility of worship, which is the recovery of the possibility of joy, which is the recovery of the possibility of being, at last, fully and truly human before the God who made us for himself.

Chapter Sixteen: The God Who Will Not Be Used

There is a form of the sentimental God that is more dangerous than all the others, because it wears the clothing of faith and even of fervor, and it is the God we have reduced to a means to our ends. This is not the God of the lukewarm or the indifferent. This is the God of the very religious, the God of the person who prays hard and believes strongly and expects results, the God who exists, in the final analysis, to give us what we want. We have many names for this reduction. We call it the prosperity gospel when it is crude, the God who exists to make you rich and healthy and successful, the divine vending machine into which you insert the correct spiritual coins and receive the blessing you ordered. But the crude version is only the obvious form of a subtle disease that infects even those who would recoil from the vending machine, because the deep structure of the error is not the desire for money. It is the assumption that God is a means, a tool, an instrument for the achievement of our purposes, rather than the end for whom all our purposes exist.

A God you can use is a God you have already dethroned. The question is not whether he is useful. The question is whether he is Lord.

The God of the Bible will not be used, and this is one of the hardest things about him for the modern soul, which has been trained to relate to everything instrumentally, to ask of every reality what it can do for me. We approach our technology this

way, and our institutions, and increasingly our relationships, and we have imported the same posture into our approach to God. We come to God with our agenda, our needs, our goals, our vision of the good life, and we ask him to bless it, to underwrite it, to supply the power for the achievement of a plan we made without him and now want him to fund. And we call this prayer, and we call this faith, and it is neither. It is the attempt to conscript the Almighty into the service of the self, to make the Creator a resource for the creature, to put God to work on our projects. And the living God will not be conscripted. He is not a resource. He is not a power we can harness. He is the Lord, and a Lord who could be harnessed would not be the Lord.

This is why God so often refuses to be useful, why he declines to answer the prayers that would confirm us in our instrumental relationship to him, why the man who treats God as a means so frequently finds God silent. It is not that God is withholding. It is that God loves us too much to let us succeed at using him, because a God we successfully used would be a God we had dethroned, an idol we had mastered, and to be mastered by the creature is not a thing the Creator will consent to, not out of pride, but out of love, because a mastered god cannot save the one who has mastered him. God's refusal to be useful is a mercy. It is his protection of us against the catastrophe of getting what we asked for, which would be a god the size of our own agenda, a god who could never lift us above the horizon of our own desires, a god as small as the self that summoned him. When God declines to be used, he is declining to become the idol we are trying to make of him, and in that decline he is preserving the possibility that we might, someday, stop using him and start worshiping him.

Consider how the pattern runs all through the Scriptures. Simon

the magician, in the book of Acts, sees the power of the Spirit and tries to buy it, tries to acquire it as a resource he can wield, and Peter's response is thunderous. May your silver perish with you, because you thought you could obtain the gift of God with money. The instrumental approach to God is not a minor error there. It is a thing worthy of perishing, because it strikes at the very heart of who God is, treating the Giver as a commodity and the gift as a technology. Or consider the sons of Sceva, who tried to use the name of Jesus as a formula, a technique for casting out demons, without any relationship to the Person the name belonged to, and the demon turned on them and drove them out naked and wounded, because the name of Jesus is not a tool that works regardless of the heart that wields it. God will not be reduced to a technique. He will not be a formula, a method, a lever we pull to produce an outcome. He is a Person, a Lord, a living and holy God, and the whole enterprise of using him is doomed from the start, because there is no handle on God by which a creature can pick him up.

I have to confess the ways I have tried to use God, because the temptation is not out there in the crude prosperity preachers but in here, in the heart of a pastor who should know better. I have prayed for the success of my ministry in ways that were really about my success, my reputation, my sense of accomplishment, and I have dressed the prayer in the language of the kingdom while the engine underneath it was the self. I have wanted God to grow my church, and told myself it was for his glory, when the honest truth is that a bigger church would have made me feel more significant, and I was, in the quiet of my own motives, trying to use God to build a monument to myself with his name on the plaque. I have approached God as a means to the ends I had already chosen, and called it faith, and the calling it faith is the most dangerous part, because it hides the idolatry under a

layer of piety so thick that I could not see it myself for years. The God who will not be used has had to refuse me, again and again, and every refusal has felt like a disappointment and been, in truth, a rescue, a merciful blocking of my attempt to shrink him to the size of my ambition.

The alternative to using God is worshipping him, and the difference between the two is the difference between treating God as a means and treating him as the end, and it changes everything about how you pray and how you live and how you suffer. When God is a means, prayer is a transaction, and unanswered prayer is a failure, a broken machine, a God who did not deliver. When God is the end, prayer is communion, and even unanswered prayer is a gift, because the point of prayer was never to extract an outcome but to be with the God who is himself the outcome, the God who is himself the answer to every prayer beneath every prayer. The person who has stopped using God and started worshipping him has been set free from the tyranny of results, because he no longer needs God to do anything for him, he only needs God to be God and to be his, and that he already has, and no circumstance can take it away. This is the freedom the instrumental believer never tastes, the freedom of a soul that wants God for himself and not for what he can provide, the freedom of a love that has finally stopped being a transaction and become, at last, a love.

So the recovery of the holy God is, among everything else it is, the recovery of a God we cannot use, and this is not a loss but a liberation, though it does not feel like one at first. The nice God is useful. That is much of his appeal. He affirms our plans, funds our agendas, exists to make our lives go better. And a useful god is a comfortable god right up until the moment you need not a tool but a Lord, right up until the moment your agenda collapses

and you discover that a god who existed to serve your plans has nothing to say when your plans are in ruins. The God who will not be used is the God who is still there when your plans are in ruins, because he was never the servant of your plans, he was always their Lord, and a Lord who could not be used by you in the good times is a Lord who cannot be lost by you in the bad times, because your grip on him was never the thing holding the relationship together. His grip on you was. And that grip does not loosen when your usefulness project fails. It holds. It holds precisely because it was never a transaction, never a tool, never a using, but a love, a lordship, a holy and unbreakable claim on a soul that was made not to use God but to worship him forever.

Chapter Seventeen: Reverence Recovered

We have almost entirely lost the word reverence, and with the word we have lost the thing, and I want to spend this chapter trying to recover both, because reverence is the practical posture that the whole of this book has been arguing toward. It is one thing to be persuaded, intellectually, that God is holy and weighty and terrible and beautiful. It is another thing to live in a manner shaped by that conviction, to carry it in the body, to let it govern how we approach God and how we speak of him and how we hold ourselves in his presence. That embodied, lived-out response to the holiness of God is what the old writers meant by reverence, and it has drained almost entirely out of the modern church, replaced by a casualness that we mistake for intimacy and a familiarity that we mistake for maturity, and the loss has cost us more than we know.

Familiarity is not intimacy, and casualness is not freedom. We traded reverence for both and got neither.

Let me describe what the loss looks like, because we swim in it and no longer notice it. We speak of God in the same tone we use for a friend or a coach or a helpful therapist. We refer to Jesus by nicknames that reduce him to a buddy. We approach the throne of grace, which Scripture says we may approach with boldness, as though boldness meant slouching in unannounced, feet on the furniture, making our requests known with the entitled ease of a regular customer. We have taken the genuine

and precious truth that God is our Father, that we may call him Abba, that the veil is torn and the way is open, and we have distorted it into a casualness that no one in the Scriptures who actually met God ever displayed. Jesus, who taught us to call God Father, also fell on his face in the garden. The apostle John, who leaned on Jesus at the supper, fell at his feet as dead on Patmos. Intimacy with God in the Bible never once produces casualness. It produces a reverence made warmer by love, but no less reverent for the warmth, in fact more reverent, because love sees the greatness of the beloved more clearly, not less.

This is the correction the sentimental age most needs and least wants to hear. We have set intimacy and reverence against each other, as though they were opposites, as though the more familiar we became with God the less reverent we needed to be, as though reverence were a distance that love overcomes. But this is exactly wrong, and the reversal of it is the recovery of the whole thing. Intimacy and reverence are not opposites. They grow together. The people who love God most reverently fear him, and the people who fear God most reverently love him, and the two deepen in the same motion, because both of them are responses to the same reality, the reality of who God actually is. It is only when we have a small God that intimacy and reverence seem to conflict, because a small god can be either approached warmly or feared distantly but not both. The great God, the true God, is approached warmly and feared reverently at once, and the warmth does not cancel the fear and the fear does not cool the warmth, because he is great enough to require both and to hold both together in the soul that truly knows him.

I think of the way a young child relates to a father who is both loved and genuinely respected, because this is the closest human analogy we have, and the Scriptures reach for it constantly. The

child of such a father runs to him, climbs on him, tells him everything, holds nothing back, is utterly at home in his presence. And the same child would never dream of mocking him, of treating him with contempt, of speaking to him the way the child speaks to his peers, because the child knows, in a way deeper than words, that this is his father, that this man is greater than he is, that there is an asymmetry in the relationship that love does not erase but rather honors. The child's intimacy and the child's reverence are the same relationship, and a child who had the intimacy without the reverence would not be closer to the father but further, would in fact have lost something essential about what it means to be a son. We have become children who have the intimacy without the reverence, who climb on God and tell him everything and are at home in his presence, but who have lost the sense that he is greater than we are, and we have called it maturity, and it is not maturity, it is a kind of arrested development, a sonship that never grew into the fullness of knowing who the Father is.

The recovery of reverence is not a return to coldness, and I have to say this clearly, because the moment I criticize casualness someone hears me calling for the frozen formality of a dead religion, the stiff and joyless piety that treats God as too holy to be loved. That is not reverence. That is its counterfeit, the counterfeit on the other side, and it is as false as the casualness it opposes. The frozen formalist has reverence without intimacy, distance without love, and he is as far from the true knowledge of God as the casual believer who has intimacy without reverence. Both have taken half of the reality and lost the whole. The recovered reverence I am calling for is not cold. It is warm and trembling at once, intimate and awed at once, the reverence of a beloved child before a Father who is also the Lord of heaven and earth, the reverence of Isaiah undone before the throne who

is also, moments later, sent and commissioned and made a friend of God. It is a reverence with love in it and a love with reverence in it, and it is the native posture of a soul that has seen God as he truly is.

How is it recovered, practically, in the body and the habits and the ordinary practices of a life. I do not have a technique to offer, because reverence, like awe and like worship, is finally a gift and not an achievement, and it comes from the sight of God and not from the effort of the will. But I can tell you the direction to face, the disciplines that clear the ground so that the gift, when it comes, finds a soul prepared to receive it. Slow down in the presence of God. Refuse the casual approach even when you feel nothing, because the body teaches the soul, and a body that kneels teaches a heart that has forgotten how. Guard your speech about God, because the tongue that grows careless about holy things carries a heart that is growing careless too. Return to the passages that unsettle you, the throne room and the whirlwind and the consuming fire, and let them do their work on you rather than explaining them away. And ask, ask God, for the recovery of reverence, ask him to show you his holiness, ask him to restore the fear of the Lord that is the beginning of wisdom, and be warned again that this is a dangerous prayer, because he may answer it, and you will not be left where you were.

I am praying that prayer myself, as I write this, because I am the chief of the casual, the pastor who has grown so familiar with holy things that they have stopped being holy in my hands, and I need the reverence recovered in me before I have any business calling for it in you. I have handled the coal so often that I have forgotten it burns. I have described the throne room so many times that I have stopped trembling at it. I have used the name of God so casually, in prayer and in preaching and in the ten

thousand small mentions of an ordinary ministry week, that the name has worn smooth in my mouth, and a name worn smooth is a name whose holiness I have profaned by mere familiarity. So I am asking for the coal again. I am asking to be undone again, to see the King again, to feel the doorposts shake and the smoke fill the temple and the woe rise up in my throat. Not because I want to be frightened. But because I want to be true, and there is no truthfulness about God that does not pass through reverence, and there is no reverence that does not begin with seeing him as he is, and there is no seeing him as he is that leaves the seer casual, ever again. Reverence recovered is the whole of the Christian life come to its proper posture. It is a creature, at last, standing rightly before its Creator. It is the shoes coming off. It is the ground remembered to be holy. And it has been holy the whole time, while we walked across it in our shoes, chattering, at home, and blind.

Chapter Eighteen: Why We Built the Nice God

I have been assuming, all through this book, that the nice God is a construction, a thing we made, an idol shaped by human hands out of our own preferences and fears. But I have not yet stopped to examine the making itself, to ask carefully how a civilization that once trembled before the *mysterium tremendum* came to worship a deity who is chiefly notable for being pleasant. This is worth doing, and doing slowly, because you cannot dismantle an idol you do not understand, and the nice God is not the product of a single error but of a long convergence of forces, some of them cultural, some of them spiritual, some of them born of genuine wounds that deserve compassion even as the god they produced deserves demolition. If we are going to let the nice God die, we had better understand where he came from, so that we do not simply build him again out of the same materials the moment our attention wanders.

We did not invent the nice God in a moment of arrogance. We assembled him, slowly, out of our wounds and our comforts and our fear of being small.

The first quarry from which the nice God was cut is the therapeutic revolution of the last century, the great shift by which the categories of psychology came to replace the categories of theology in the modern understanding of the self. This was not all bad, and I want to be fair to it, because the recovery of attention to the inner life, to trauma and to healing and to the

reality of psychological suffering, has relieved genuine misery and I will not sneer at it. But it had a cost, and the cost was that the language of sin gave way to the language of sickness, the language of guilt gave way to the language of woundedness, and the categories that had once organized our understanding of the human predicament were quietly retired. And a God who deals with sin is a very different God from a God who deals with woundedness. The God who confronts sin must be holy, must be a God before whom we stand accountable, must be a God with a claim on us and a standard we have violated. But the God who tends woundedness need only be kind, need only be affirming, need only be a divine therapist who helps us feel better about ourselves. The therapeutic revolution did not set out to build the nice God, but it supplied the raw material, because a culture that has replaced sin with sickness has already, without deciding to, replaced the holy God with the helpful one.

The philosopher and sociologist Philip Rieff saw this coming with terrible clarity, and in 1966 he published a book called *The Triumph of the Therapeutic*, in which he argued that Western culture was abandoning the whole framework of commitment and obligation and self-transcendence in favor of a new ideal, the psychological man, whose highest good was his own well-being, whose central project was the management of his own inner states, and who related to every institution and belief, including religion, primarily by what it contributed to his sense of well-being. The therapeutic person does not ask whether a thing is true. He asks whether it makes him feel better. He does not ask whether God is holy. He asks whether God is helpful. And a God submitted to that test, judged by whether he improves our sense of well-being, will inevitably be sanded down into the nice God, because every hard edge, every demand, every terror, every unwelcome truth reduces our well-being in the short term and so

gets quietly filed away as unhelpful, as toxic, as the kind of thing a healthy spirituality has moved beyond. The therapeutic person cannot worship the holy God, because the holy God fails the only test the therapeutic person knows how to apply. He is not, by the metric of immediate well-being, helpful. He is holy, and holiness, in the short run, disrupts our well-being before it heals us, and the therapeutic person has no patience for disruption.

The second quarry is comfort itself, the sheer unprecedented physical ease of modern life, and I include myself squarely inside this indictment because I have lived my whole life inside that ease and it has shaped me more than I can measure. Consider that for the overwhelming majority of human history, and for the overwhelming majority of human beings alive on the earth even now, life has been marked by a vulnerability that we in the comfortable West have almost entirely forgotten. Hunger was a real possibility. Disease struck without remedy. Children died. The weather could kill you. The powers of nature and of history pressed in on the human being from every side, and the transcendent did not have to knock to be felt, because life itself was thick with forces beyond human control. And in such a world the holy God, the God of terrible power and unsearchable purpose, was not an abstraction but a felt reality, because the human being lived close enough to the edge of catastrophe to know his own smallness. We do not live close to that edge, most of us, most of the time. We have padded ourselves against catastrophe with a thousand comforts, and the padding is a mercy, but it has a spiritual cost, because a creature that no longer feels its own smallness will not feel its need for a great God, and a creature insulated from terror will manufacture a God without terror, because the terror has gone out of its experience and so goes out of its theology. The nice God is the God of the comfortable, and we are the most comfortable people who have

ever lived, and we have made a God to match.

The third quarry, and this is the one I hold with the most tenderness because it is a real wound and not merely a comfortable delusion, is the failure of the church itself, the way that many people were handed a false and cruel god in the name of the true one, and fled, and had nowhere to flee except toward the opposite error. I have alluded to this before, but it deserves its own careful treatment here, because it would be a cruelty of my own to write a whole book against the nice God without acknowledging that many people reached for him out of genuine injury. Consider the person raised under a god of pure condemnation, a god who was always disappointed, always watching for the failure, always ready with the punishment, a god weaponized by an angry parent or a legalistic church to control and to shame. That person grew up associating the word holy with cruelty, associating the fear of God with the fear of abuse, associating reverence with the crushing of the self under a religion that had no gospel in it. And one day that person could not breathe under that god any longer, and they walked away, and they were right to walk away, because the god they walked away from was a slander against the true God, an idol of condemnation as false as the idol of niceness. But here is the tragedy. They had never been shown the true God. They had been offered only the cruel god, and so when they fled, the only alternative they could imagine was his opposite, and the opposite of a cruel god is a nice one. They ran from condemnation into affirmation, from the god who was always angry to the god who is never angry, and they never found the true God, the holy God, who is neither, because no one had ever shown him to them. The church built the cruel god that drove them to build the nice one. We are complicit in the very idolatry we now must confront, and any honest reckoning with the nice God has to begin with a

confession of the church's part in creating the wound that made him seem necessary.

There is a fourth quarry, subtler than the others, and it is the one I find hardest to confess because it implicates not the culture or the wounded but the ordinary spiritual laziness of the comfortable believer, which is to say it implicates me. The nice God requires nothing. That is his deepest appeal, deeper than comfort, deeper even than the healing of wounds. The holy God makes a total claim. He wants all of you, every room, every allegiance, every hidden thing, and the wanting is relentless and it does not stop and it will not be negotiated down. And there is a laziness in the human heart, a preference for the manageable minimum over the total demand, that reaches for the nice God not because it has been wounded and not because it has been seduced by therapy but simply because the nice God is easier, because a god who asks for a pleasant Sunday and a general benevolence is a god you can satisfy while keeping your life essentially your own, and the holy God is a god who will take your life and remake it, and remaking is hard, and we are tired, and the nice God lets us rest in a way the holy God never will. I have reached for the nice God out of sheer fatigue, out of the wish to be left alone, out of the desire for a faith that would fit inside the margins of a life I had already arranged to my own liking. And that reaching is not a wound and it is not a cultural conditioning. It is a sin, the old sin, the sin of wanting to keep the self on the throne, and it dresses itself up in the language of a gentler spirituality, and underneath the language it is simply the refusal to be dethroned.

So the nice God was built, out of therapy and comfort and wounded fleeing and lazy self-preservation, and he was built so gradually and by so many hands that no one ever decided to

build him, and that is why he is so hard to see and so hard to dismantle. He was not chosen. He was accumulated. He is the sediment of a hundred small preferences, the deposit left by a culture and a church and a heart all pulling in the same direction for a century, and he sits now in the center of our religious life looking so natural, so obvious, so much like simple kindness, that to attack him feels like attacking kindness itself. But he is not kindness. He is an idol, assembled from real materials and genuine wounds, and the fact that some of the materials were tears does not make him true. It only makes him harder to give up. Understanding where he came from is the beginning of being free of him. We built him out of our comfort and our fear, and we can, by grace, let him be torn down, and stand again, uncomfortable and unafraid, before the God we did not build, the God who built us, the God who was holy the whole time we were busy making him nice.

Chapter Nineteen: The Sons and the Father

I have to write a chapter that is more personal than the others, and I have been avoiding it, because it costs me something to write, and because I am not sure I can keep the voice steady through it. But this book has promised not to hide, and there is a place in my own life where the whole argument of it has been tested more severely than in any theology, and that is the place of being a father to five sons while having had no father myself. I do not know how to think about the God who is not nice apart from that absence and that fullness, apart from the empty place where a father should have been in my own childhood and the crowded house of sons I was somehow given to raise. The doctrine of the fatherhood of God is not, for me, an abstraction. It is the most personal wound and the most personal healing I have, and I cannot write honestly about the weight of God without writing about the weight of that.

A boy without a father does not learn that God is distant. He learns that God is the only Father there is, and he cannot afford for that Father to be nice.

I grew up without a father, and I want to be careful how I say this, because the absence of a father is not a single wound but a whole territory of wounds, and the map of it is different for every child who carries it. For me the absence was not dramatic. There was no single catastrophe, no scene I can point to. There was simply a hole where a man should have been, a hole so constant

that for years I did not perceive it as a hole at all, the way a fish does not perceive water. I did not miss what I had never had. What I had instead was a kind of self-sufficiency forced on a child too early, a sense that there was no one above me, no larger man whose strength I could shelter under, no one to teach me what a man was by being one in front of me. And I built, out of that absence, a certain hardness, and also a certain hunger, and the hardness and the hunger between them made me, I think, an atheist, because a boy who has learned that there is no father over him is well prepared to conclude that there is no Father over anything.

When I came to faith, late and from the outside, the thing that undid me was not an argument, though I had lost the arguments long before I surrendered. The thing that undid me was the discovery that the God I had denied was a Father, and not the absent kind, and not the cruel kind, but a Father in the full and terrible and tender sense that I had never had and had stopped believing was possible. And here is the thing I most need to say in this chapter, the thing that connects it to everything else in this book. The Father I found was not nice. If he had been merely nice, he could not have healed the wound, because the wound was not a wound that niceness could reach. A boy who grew up without a father does not need a pleasant God, an affirming God, a God who is glad he came and hopes he has a nice week. A boy who grew up without a father needs a Father with weight, a Father whose strength is real, a Father under whom he can finally, for the first time, shelter, a Father great enough to be the thing that was missing. And the nice God is not great enough. The nice God is another absent father, present in a pleasant sort of way but without the weight, without the strength, without the terrible reality that a fatherless child actually requires. It was the holy God, the weighty God, the God of the throne room and the

consuming fire, who turned out to be the Father I had needed all along, because only a God that great was large enough to fill a hole that deep.

And then I was given sons, five of them, and I had to become the thing I had never seen, and I want to tell you that the doctrine of the fatherhood of God became, in that becoming, the most practical theology I possess. Because I did not know how to be a father. I had no template. I had the absence and the hunger and nothing else, and I was terrified, in the early years, that I would either repeat the absence or overcorrect into some smothering and anxious presence that would be its own kind of harm. And what saved me, what taught me, was the character of God the Father, the real one, the one who is not nice. Because I watched how he fathers, in the Scriptures and in my own life, and I saw that true fatherhood is exactly the thing this whole book has been describing, the holding together of severity and tenderness, of demand and delight, of the strength that a child can shelter under and the love that makes the strength safe. I learned that a father who is merely nice fails his sons, because a father who is merely nice will not confront them, will not discipline them, will not hold them to a standard, will not be strong enough for them to push against and find that he does not give way. And I learned that a father who is merely severe destroys his sons, because severity without tenderness is the cruel god all over again, the god who drives children to atheism, the god I had half-built my own unbelief against. The true father, the God-shaped father, is both, and the being both is the hardest thing I have ever tried to do, and I fail at it constantly, and the God who is not nice is the only pattern I have for getting it even partly right.

There is a moment I keep returning to, and I will not give you which son or which occasion, but I will give you the shape of it,

because it taught me more about the wrath and the love of God being one fire than any book ever did. One of my sons did a thing that was genuinely wrong, a thing that had hurt someone, and I felt, rising up in me, something that I can only call anger, and it frightened me, because I had spent my life fearing anger, associating it with the absent and the cruel, and here it was in me, hot and real. And I had to decide, in that moment, what to do with it, and what I discovered is that the anger was not the opposite of my love for my son. The anger was my love for my son, turned toward the thing he had done that was going to destroy him if it went unchecked. I was not angry at my son. I was angry, out of love for my son, at the thing in him that was hurting others and would, unaddressed, hurt him most of all. And I understood, in a way I never had before, the wrath of God the Father, understood that it is not the opposite of his love but the fierce edge of it, understood that a father who felt no anger at what was destroying his child would be a father who did not love his child, and that the fire I felt was the same fire, at an infinitesimal scale, that burns at the heart of the holy God who loves the world he made.

And I have learned the severe mercy as a father too, learned it from the inside, learned how much it costs to wound a son for his good, to let him face a consequence I could have spared him, to refuse a thing he wanted because I could see it would harm him, to be, in his eyes and sometimes in my own aching heart, the bad guy, the one who said no, the one who did not give the child what the child was sure he needed. Every parent knows this and the nice God does not, and that is the proof that the nice God is not a real father, because no real father can afford to be merely nice, no real father can give his children everything they want, no real father can spare his children every pain, because a father who spares his children every pain raises children who cannot

survive the world, and love, real love, refuses to do that to a child. I have wounded my sons in small ways for their good, and it has cost me, and I have understood, through the cost, that when God wounds me for my good it costs him too, that the severe mercy is severe on the one who administers it and not only on the one who receives it, that the Father's hand that disciplines is a hand that aches while it disciplines, because he is not nice, he is something infinitely better, he is a Father, and a Father's love is the most demanding and most costly love there is.

So when I say that God is not nice, I am not saying it from a safe distance, as a doctrine I find interesting. I am saying it as a man who needed a Father and found one, and who was given sons and had to become one, and who has learned in both directions that the nice God is a fiction that could neither have healed my fatherlessness nor taught me to father, and that only the weighty God, the holy God, the God whose severity and tenderness are the same fire, is real enough and strong enough and demanding enough to be an actual Father to actual children in an actual and dangerous world. I needed that Father. My sons need that father in me, however poorly I manage it. And the whole world, full of fatherless children and failing fathers, needs to know that the God over all of it is not the pleasant absence they have been offered but a Father with weight, a Father under whom the fatherless can finally shelter, a Father whose strength is real and whose love is fierce and whose discipline aches in his own heart and whose arms, when you finally run into them, are strong enough to hold everything you have been carrying alone. That is not a nice God. That is a Father. And a fatherless world does not need the former. It is dying for the latter.

Chapter Twenty: The Immensity We Cannot Hold

A.W. Tozer opened *The Knowledge of the Holy* in 1961 with a sentence I have already made the epigraph of this whole book, and I want to come back to it now and stand under its full weight, because it is the sentence that explains why any of this matters. What comes into our minds when we think about God is the most important thing about us. Not what we say about God. Not what we profess or sing or defend in argument. What actually comes into our minds, involuntarily, when the word God surfaces, the picture that rises unbidden, the felt sense of who he is that governs our prayers and our fears and our hopes below the level of our stated theology. That, Tozer says, is the most important thing about us, more important than our talents or our circumstances or our accomplishments, because it silently shapes everything else. And I have to ask myself, and I have to ask you, what actually rises when the word God surfaces in us, and I suspect that for most of us the honest answer is something small, something manageable, something a great deal less than the immensity that the word is supposed to name.

The God who fits in your mind is not God. He is a portrait you painted of a God too large to sit for the portrait.

Tozer's whole burden in that book was that the church of his day had lost the majesty of God, had reduced him to a size the modern mind could hold, and that this reduction was the root of

every other weakness in the church's life. A low view of God, he wrote, is the cause of a hundred lesser evils, but a high view of God is the solution to ten thousand temporal problems. And he meant something precise by a high view of God, something that the sentimental age has almost entirely lost the capacity even to imagine. He meant the recovery of God's immensity, his infinitude, his transcendence, the sheer unmanageable vastness of a Being who is not one item in the universe but the ground of the universe, not the largest thing that exists but the reason anything exists at all, a Being before whom the galaxies are less than a breath and the ages of history are less than an afternoon. That God cannot be held in the mind. That is the first thing to understand about him. The moment you think you have grasped him, you have grasped something else, because a God you could grasp would be smaller than your grasp, and nothing smaller than your grasp is worth worshiping.

This is the doctrine the theologians call the incomprehensibility of God, and it is not a confession of ignorance but a confession of glory. To say that God is incomprehensible is not to say that we can know nothing of him, for he has revealed himself and we may truly know what he has shown. It is to say that what he has shown is the edge of an immensity we will never reach the end of, that even in eternity we will be exploring a God who is infinitely beyond our comprehension, that the knowledge of God is not a territory we will someday map completely but an ocean without a shore, a fire we will draw nearer to forever without ever arriving at its center. And this incomprehensibility is a mercy and a glory, not a frustration, because a God we could fully comprehend would be a God we would eventually exhaust, and a God we could exhaust would eventually bore us, and the terror of the sentimental age is that it has made a God small enough to be exhausted, and having exhausted him, it is bored

with him, and calls its boredom sophistication and its exhaustion maturity. The immense God is never exhausted. There is always more. The saints in glory a billion years from now will still be discovering him, still being surprised by him, still finding, as Lewis said, that as they grow he is bigger. That is not a limitation. That is the endlessness of joy.

I confess that I prefer the manageable God for exactly the reason Tozer diagnosed, because the manageable God can be held, and there is a comfort in holding, in feeling that I have God figured out, that I know his shape and his ways and can predict him, that I have, in my theology, a complete and finished portrait I can hang on the wall and consult when needed. And every complete and finished portrait of God is a lie, because God does not sit for portraits, because the moment you have finished the portrait you have proven that you were painting something smaller than God, since the real God cannot be finished, cannot be framed, cannot be hung on any wall or held in any mind. My tidy theology, the theology I can carry around and deploy, is a portrait of an idol, and I have to keep confessing this, because the temptation to prefer the portrait to the immensity is the temptation of every person who thinks about God professionally, and it is the temptation I fall to most often, the reduction of the living and unmanageable God to a system I have mastered and can teach. A God I have mastered is not God. He is my notes about God, and my notes, however careful, are not the fire they describe.

There is a particular danger here for those of us who value the intellect, who love theology, who have given our lives to the study of God, and I want to name it because it is my own danger and I have watched it destroy the faith of people cleverer than I am. The danger is that the study of God can become a substitute for the knowledge of God, that we can accumulate accurate

information about the immense God while our actual relationship is with the manageable god of our own system, that we can become experts on a fire we have never been burned by. Tozer saw this too, and he was merciless about it, because he understood that you can be theologically correct and spiritually dead, that you can hold every right doctrine about God while your heart worships a portrait, that orthodoxy about the immense God is no protection at all against the idolatry of the manageable one if the immensity has never actually broken in and undone you. The mind can hold correct propositions about a God the heart has reduced to a comfortable size, and this is perhaps the most insidious form of the nice God, the theologically orthodox nice God, the God who is correctly described in all our books and never once trembled at in any of our prayers.

So how do we recover the immensity, we who have made God small, we who prefer the portrait to the fire. And I have to give the same answer I have given throughout this book, because it is the only true answer, which is that we cannot recover it by effort, cannot inflate our small God back to his proper size by an act of the will, cannot argue ourselves into awe. The immensity is recovered the way everything real about God is recovered, by sight, by the God who is immense breaking in and showing himself to be immense, by a disclosure we receive rather than an achievement we accomplish. What we can do is stop resisting the immensity, stop preferring the portrait, stop reaching for the manageable God the moment the immense one begins to overwhelm us. We can go back to the passages that stretch the mind past its breaking point, the vision of Ezekiel with its wheels within wheels and its living creatures and its throne above the firmament, the vision of Daniel with the Ancient of Days whose throne was flaming fire and whose wheels were burning fire and before whom a thousand thousands served and

ten thousand times ten thousand stood, the vision of John with the one seated on the throne who had the appearance of jasper and carnelian and around whom was a rainbow like an emerald. We can let those visions do their work, refuse to reduce them, refuse to explain them into manageability, and let the God they describe be as immense in our minds as he is in himself.

And here is the promise, the thing that makes the recovery of the immensity worth the loss of the comfortable portrait. The immense God, the God too large to hold, the God we will never exhaust or master or finish, is not a distant God, and this is the reversal that the whole recovery turns on. We assume that immensity means distance, that a God that vast must be that far away, that the price of a great God is a remote one. But it is exactly backward. The immense God is the near God, nearer than the small god could ever be, because the small god is near you the way another object is near you, across a gap, from outside, while the immense God, who is not an object at all but the ground of your being, is nearer to you than your own heartbeat, holding you in existence from within, closer than the small god could ever come. The immensity is the intimacy. Lose the immensity and you lose the intimacy with it, and you are left with the manageable god, who is neither vast nor near, neither immense nor intimate, a portrait on a wall that neither overwhelms you nor holds you, and we have settled for that portrait, and Tozer wept over the settling, and I weep over it too, and the tears are the beginning of the recovery, because a man who weeps over his small god has already begun to suspect that there is a larger one, and the suspicion, God willing, is the first crack in the frame through which the immensity will come flooding back.

Chapter Twenty-One: The God Who Hides

There is a strange and difficult truth about the holy God that the sentimental age cannot account for and would rather not discuss, which is that he hides. He is not always found. He is not perpetually available, warm and present and near at hand, the way the nice God is imagined to be. The Scriptures speak, over and over, of a God who conceals himself, who withdraws, who is sought and not found, who seems for long seasons to have hidden his face. Truly, you are a God who hides himself, cries Isaiah, and he is not complaining about an aberration but naming a permanent feature of who God is. Why do you hide your face, cries the psalmist, and the question is not answered, is left hanging, is allowed to stand as one of the real experiences of the life of faith. The nice God does not hide. He is always there, always warm, always accessible, a reliable source of good feelings available on demand. But the true God hides, and the hiddenness of God is one of the deepest reasons the sentimental believer eventually loses his faith, because the sentimental believer was never told that God hides, and when the hiding comes, he concludes that God was never there.

The God who is always available is not God. He is a feeling you have learned to summon. The real God comes and goes, and his going is part of how he keeps you his.

Let me describe the experience, because you have had it, or you will, and it is essential to know that it is not a failure of your

faith but a feature of the God you are dealing with. There are seasons in the life of every believer, and they are longer and more common than we admit from our pulpits, when God is simply not felt, when prayer seems to reach the ceiling and stop, when the warmth that once attended the faith has gone cold, when God, who was so present, seems to have withdrawn behind a veil and left the soul calling into a silence. The old writers had a name for this, a name we have almost entirely forgotten because our sentimental theology has no place for it. They called it the dark night of the soul, and they did not regard it as a spiritual disaster but as a normal and even necessary stage in the deepening of a real relationship with the real God. And notice that the nice God has no dark night, because the nice God is a feeling, and feelings can always be summoned again, and so the worshiper of the nice God, when the warmth fades, simply works to summon it back, and if he cannot, concludes that the whole thing was a delusion. But the worshiper of the holy God knows that God hides, and knows that the hiding is not abandonment, and holds on through the darkness precisely because he was never depending on the warmth in the first place, was depending on the God who is real whether or not he is felt.

Why does the holy God hide. There are, I think, several reasons woven together, and none of them is the reason the sentimental believer fears, which is that God has stopped loving him or was never there. The first reason is that God hides in order to be sought, because a God perpetually and effortlessly available would be a God taken for granted, a God whose presence, because it cost nothing, would be valued at nothing. It is a hard law of the human heart that we do not treasure what we cannot lose, and so the God who wishes to be treasured allows himself, for seasons, to be lost, to be sought, to be longed for, so that when he is found again he is found by a heart that has learned,

through the seeking, how precious the finding is. The hiding of God is the schooling of desire. It teaches us to want him, and a heart that has learned to want God through the pain of his absence loves him more truly than a heart that has only ever enjoyed the ease of his presence. Blessed are those who hunger, Jesus said, and you cannot hunger for a God who is always at the table. The hiding creates the hunger, and the hunger is the making of a deeper love.

The second reason God hides is to wean us from his gifts and draw us to himself, and this cuts close to the instrumental idolatry I described earlier, the using of God rather than the worshiping of him. Because as long as God is felt, as long as the warmth and the sweetness attend our devotion, there is a subtle danger that we are in love with the feeling rather than with God, that we come to him for the experience he provides rather than for himself, that we are, without knowing it, using even our devotion as a means to the end of our own emotional satisfaction. And so God, who will not be used, sometimes withdraws the feeling, takes away the sweetness, hides the warmth, precisely in order to test and to purify the love, to reveal whether we wanted him or only wanted what he made us feel. The dark night strips away the consolations of religion and leaves the soul with a stark question. Do you want God, or did you only ever want the good feelings God gave you. And a soul that keeps seeking God through the darkness, when there is no warmth and no reward and no consolation, is a soul that has proven, to itself and to God, that it loves God for himself, and that love, forged in the absence of every feeling, is worth more than a thousand seasons of easy warmth. The hiding of God is the purification of love, the burning away of the instrumental, the making of a devotion that wants God and not merely his gifts.

I have walked through the hiding of God, and I will tell you honestly that it was the most frightening thing that has happened to me in the life of faith, more frightening than the doubts of my atheist years, because in my atheist years I did not believe there was anyone to lose. But to have known the presence of God, to have been warmed by it and consoled by it and to have built a life on it, and then to have it withdraw, to call into the silence and hear nothing, to kneel where you have always met him and find the place empty, that is a terror the sentimental faith has no equipment to survive. And I nearly did not survive it, and what carried me through was not a feeling, because the feelings were gone, and not an experience, because the experiences had stopped, but a naked and stubborn trust in the character of a God I could no longer feel, a holding on in the dark to what I knew to be true of him even when I could feel nothing of him at all. And I learned, on the far side of it, that the God who hid had not left, that he had been there in the darkness all along, closer than ever, holding me through the very absence I thought was abandonment, and that the faith I had on the far side of the hiding was deeper and truer and less dependent on my own emotional weather than anything I had known before. The hiding of God had done its work. It had taken my sentimental faith, my warm and feeling-dependent devotion, and it had burned it down to something harder and realer, a faith that could stand in the dark, a faith that trusted the God it could not feel.

The sentimental God cannot do this for us, and this is the last thing I want to say about the hiding, because it is the thing that makes the hiding, terrible as it is, a mercy. The sentimental God, being a feeling, cannot survive the loss of the feeling, and so the worshiper of the sentimental God is a worshiper whose faith is only as strong as his last good experience, a faith perpetually vulnerable to the shifting of his own emotional weather, a faith

that will collapse the moment the warmth fades, as the warmth always eventually fades. But the holy God, by hiding, teaches us to build our faith on something other than our feelings, on his character rather than our experience, on what is true of him rather than what we feel of him, and a faith built on that foundation is a faith that can survive anything, because it does not depend on the one thing that is always failing, which is us. The hiding of God is the gift of a faith that does not depend on feeling God, and that gift can only be given by hiding, and so the God who loves us enough to give us an unshakable faith is a God who must, for a season, shake us, must withdraw, must hide his face, must let us call into the silence and find him gone, so that we will learn to hold on to him in the dark, and having learned it, will never again be at the mercy of our own unreliable hearts. That is not a nice thing to do to someone you love. It is a holy thing, and a wise thing, and a thing that only a God far greater and far more loving than the sentimental idol could ever have the courage and the wisdom to do.

Chapter Twenty-Two: Holiness and the Gathered Church

I have written this book largely about the individual soul before God, but I am a pastor, and I would be failing my calling if I did not turn, before the end, to the gathered church, to what happens when the people of God assemble, because the loss of the holy God has done its deepest damage there, in the corporate life of the church, in the thing that happens on Sunday morning across ten thousand sanctuaries in this comfortable land. The sentimental God has reshaped the church in his own image, and the reshaping has been so thorough and so gradual that most of us cannot see it, because we have never known anything else, because the church of the nice God is the only church most of us have ever attended, and you cannot perceive the water you were born swimming in. But I have to try to name it, because the recovery of the holy God is not merely a private matter of individual devotion. It is a matter of what the church is, and what it is for, and whether it will survive as anything more than a pleasant social institution offering religious services to comfortable consumers.

A church built to make people comfortable will never make them holy, and a church that does not make people holy has forgotten the only reason it exists.

Consider what the gathering of the church has become in the age of the nice God, and consider it honestly, including the ways I have led it in exactly this direction. The church service has

become, in many places, a carefully engineered experience designed to make people feel welcomed, comfortable, uplifted, and glad they came. Every element is optimized for the comfort of the attender. The music is designed to move without demanding. The message is crafted to encourage without confronting. The whole atmosphere is calibrated to ensure that no one feels awkward, no one feels convicted, no one leaves troubled, no one encounters anything that would disturb the pleasant equilibrium of a comfortable Sunday. And we have called this being welcoming, being seeker-sensitive, being relevant, and there is a grain of truth in each of those, and I do not despise the desire to welcome the stranger. But we have to ask what we are welcoming them into. We have built churches that are extraordinarily good at making people comfortable and extraordinarily bad at bringing them face to face with the holy God, and we have done it on purpose, because comfort fills rooms and holiness empties them, at least at first, and we have chosen full rooms over holy encounters, and we have called the choice ministry.

But here is what the whole enterprise forgets. The church does not exist to make people comfortable. The church exists to be the place where the living God is encountered, where his people gather in his presence, where heaven touches earth and the holy God meets his gathered people and does to them what he did to Isaiah, undoes them and cleanses them and sends them. The gathering of the church is meant to be a dangerous thing, a holy thing, an encounter with the *mysterium tremendum*, and the early church understood this in a way we have entirely lost. When the church gathered in the book of Acts, awe came upon every soul. When Ananias and Sapphira lied to the Holy Spirit in the gathered assembly, they fell down dead, and great fear came upon the whole church and upon all who heard of these things.

That is a church in the presence of the holy God. That is a gathering where the weight of God is actually present, where the stakes are real, where you do not saunter in casually because the God who is there is a consuming fire. And I am not calling for a church where people drop dead, but I am calling for a church that remembers that the God it gathers before is the same God, that the casualness with which we approach our gatherings would have been unthinkable to a church that knew whose presence it was entering.

The tragedy of the comfortable church is that it fails the very people it is trying to serve, because people do not actually need what the comfortable church offers them. They come, many of them, in real pain, carrying real burdens, facing real death, and the comfortable church gives them a pleasant experience and a warm feeling and an uplifting message and sends them back out into their real suffering with nothing that can hold its weight. They came needing the holy God, the God of the rod and the staff, the God who is Lord even of the valley of the shadow, and they were given the nice God, the God of the pleasant Sunday, and the nice God cannot carry what they brought. I have watched people leave churches, good people, hungry people, and when I have asked them why, the answer, underneath whatever surface reasons they give, is so often the same. They were starving. They came looking for God, the real one, the weighty one, and they were fed comfort, and comfort is not food, and they were starving in a room full of people who thought they were being fed. The comfortable church is a place where the hungry starve amid abundance, because the abundance is not the bread they need, and the bread they need, the holy God in his full weight, is the one thing the comfortable church has decided not to serve, because it is too heavy, and heavy things do not fill rooms.

I have to confess my own part in building the comfortable church, because I have led one, and I have made the choices, week after week, that shaped it in the image of the nice God. I have softened messages because the hard version would have troubled people, and troubled people leave, and leaving people take their giving with them, and a church with a shrinking budget cannot do the good it wants to do, and so the logic runs, and every step of it seems reasonable, and at the end of it you have a church that has traded the holy God for institutional survival and called the trade wisdom. I have chosen the comfortable word over the true one more times than I can count, and each choice seemed small, seemed pastoral, seemed kind, and the accumulation of them has built a ministry that is, I fear, better at comforting people in their sin than at confronting them with their God. And I do not know how to fix it except by repentance, by the slow and costly work of preaching the holy God even when it empties the room, of trusting that a smaller church built on the true God is worth more than a larger one built on the nice one, of believing that the hungry who are actually fed are worth more than the comfortable who are merely entertained. That repentance is not comfortable. It costs, and it costs most of all the pastor who has built his sense of himself on the size of the room.

Because the recovery of the holy God in the gathered church would cost us something we are terrified to lose, and I have to name it plainly. It would cost us numbers, at least at first, because the holy God is not a crowd-pleaser, because the message that undoes people before it heals them is not a message that fills a room the way comfort does. It would cost us the pleasant Sunday, the reliable uplift, the warm feeling that people have come to expect and that we have trained them to want. It would cost us the applause of a culture that likes its religion

mild. And we are not sure we are willing to pay it, we pastors, we church leaders, we who have built our identities on the growth of institutions that grew by being comfortable. But I am increasingly sure that we have to pay it, that the alternative is a church that survives as an institution while dying as a witness, a church that keeps its rooms full and loses its reason to exist, a church that has so thoroughly domesticated God that it can no longer offer the world the one thing the world cannot get anywhere else, which is an encounter with the living and holy God. The world has comfort. The world has affirmation and uplift and pleasant experiences in abundance. The one thing the world does not have, the one thing only the church can offer, is the holy God, and if the church will not offer him, if the church offers instead a religious version of the comfort the world already has, then the church has made itself redundant, a pleasant and dispensable option among the many pleasant and dispensable options a comfortable culture provides. The recovery of the holy God is the recovery of the church's reason to exist. Without him, we are one more comfortable institution in a world drowning in comfortable institutions, and we will deserve the irrelevance we have chosen.

Chapter Twenty-Three: The Terror and the Tenderness Are One

I have spent much of this book insisting on the terror of God against a sentimental age that had forgotten it, and I have insisted just as hard that this is not a book for the mean God, the angry deity of condemnation, and I am aware that holding these two together is precisely the thing our whole culture finds impossible. We think in binaries. We think a thing must be either soft or hard, either warm or cold, either loving or fearsome, and we cannot hold together in a single object the terror and the tenderness, the severity and the sweetness, the wrath and the mercy. And so, faced with a God who is unmistakably both in the pages of Scripture, we do what our binary minds require. We choose. We keep the tenderness and lose the terror and get the nice God, or we keep the terror and lose the tenderness and get the mean god, and either way we have destroyed the actual God, who is not a balance of the two, not a compromise between them, not fifty percent stern and fifty percent kind, but a single fire in which the terror and the tenderness are the same thing, seen from different distances, felt by different souls, but one fire, one God, one holiness that burns and warms with the identical flame.

The severity and the tenderness of God are not two temperatures of his love. They are one temperature, felt differently depending on what in you is being touched.

This is the hardest thing in the book to say clearly, and I have

circled it many times, and I want now to say it as directly as I can, because everything depends on it. The love of God and the wrath of God are not two separate attributes that God has to balance against each other, as though he were sometimes loving and sometimes wrathful and had to decide which mood to be in. They are one thing. The wrath of God is his love, burning against everything that is destroying the beloved. The severity of God is his tenderness, refusing to leave the beloved in the ruin the beloved has chosen. The terror of God is his beauty, at a magnitude too great for a small soul to bear without trembling. It is all one fire. When the same fire touches the cancer, it is experienced as a burning, a destruction, a terror, because the fire is consuming what must be consumed. When the same fire touches the patient, it is experienced as a healing, a warmth, a mercy, because the fire is saving what must be saved. But it is one fire, one holiness, one God, and the difference is not in him but in what he is touching, whether it is the disease or the beloved, whether it is the sin or the sinner God means to rescue from the sin.

The cross is where this becomes visible, and I return to it because it is the only place where the unity of the terror and the tenderness is displayed in a single event. At the cross the wrath of God and the love of God are not balanced against each other, not held in some careful equilibrium, but revealed to be one thing, because at the cross God pours out his wrath against sin and his love for sinners in the identical act, in the same broken body, in the one death that is at once the most terrible display of God's severity against evil and the most tender display of God's mercy toward the evildoer. You cannot separate them at the cross. You cannot say, here is the wrath part and here is the love part. The wrath and the love are the same nail, the same thorn, the same cry of dereliction, the same blood. The God who is not

nice is revealed at the cross to be a God whose terror and tenderness are so completely one that they are indistinguishable, a God whose fiercest severity against sin is his tenderest mercy toward sinners, a God who could only love us this tenderly by being this terrible, and could only be this terrible because he loved us this much. The cross is the death of the binary. It is the place where our either-or, our soft-or-hard, our warm-or-cold, is exposed as a failure to perceive the single fire that God has always been.

And this means that the tenderness of God, the real tenderness, the tenderness that can actually comfort and heal and hold, is only available on the far side of the terror, and this is the thing the sentimental age has gotten exactly backward. We think that to get the tenderness we must get rid of the terror, that the two are in competition, that every ounce of severity we attribute to God is an ounce of tenderness we lose. But it is the reverse. The tenderness of God is only as deep as his terror, because they are the same fire, and a God with no terror would have no tenderness either, would have only the thin warmth of sentiment, the shallow niceness that cannot reach the depths where real comfort is needed. The tenderness that heals the dying, the tenderness that holds the grieving, the tenderness that forgives the guilty and cleanses the defiled, is a tenderness with the full weight of God's holiness behind it, a tenderness that costs, a tenderness forged in the same fire that terrifies. Strip away the terror and you do not get more tenderness. You get less. You get a nice god whose tenderness is as thin as his terror, and whose comfort, when you finally need it, proves as insubstantial as his fear.

I think of the moments in the Gospels when Jesus is most tender, and I notice that the tenderness is never separate from the weight, is never the tenderness of a merely nice man, but is

always the tenderness of one in whom the fullness of God dwells, and the weight of the divinity makes the tenderness infinitely more than sentiment. When he weeps at the tomb of Lazarus, it is not the helpless weeping of a fellow mourner, though he weeps real tears, because moments later he speaks and the dead man walks. The tenderness of his tears and the terror of his authority over death are one thing, one Lord, one fire. When he takes the children in his arms and blesses them, the arms that hold them are the arms of the one through whom all things were made, and the tenderness is the tenderness of omnipotence bending down, which is a tenderness of a wholly different order than the tenderness of a merely nice man, because it is tenderness with the weight of God in it. When he says to the woman caught in adultery, neither do I condemn you, the words are spoken by the one who will, on the last day, judge the living and the dead, and the mercy is the mercy of the Judge himself declining to condemn, which is a mercy of infinite weight, not the cheap mercy of a god who was never going to condemn anyone anyway. The tenderness of Jesus is terrible tenderness, weighty tenderness, the tenderness of the holy God, and it is precisely the weight that makes it able to save.

So I have to let go, finally, of my demand that God be simple, that he be one thing I can categorize, that he be either the soft god of my comfort or the hard god of my fear, and I have to receive him as he is, as the single fire in which the terror and the tenderness are one, as the God who is not nice precisely because he is something so much greater and stranger and more wonderful than nice, a God whose severity is his mercy and whose mercy is his severity and whose whole being is a holiness that burns and warms with the same flame. And I have to stop trying to resolve the tension, because the tension is not a problem to be solved but a glory to be beheld, and every attempt

to resolve it, to make God simply soft or simply hard, is an attempt to reduce the glory to something my small mind can manage, and the glory will not be reduced. He is terrible and he is tender, and he is both at once, and the both-at-once is not a contradiction to be smoothed away but the very thing that makes him God, the very thing that makes him worthy of worship, the very thing that makes him able to save. I wanted a simple God. He gave me himself instead, terrible and tender, one fire, and I am learning, slowly, that the God who will not be simplified is the only God large enough to be real.

Chapter Twenty-Four: The Weight We Were Made to Bear

There is a Hebrew word that stands behind almost everything I have been trying to say in this book, and I have been circling it without naming it directly, and it is time to name it, because it is the word that holds the whole thing together. The word is *kavod*, and we translate it glory, but the root meaning of the word is weight, heaviness, substance. The glory of God is, at root, the weight of God, his sheer substantiality, the density of his reality compared to which everything else is thin and insubstantial and light. When the glory of God filled the temple so that the priests could not stand to minister, it was the weight of God, the *kavod*, the crushing substantiality of the divine presence, too heavy for the room to hold. When Moses asked to see God's glory, he was asking to see the weight, the substance, the full density of the divine reality, and God told him that no one could see it and live, because a creature cannot bear the full weight of God without being crushed, without being undone, without dying under a substantiality too great for finite flesh to hold.

We were not made to be light. We were made to be weighted, and the weight we were made to bear is the weight of the glory of God.

And here is the thing that turns the whole meditation from theology into the deepest possible good news. We were made for that weight. This is the astonishing claim at the heart of the Christian understanding of what a human being is and is for. We

were not made to be light, to be thin, to be insubstantial creatures skimming across the surface of a comfortable existence. We were made to bear weight, to carry glory, to be substantial with a substantiality borrowed from God himself. C.S. Lewis saw this and gave it its greatest expression in that sermon from 1941, *The Weight of Glory*, where he argued that the destiny of the redeemed human being is to bear a weight of glory so great that if we saw it now in another person we would be tempted to worship them, that we are being prepared to carry a substantiality, a solidity of being, that would break us if it came all at once but that is the very thing we were created to hold. The sentimental age has forgotten this entirely. It thinks the goal of human life is comfort, ease, the reduction of weight, the smoothing away of everything difficult, the achievement of a frictionless pleasant existence. And it is exactly wrong, because we were not made for lightness. We were made for weight, and a life spent fleeing weight is a life spent fleeing the very thing we were created for.

Consider how this reframes everything. The reason the nice God cannot satisfy us is not merely that he is false but that he is light, and we were made for weight, and a light god leaves the weight-shaped hunger in us unfed. We were built with a capacity for glory, a capacity to bear substance, a capacity to carry a weight of meaning and reality and holiness, and the nice god, being light, cannot fill that capacity, cannot give us the weight we were made to bear, and so leaves us restless, hungry, unsatisfied, skimming across the surface of a comfortable existence while some deep part of us aches for a density we cannot name. Augustine named it in the fourth century when he said that our hearts are restless until they rest in God, and the restlessness is the ache of a weight-shaped creature offered only lightness, a substantial being fed only froth, a soul made for glory and

offered only comfort. The nice god cannot cure the restlessness because the nice god is part of the disease, is himself a form of the lightness we are fleeing, and only the weighty God, the God of kavod, the God of glory, can fill the weight-shaped hunger with the weight it was made for.

And this is why the recovery of the holy God is not a burden but a homecoming, and I want to press this hard against the impression I may have given that the holy God is a heavier load to carry, a more demanding deity, a God who asks more of us than the nice one. In one sense that is true. But in the deeper sense it is exactly backward, because the weight of the holy God is not a load laid on us from outside but the weight we were made to carry from within, the weight that fits the shape of our souls, the weight in the bearing of which we become, at last, fully ourselves. It is like the difference between the weight of a burden and the weight of a body. A burden is a weight you were not made to carry, laid on you from outside, crushing and foreign. But your own body is a weight too, and you do not experience it as a burden, because it is the weight you were made to be, the weight that is you, the weight in which your life happens. The weight of the glory of God is like that. It is not a burden laid on us from outside but the weight we were made to bear, the substantiality we were created to hold, and to receive it is not to be crushed but to become, finally, solid, real, substantial, weighted, fully the kind of being we were made to be. The lightness of the nice god feels easier only because we have grown used to being thin, and we have mistaken our thinness for freedom, when it is really only emptiness, the hollowness of a creature made for glory and settling for froth.

There is a discipline in learning to bear weight, and I have to be honest about it, because the recovery of the capacity for glory is

not instantaneous and it is not painless. A creature that has spent its life fleeing weight, skimming the surface, avoiding everything difficult and heavy and demanding, has grown weak in exactly the muscles that bearing glory requires, and those muscles must be rebuilt, and the rebuilding is hard, the way rebuilding any atrophied strength is hard. It hurts to begin bearing weight again after a life of lightness. The first encounters with the weighty God are overwhelming precisely because we have let ourselves grow so thin that even a little of his glory feels crushing, feels like more than we can bear, sends us reaching for the nice god to make the weight stop. But this is the pain of a muscle being rebuilt, not the pain of a burden being imposed, and if we will endure it, if we will let the weight of God begin to work on us, we will find that we grow stronger, that we can bear more, that the glory which once overwhelmed us becomes the glory in which we live, until we become, by grace and over time, the kind of beings who can stand in the full weight of God and not be crushed but sustained, held up by the very weight we once fled.

This is the destiny the Scriptures hold out to us, and it is a destiny of weight, not of lightness, of glory, not of comfort, of substance, not of ease. We shall be like him, John writes, for we shall see him as he is, and the seeing him as he is, the beholding of the full weight of his glory, will not crush us then but complete us, because we will have been made, through all the weight-bearing of this life and the perfecting of the next, into beings substantial enough to hold it. That is what we are being prepared for. Every encounter with the weighty God in this life, every time his glory presses on us and we feel we cannot bear it, every painful stretching of our capacity for weight, is preparation for that, is the slow strengthening of a creature being made able to bear the unbearable weight of glory it was created for. The nice god prepares us for nothing, because he asks us to bear

nothing, and a creature that has borne nothing will be unable to bear the glory when it comes. But the holy God, the God of kavod, the God of weight, is preparing us, through every heavy thing, to become at last what we were made to be, the weight-bearing, glory-carrying, substantial beings who can stand in the full blaze of his presence and not be undone but glorified. We were made for weight. Do not flee it. It is the shape of your true self, waiting to be filled.

Chapter Twenty-Five: What the Nice God Cannot Forgive

I want to return, near the end, to the matter of forgiveness, because it is where the whole argument of this book comes to its sharpest point, and because I have discovered, in years of pastoral work, that the failure of the nice god shows up most cruelly right here, at the place where wounded people come looking to be free of their guilt and find that the god they have been given cannot actually set them free. This is not an abstract theological problem. It is a matter of souls in agony, of people carrying real guilt for real wrongs, coming to the church for the one thing the church is supposed to be able to offer, which is forgiveness, and receiving instead the cheap and weightless pardon of the nice god, and walking away still bound, still guilty, still carrying the weight they came to lay down. The nice god cannot forgive, not really, not the deep guilt that actually torments the human conscience, and I have to explain why, because the reason cuts to the heart of everything.

A forgiveness that costs nothing convinces no one, and the guilt that a cheap pardon cannot lift is the guilt that was crushing you in the first place.

The nice god, having no holiness that was ever violated, having no wrath that ever needed to be satisfied, having no cost that ever needed to be paid, can only offer a forgiveness that is really just an overlooking, a letting-go, a decision not to make a big deal of it. And for small guilt, for the minor and forgettable failures, this

might be enough. But the human conscience, when it is truly awakened, is not troubled by small guilt. It is troubled by real guilt, by the genuine wrongs we have done, the betrayals, the cruelties, the words that wounded and the deeds that cannot be undone, the actual weight of an actual life lived in actual failure. And to that guilt, the guilt that truly torments, the nice god's overlooking is worse than useless, because the conscience knows, at a level below argument, that what it has done was real, that it deserves more than an overlooking, that a mere decision not to make a big deal of it does not touch the actual debt. The tormented conscience cannot believe a forgiveness that costs nothing, because it knows that its sin was not nothing, and a forgiveness proportioned to nothing cannot answer a guilt proportioned to everything. The nice god's cheap pardon slides right off the real wound, and the person walks away still bleeding, now with the added despair of having been offered a cure that did not reach the disease.

I have sat with this agony many times, and one occasion has stayed with me, and I will tell it carefully. A man came to me carrying a guilt so heavy he could barely speak of it, a real wrong, a genuine betrayal that had done genuine damage to people he loved, years in the past but not diminished by the years, grown heavier if anything, a stone he had carried so long that he had forgotten what it was to stand upright. And he had been to churches, and he had been told, in the language of the nice god, that God loved him, that God accepted him, that he should stop being so hard on himself, that God did not want him to feel guilty, that he should let it go and move on. And none of it had touched him, and he came to me half in despair, because if even the church could not lift this, then perhaps nothing could, perhaps he was condemned to carry it forever. And I realized, sitting with him, that the problem was not that he needed to hear

more of the nice god. The problem was that he had heard only the nice god, and the nice god could not help him, because the nice god's forgiveness was too cheap to touch a guilt that heavy. What he needed was the holy God, and the costly forgiveness only the holy God can offer, and I had to give him not less weight but more.

So I did not tell him to stop feeling guilty. I told him, instead, that his guilt was real, that the wrong he had done was genuinely wrong, that the weight he felt was not a neurotic exaggeration but an accurate perception of a real debt, that his conscience was not malfunctioning but working correctly, that he had in fact sinned against a holy God and against the people that God loves, and that the weight was the true weight of a true wrong. And I watched something happen in his face as I said it, a kind of relief, strange as that sounds, the relief of finally being taken seriously, of having his guilt honored as real rather than waved away as excessive. And then, only then, having established the reality and the weight of the guilt, I told him about the cross, about the holy God who did not wave the guilt away but bore it, absorbed it, paid it, took the full weight of that real wrong into his own body and answered it in full, so that the debt he could never pay had been paid, not overlooked, not minimized, not waved away, but paid, in blood, by God himself. And that he could believe, because it did not ask him to pretend his sin was small. It declared his sin enormous and declared it fully answered. The costly forgiveness reached the wound the cheap forgiveness could not touch, precisely because it was costly, precisely because it took the guilt as seriously as the conscience did and then dealt with it at a cost equal to its weight.

This is the great secret that the sentimental age has lost, and it is the secret that could set a million tormented consciences free if

the church would recover it. The forgiveness that heals is not the forgiveness that minimizes the sin but the forgiveness that pays for it. The tormented conscience does not need to be told its guilt is not real. It needs to be told that its real guilt has been really paid for. And only the holy God can offer that, because only the holy God took the guilt seriously enough to pay for it, and only a forgiveness with a cross behind it, a forgiveness that cost God his Son, is heavy enough to answer a guilt that is genuinely heavy. The nice god offers a light forgiveness for a light sin, and it fails the moment the sin turns out to be heavy. The holy God offers an infinitely costly forgiveness for an infinitely serious sin, and it succeeds precisely where the conscience is most desperate, because it meets the full weight of the guilt with the full weight of the cross, and the two weights answer each other, and the conscience, at last, can rest.

And here is the final turn, the thing that makes the holy God not merely the more accurate God but the more merciful one, more merciful by far than the nice god who wears the clothing of mercy. The nice god's cheap forgiveness leaves people in their guilt, unable to believe a pardon too light to be trusted, and there is nothing merciful about that, whatever it calls itself. The holy God's costly forgiveness sets people free, actually free, free of guilt that no other forgiveness could lift, and that is mercy, real mercy, the deepest mercy there is. So when I say that God is not nice, I am not saying that he is less merciful than the nice god. I am saying that he is infinitely more merciful, that his refusal to offer cheap grace is itself the deepest mercy, because it is the only thing that could ever actually set a guilty soul free. The nice god is cruel in his kindness, leaving people bound with a pardon that cannot free them. The holy God is kind in his severity, taking sin so seriously that he pays for it in full, and in the paying, lifting a weight that nothing else in the universe could

lift. That is the forgiveness the tormented conscience is dying for. It is not offered by the god who says your sin does not matter. It is offered by the God who says your sin matters so much that I died for it, and it is finished, and you are free. That God is not nice. He is the only one who can forgive.

Chapter Twenty-Six: The Sovereignty We Fled

I have written about the wrath of God and the holiness of God and the jealousy of God, but I have not yet confronted directly the attribute of God that the sentimental age fears more than any of them, the attribute that empties churches faster than any doctrine and that even robust believers quietly set aside, and it is the sovereignty of God, the plain biblical teaching that God rules over all things, that nothing happens outside his will, that he works all things according to the counsel of his own will, that he is not a spectator in his universe but its King, exercising a governance so total that not a sparrow falls to the ground apart from him. This is the doctrine we have fled hardest of all, and I understand the fleeing, because the sovereignty of God, pressed to its full extent, raises questions so terrible that whole libraries have been written trying to answer them, and I will not pretend to answer them here. But I have to insist that we cannot flee this doctrine without fleeing the God who teaches it, and that in fleeing it we have lost, once again, the very thing that could have saved us.

A God who is only sometimes in charge is a God who is never quite trustworthy, because you can never be sure this is not one of the times he has lost control.

The nice god is not fully sovereign, and this is a defining feature of him, though we rarely state it so baldly. The nice god does his best, wishes us well, is on our side, but he does not exactly rule,

does not exactly govern the catastrophe, is not exactly Lord over the diagnosis and the accident and the loss. When bad things happen, the nice god is imagined to be as surprised as we are, as grieved, as helpless, standing beside us in our suffering but not over it, a fellow victim of a world that has somehow gotten out of his control. And we have found this comforting, because it lets us off the terrible hook of the sovereignty of God, lets us avoid the unbearable question of why a God who could have prevented our suffering did not. If God is not fully in charge, then he is not responsible, and if he is not responsible, then we do not have to face the dreadful mystery of a good and sovereign God who permits terrible things. The nice god is, in part, a flight from that mystery, a god constructed precisely so that we will never have to ask the hardest question, and we have found his impotence more comfortable than the sovereignty we could not understand.

But consider what we have given up in fleeing the sovereignty of God, because it is everything. A god who is not sovereign over your suffering is a god who cannot use your suffering, cannot weave it into any purpose, cannot promise that it will work for your good, cannot assure you that it means anything at all. If your suffering caught God by surprise, if it happened outside his will, in a corner of the universe that had slipped his control, then it is simply meaningless, a random catastrophe in a world God is not fully governing, and no good can be promised to come from it because no one was in charge of it. The impotent god, the nice god who does not rule the catastrophe, can weep with you but he cannot redeem your suffering, because redemption requires sovereignty, requires a God who was over the suffering and can bring good out of it, requires the very lordship we fled. When Joseph says to the brothers who sold him into slavery, you meant it for evil, but God meant it for good, he is confessing the

sovereignty of God over the worst thing that ever happened to him, and it is precisely that sovereignty that lets him find meaning in his suffering rather than mere horror. Flee the sovereignty and you flee the possibility that your suffering means anything, and you are left with the nice god who feels bad about your meaningless pain and can do nothing to redeem it because he was never in charge of it in the first place.

I know the objection, and I feel it myself, and I will not pretend it away. If God is sovereign over my suffering, then God permitted my suffering, and a God who permitted my suffering seems harder to love than a god who merely failed to prevent it. This is the terrible edge of the doctrine, and I will not dull it, because dulling it is how we got the nice god. But I want to point to something the sufferers themselves have discovered, again and again, across the centuries, which is that the sovereign God, terrible as he is, is more comforting in the end than the impotent one, because only the sovereign God can be trusted with the suffering he permitted. This is the paradox that the book of Job embodies and that I have watched play out at a hundred bedsides. The God who was in charge of your suffering is the God who can be trusted to have had a purpose in it, even a purpose you cannot see, and a suffering that is inside the purpose of a good and sovereign God, however painful, is not meaningless, and meaning, even hidden meaning, even meaning you must take on trust, is more bearable than the sheer randomness of a pain that no one governed. The sovereignty of God is the guarantee that your suffering is not wasted, not random, not outside any purpose, but held, somehow, in the hands of a God who works all things, even this, even this unbearable thing, according to the counsel of a will that is good even when it is inscrutable.

There is a passage in the fiftieth chapter of Genesis and a passage in the eighth chapter of Romans that between them hold the whole of what I am trying to say, and I want to set them side by side. Joseph says, you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive. And Paul says, we know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose. All things. Not most things. Not the pleasant things. All things, including the evil that others mean against us, including the suffering that breaks us, including the losses that we cannot understand, all of it working together for good, not because the evil is good, it is not, but because the God who is sovereign over the evil is good, and can bring good even out of evil, can weave even the worst thread into a design whose beauty we may not see until the end, if we see it even then. This is a promise available only from the sovereign God. The nice god cannot make it, because the nice god does not govern all things, and a promise that all things work for good can only be made by a God who is Lord of all things. We fled the sovereignty and we lost the promise, and the promise was the very thing we most needed, the assurance that our suffering is not the last word, that it is held, that it means something, that it is working, even now, even invisibly, toward a good we cannot yet see.

And so I have had to come back to the sovereignty of God, not because it is easy, but because it is the only ground on which real hope can stand. I have had to stop fleeing the God who rules the catastrophe and start trusting him, and the trusting is hard, and it is not the trust of someone who has all his questions answered but the trust of someone who has decided that the character of God is more certain than the meaning of his own suffering. I do not understand why God permits what he permits. I have stood at gravesides and had no answer, and I have refused to give the

cheap answers that the sentimental age offers, the it was all for a reason and the God needed another angel and the everything happens for a purpose delivered in a tone that makes the mystery small. I do not make the mystery small. But I have come to rest, in the dark, on the sovereignty of a God whose character I have seen at the cross, and I reason that a God who would go to the cross for me is a God I can trust with the sufferings I cannot understand, that the God who was sovereign over the death of his own Son and brought the salvation of the world out of that darkest of all evils is a God who can be trusted to be sovereign over my smaller darknesses too, working them, somehow, toward a good I cannot yet see. That is not the nice god. The nice god offers sympathy and no sovereignty, and sympathy without sovereignty is despair with a kind face. The sovereign God offers something harder and infinitely better, a hope that holds, a promise that all things, even the unbearable things, are working toward good in the hands of a God who is good and who rules, and who will, in the end, wipe every tear away, and make even the suffering part of the glory.

Chapter Twenty-Seven: The Name Too Holy to Speak

There is a detail in the religion of ancient Israel that the sentimental age finds baffling and that I have come to see as one of the most instructive things in the whole of Scripture, and it is the treatment of the name of God, the personal name, the name revealed to Moses at the burning bush, the four Hebrew letters that we render, uncertainly, as Yahweh. The Israelites came to regard this name as so holy that they would not speak it aloud. When they came to it in the reading of the Scriptures, they would substitute another word, Adonai, Lord, so that the holy name itself would not pass casually through human lips. And we look at this practice, we casual moderns who toss the names of God around a thousand times a day, in our prayers and our sermons and our conversations and our exclamations, and we find it strange, excessive, superstitious even, the fearful scrupulosity of a primitive religion that had not yet learned how approachable God really is. But I have come to think that they understood something we have entirely lost, and that our casualness with the name of God is not a sign of our greater intimacy but a sign of our diminished awe.

We have used the name of God so often and so lightly that it has worn smooth in our mouths, and a name worn smooth is a name whose holiness we have handled away.

Think about what a name is, and why the treatment of a name matters. A name is not merely a label. In the ancient

understanding, and in truth, a name is a kind of access, a handle, a means of address and of relationship and even of power. To know someone's name is to be able to call them, to have a claim on their attention, to stand in a relationship with them. And the name of God, the personal name, is the astonishing gift of access to the Almighty, the means by which the creature may address the Creator, the handle by which the finite may lay hold of the infinite. And the ancient Israelites understood that such a gift is not to be treated casually, that to be given the name of God is to be given something of unspeakable holiness, and that to speak that name lightly, to toss it around, to let it pass through the lips without weight, is to profane the very access that makes relationship possible. Their refusal to speak the name was not a denial of intimacy but a guarding of it, a recognition that the most precious things are the ones we handle most carefully, that a gift of infinite value is dishonored by casual handling, and that the name of God, being the most valuable thing they possessed, deserved a reverence that our casual age cannot even comprehend.

And this connects directly to the commandment, the third of the ten, that we shall not take the name of the Lord our God in vain, a commandment we have shrunk down to a prohibition against a few crude expletives, which misses almost everything it means. To take the name of God in vain is to take it up emptily, to handle it without weight, to use it as though it were a light thing, a common thing, a thing of no particular holiness. And by that definition, the profanation of God's name is not primarily the sin of the man who curses. It is the sin of the church that has made the name of God common through relentless casual use, that has worn the holy name smooth through ten thousand weightless repetitions, that speaks of God and to God with a familiarity so unreflective that the name has ceased, in our mouths, to carry

any weight at all. I am the chief offender here, because I speak the name of God professionally, hundreds of times a week, in prayers and sermons and conversations and casual remarks, and I have to ask myself how many of those hundreds carried any real weight, any real awareness that I was handling the holiest thing in existence, and the honest answer shames me, because the name of God has become, in my constant handling of it, a tool of my trade, a word I use, a common thing, and I have taken it up emptily more times than I could ever count.

The sentimental age has a ready objection to all of this, and I want to face it, because it contains a truth that has been twisted into an error. The objection is that Jesus taught us to call God Abba, Father, an intimate and tender name, the name a small child uses, and that the whole movement of the gospel is toward greater intimacy with God, toward a boldness of access, toward a relationship so close that reverent distance would be a kind of unbelief. And this is true, gloriously true, and I would not diminish it. The veil is torn. We may come boldly. We may call the holy God our Father, our Abba, and mean it. But notice, once again, that intimacy is not the same as casualness, that boldness is not the same as flippancy, that the tender name Abba was taught by the same Jesus who fell on his face in the garden and who taught us to pray hallowed be thy name in the very same prayer where he taught us to say Father. Hallowed be thy name. Let your name be treated as holy. The prayer that gives us the intimate name in its first words gives us, in its next words, the plea that the name be hallowed, kept holy, treated with the weight it deserves. The intimacy and the reverence are held together in a single prayer, and only the sentimental age has managed to keep the intimacy and lose the reverence, to say Abba without ever saying hallowed, to claim the boldness while abandoning the awe.

I have begun, in my own devotional life, a small and difficult practice, and I offer it not as a technique but as a confession of my own need for repair, which is to slow down before I speak the name of God, to pause, however briefly, and to remember whose name I am about to take up, to refuse the automatic and weightless use that has become my habit and to handle the name, once again, as the holy thing it is. It is harder than it sounds. The habit of casualness runs deep, and I catch myself, again and again, tossing the name off without weight, using it as a filler, a common word, a tool. But when I manage it, when I actually pause and remember and speak the name of God with the weight it deserves, something happens, a small recovery of awe, a momentary return of the sense that I am dealing with the Holy One, the Ancient of Days, the God before whom the seraphim veil their faces. And I think that if the church would recover this, would learn again to handle the name of God with weight, to refuse the casual and the flippant, to hallow the name in our actual speech and not merely in our stated theology, we would find that a great deal of the awe we have lost would begin to return, because the way we handle the name of God shapes the way we hold the reality of God, and a name handled casually is a God held casually, and a God held casually is a God we have already reduced to something less than he is.

Because in the end the treatment of the name is a test of the treatment of the God, and the ancient Israelites, who would not speak the name, were not more distant from God than we are. They were more reverent, and their reverence was not the enemy of their relationship but the guardian of it, and we have thrown away the guardian and lost, along with it, much of the relationship it was guarding. We speak the name of God constantly, and we know God less than they did, and the two facts are connected, because the casualness that lets us speak the

name so freely is the same casualness that lets us hold the reality so lightly. I am not calling for a return to the practice of not speaking the name, which would be its own kind of superstition. I am calling for a recovery of the weight behind the practice, the awe that made them treat the name as holy, the reverence that we have lost. Hallowed be thy name. It is the first petition of the prayer our Lord taught us, and it comes before the requests for bread and forgiveness and deliverance, because the hallowing of the name, the treating of God as holy, is the foundation on which every other petition stands. We have skipped it. We have gone straight to the requests and left the hallowing behind. And a prayer life that has left the hallowing behind is a prayer life addressed to a God we have already made too small, a God whose name we take up emptily, a God we have profaned not with curses but with a familiarity that has forgotten how to tremble.

Chapter Twenty-Eight: When the Weight Returns

I have spent this whole book arguing that we must recover the weight of God, and I have written as though this recovery were something we could accomplish, a project we could undertake, a set of ideas we could adopt and thereby restore the holiness we have lost. But I have to end this stretch of the book by confessing the limit of everything I have said, because the truth is that we cannot recover the weight of God by wanting to, cannot argue ourselves into awe, cannot manufacture the *mysterium tremendum* by any technique or discipline or act of will. The weight of God, when it returns, returns as a gift, as a visitation, as a disclosure that we receive and do not achieve, and everything I have written in this book can at best clear the ground, remove the obstacles, prepare the soul, but it cannot summon the fire, because the fire is God's to give, and he gives it as he wills, and no one can command it.

You cannot decide to be awed. You can only stop resisting the awe, and wait, and when it comes, not flee it.

I want to describe what it is like when the weight returns, because I have known it, not often, not on command, but really, and I think that describing it may do more good than all my arguments, because the arguments can persuade the mind but only the thing itself can change the heart. There are moments, and they come unbidden, when the veil thins, when the buffered self is unexpectedly pierced, when the God I have been

discussing so professionally becomes, for a moment, terribly and gloriously real, and the whole comfortable apparatus of my managed faith falls away and I am left, like Isaiah, undone, aware of the immensity and the holiness and the sheer overwhelming reality of the God I had reduced to a subject. Sometimes it comes in worship, when the singing stops being performance and becomes, for a moment, actual adoration, and the room fills with a weight that no one manufactured. Sometimes it comes in solitude, in prayer, when the words run out and something vast presses in. Sometimes it comes in suffering, when the props are knocked away and the soul, stripped of its comforts, finds itself face to face with the God who was there all along behind the comforts. And sometimes it comes in the reading of the Word, when a passage I have read a hundred times suddenly opens and the God it describes steps out of the text and into the room, and I am undone by a book I thought I had mastered.

When it comes, the first thing it does is expose how small my managed God had become, and this is always a shock, because I had not known, until the real one appeared, how thoroughly I had reduced him. It is like the difference between remembering the ocean and standing before it. I can remember the ocean, can describe it, can hold in my mind a picture of it that is accurate as far as it goes. But the picture, however accurate, is nothing next to the reality, and the moment I stand before the actual ocean I realize that my picture had shrunk it, tamed it, reduced its vastness to something my mind could hold, and that the reality is immeasurably greater than the memory. So it is with God. My theology, my careful doctrine, my remembered God, is a picture, and it is accurate as far as it goes, but when the real God visits, when the weight returns, I realize how thoroughly the picture had shrunk him, how the God I carry around in my mind is to the

actual God as a photograph of the ocean is to the ocean, and I am humbled, and I am undone, and I am also, strangely, glad, because the smallness of my managed God had been starving me without my knowing it, and the return of the real one is like a starving man finally being fed.

And the second thing the returning weight does is reorder everything, instantly and without argument, putting back into their proper places all the things that my sentimental faith had gotten backward. In the presence of the weight of God, I do not have to be persuaded that I am a sinner. I simply see it, the way Isaiah saw it, the way you see your own dirtiness when you step into a shaft of sunlight. I do not have to be argued into worship. I simply worship, the way a struck bell rings, because worship is the involuntary response of a creature that has perceived its Creator. I do not have to work up reverence or manufacture awe or discipline myself into the fear of the Lord. All of it comes, unbidden and immediate, as the natural and inevitable response of a soul that has, for a moment, seen. This is the great secret that the sentimental age, with all its techniques and its efforts and its worship strategies, has entirely missed. You do not produce reverence and awe and worship and the fear of the Lord by working at them. You produce them by seeing God, and when you see God, they come by themselves, and when you do not see God, no amount of working at them will produce anything but a hollow imitation. The whole thing hangs on sight, and sight is a gift, and the gift is God's to give.

So what are we to do, if the weight returns as a gift we cannot command. Are we simply to wait passively, hoping the visitation comes. No, and this is the last practical thing I want to say, because there is a great deal we can do, not to summon the weight, which we cannot, but to prepare for it, to clear the

ground, to remove the obstacles that our sentimental habits have piled up between us and the God who wishes to disclose himself. We can stop actively resisting the weight, stop reaching for the nice god the moment the real one begins to overwhelm us, stop fleeing the passages and the experiences and the sufferings that would make us tremble. We can return to the Word and refuse to reduce it, can sit under the throne-room visions and the whirlwind and the consuming fire and let them do their work rather than explaining them into manageability. We can slow down, can guard our speech about God, can recover the practices of reverence that our casualness has abandoned, not because these practices produce the weight but because they prepare the soul to receive it when it comes. We can, above all, ask, can pray the dangerous prayer, show me your glory, knowing that it may be answered and that the answer will undo us, and wanting it anyway, because we have grown so tired of the small god and so hungry for the real one that we are willing, at last, to be undone.

And I have to end this chapter by admitting that I am still, most of the time, the man who prefers the small god, and that the weight, when it returns, does not stay, and that I find myself, again and again, in the flat and managed spaces between the visitations, reaching once more for the comfortable deity of my own construction. The recovery of the weight of God is not a single event after which everything is different forever. It is a lifelong contending, a repeated dying to the small god and a repeated receiving of the great one, a rhythm of visitation and flatness, of awe and forgetfulness, of the weight returning and the weight receding, and the whole art of the life of faith is to keep leaning toward the weight even in the flat seasons, to keep asking for the sight even when the sight has withdrawn, to keep refusing the small god even when the great one is not, at the moment, being felt. I fail at this constantly. But I have learned

that the flat seasons are not the end, that the weight returns, that the God who hid comes back, that the fire that seemed to have gone out flares up again when I least expect it, and that a life spent leaning toward the weight, even a life of much failure and much forgetfulness, is a life being slowly, painfully, gloriously reshaped by the God who is not nice, into a creature that can bear, at last, the weight of his glory.

Chapter Twenty-Nine: The God of the Prophets

If you want to meet the God who is not nice, and to meet him at his most uncomfortable, you go to the prophets, and I have been quoting them throughout this book, but I have not yet stopped to consider what it means that the God of Israel raised up a whole order of men whose entire vocation was to speak words that no one wanted to hear. This is itself a fact about God worth pondering. The nice god does not raise up prophets, because prophets say hard things, and the nice god does not say hard things, and so a religion of the nice god has no prophets, only affirmers, only encouragers, only voices that tell the people what they already want to hear. But the God of the Bible fills the Scriptures with prophets, with men who stood before kings and nations and priests and spoke words of judgment and warning and woe, words that got them beaten and imprisoned and sawn in two, words that made them the most hated men of their generation, and God kept sending them, century after century, because the God who is not nice loves his people too much to leave them comfortable in their destruction.

The measure of a prophet was never whether the people liked what he said. It was whether God had said it. We have forgotten there is a difference.

Walter Brueggemann, in that 1978 book *The Prophetic Imagination*, argued that the fundamental task of the prophet was to break the grip of what he called the royal consciousness, the

settled, comfortable, self-satisfied worldview of the established order, the consciousness that had made its peace with injustice and numbed itself to the suffering of the poor and convinced itself that things were basically fine. The prophet's job was to shatter that numbness, to make the comfortable uncomfortable, to grieve out loud over the wrongs that everyone else had agreed to ignore, and to announce the judgment of a holy God against a people who had grown fat and blind and cruel. And Brueggemann saw that the prophetic vocation was, above all, a vocation of grief, that the prophet felt the pain that the numbed society had anesthetized, felt it on behalf of God, and gave voice to a divine anguish over a people destroying themselves. The prophets are not primarily predictors of the future, though they sometimes are. They are primarily the ones who feel the weight of God's grief and God's anger over a people who have abandoned him, and who speak that weight into a society that has worked very hard not to feel it.

And here is the thing that the sentimental age cannot abide about the prophets, the thing that makes us skip their books or read them selectively, harvesting the comforting verses and averting our eyes from the rest. The prophets are relentlessly negative, by the standards of a culture that has made positivity the highest value. They thunder. They accuse. They grieve. They announce doom. Read Amos, who says that God hates and despises the religious festivals of a people who have trampled the poor, who says that their solemn assemblies are a stench in God's nostrils, who tells them that the day of the Lord they are longing for will be darkness and not light. Read Jeremiah, who wept, who was called to pluck up and to break down and to destroy and to overthrow before he was ever called to build and to plant, who spent forty years announcing a judgment that no one would believe until it fell. Read Ezekiel, who was made to perform the

strangest and most disturbing signs, who was told that the people would hear his words as a pleasant song and do nothing, who spoke to a rebellious house that would not listen. These are not comfortable men delivering comfortable messages. These are men crushed by the weight of a holy God's grief and anger, speaking words that scald, and God sent them on purpose, because the God who is not nice would rather wound his people with the truth than comfort them with a lie.

I have to ask myself, as a preacher, whether I have any of the prophet in me, or whether I have become entirely a creature of the royal consciousness, a chaplain to the comfortable, a voice that tells the people what they want to hear. And the honest answer terrifies me, because I know how much I want to be liked, how much I depend on the approval of the people I preach to, how the whole structure of my ministry, the giving and the attendance and the good opinion I need to survive, rewards me for saying comfortable things and punishes me for saying prophetic ones. The prophets were hated. They were not building large and thriving religious institutions. They were being thrown into cisterns and run out of town and killed. And I am building a large and thriving religious institution, and it is thriving in part because I have learned to say the comfortable thing, and I have to ask whether the very success of my ministry is evidence that I have abandoned the prophetic vocation, whether the applause I receive is the applause that Jesus warned about when he said, woe to you when all men speak well of you, for so their fathers did to the false prophets. The false prophets were the popular ones. The true prophets were hated. And I am popular, and it keeps me awake.

Because the false prophets, in every age, are the prophets of the nice god, and this is a connection I cannot avoid making,

because it runs right through the heart of everything this book is about. The false prophets of ancient Israel were not the ones who denied God. They were the ones who said, peace, peace, when there was no peace, who healed the wound of the people lightly, who prophesied smooth things, who told the kings and the nation what they wanted to hear and called it the word of the Lord. They preached a nice god, an affirming god, a god who was pleased with Israel and had no judgment in store, a god who would never let the comfortable predictions fail, and they were wildly popular, and they were completely false, and the judgment they said would never come, came. The true prophets, by contrast, preached the holy God, the God of terrible judgment and terrible mercy, and they were hated for it, and they were vindicated by history, because the God they preached was real and the god the false prophets preached was a comfortable fiction that shattered against reality. And I look at the religious landscape of my own comfortable land, full of voices preaching a nice god, an affirming god, a god who wants us happy and successful and comfortable, voices that are wildly popular and fill enormous rooms, and I cannot help hearing the false prophets of Jeremiah's day, saying peace, peace, when there is no peace, healing the wound of the people lightly, and I tremble, because I know how easily I could become one of them, how much of me already is.

So the recovery of the God who is not nice is, among everything else, the recovery of the prophetic word, the willingness to say the hard thing, the true thing, the unwelcome thing, because God has said it, and not to trim it to fit the appetite of a comfortable people. This is costly, and I will not pretend otherwise, and I am not sure I have the courage for it, because the cost is real, the cost is the loss of the approval I have built my life on. But I am increasingly sure that the alternative is worse, that a church with

no prophetic voice is a church that has abandoned its people to their destruction with a smile, that a preacher who only comforts is a false prophet however kind his intentions, and that the love of God for his people is a love fierce enough to wound them with the truth rather than soothe them with a lie. The prophets loved Israel. That is the thing we forget when we recoil from their harshness. They loved Israel enough to be hated by Israel, enough to grieve and thunder and weep and warn, enough to say the unbearable thing because it was true and because the truth, however painful, was the only thing that could save. That is the love of the God who is not nice, the love that would rather wound with truth than comfort with falsehood, and it is the love that the church, if it is to be the church, must recover, whatever it costs, however much it empties the room, however much it makes us hated by the very people we are trying, at the cost of our own comfort, to love.

Chapter Thirty: The Danger of the Familiar

There is a peculiar danger that afflicts those of us who have spent long years in the faith, who know the Scriptures well, who can discuss theology fluently, who have been Christians so long that the whole thing has become familiar, and it is a danger that the new convert and the seeker do not face in the same way, and I have to write about it because I am squarely inside it and because it may be the single greatest obstacle to the recovery of the weight of God in a mature believer's life. The danger is familiarity. The danger is that the holy things, handled long enough, stop being holy in our hands, that the truths that once undid us become the truths we can recite in our sleep, that the God who once terrified and thrilled us becomes the God we have, in a sense, gotten used to, and that our very knowledge of him becomes the veil that hides him from us. It is a strange and terrible thing that the closer we get to God in one sense, the more thoroughly we may lose him in another, that familiarity with the things of God can become the enemy of the fear of God, that we can know so much about him that we forget to tremble before him.

The gravest danger to the soul is not ignorance of God. It is familiarity with God, the slow death of awe under the weight of routine.

I see this most clearly in myself, because I handle the holy things professionally, and there is no faster route to familiarity than

professional handling. The surgeon becomes accustomed to the body opened on the table, the mortician to the face of death, the pastor to the presence of God, and the accustoming is necessary in a sense, is even a mercy, because a surgeon who fainted at every incision could not operate and a pastor who was undone by every mention of God could not function. But there is a cost, and the cost is real, and for the pastor the cost is the gravest of all, because the thing we grow accustomed to is not a body or a corpse but the living God, and to grow accustomed to the living God is to lose, by slow degrees, the very awe that makes us able to know him truly. I have preached on the holiness of God so many times that I can do it competently without feeling it at all. I have described the throne room of Isaiah so often that I can walk a congregation through the smoke and the seraphim and the shaking doorposts while my own heart remains entirely unmoved, a tour guide pointing at a fire he has stopped feeling. This is the occupational hazard of my calling, and it is a hazard to the soul, and I do not always escape it, and sometimes I do not even notice I have fallen into it until the flatness of my own preaching wakes me to the flatness of my own heart.

But this danger is not the pastor's alone. It belongs to every believer who has been in the faith long enough for it to become routine, and that is most of us, and the symptoms are worth naming so that we can recognize them in ourselves. The chief symptom is boredom, the quiet, unadmitted boredom that creeps into a long-familiar faith, the sense that we have heard it all before, that the sermons cover ground we have covered a hundred times, that the Scriptures hold no more surprises, that we have, in some sense, finished learning about God and are now simply maintaining a knowledge already complete. This boredom is a symptom of a diseased familiarity, and it is a lie, because we have not finished learning about God, we have not

exhausted him, we have not reached the end of his immensity, we have simply grown so accustomed to our small and manageable picture of him that we have mistaken the exhaustion of the picture for the exhaustion of the reality. The boredom is not evidence that there is nothing more to see. It is evidence that we have stopped seeing, that our eyes have glazed over, that familiarity has drawn a film across our vision so that the God who is infinitely worth beholding has become, to our dulled sight, a familiar object we have grown tired of looking at.

The second symptom is presumption, the loss of the sense that our access to God is a staggering gift and its replacement by the assumption that it is simply our due, that of course we can approach God, of course we can call on him, of course the door is open, as though the tearing of the veil that gave us access had cost nothing, as though the blood that purchased our boldness were a mere formality, as though the right to come before the holy God were a thing we had always had and would always have and need never marvel at. The new convert marvels. The new convert cannot believe that he, of all people, is permitted to come before God, weeps at the wonder of it, approaches the throne with trembling gratitude. And the long-familiar believer strides in, presumes upon the access, treats the throne room like his own living room, and has lost, without noticing, the wonder that made the access precious. Presumption is familiarity's child, and it is a form of contempt, a taking for granted of the most precious gift in the universe, and it afflicts the mature believer precisely because the maturity has bred a familiarity that has bred a presumption that has quietly emptied the gift of its wonder.

How do we fight this, we who are familiar, we who have handled the holy things so long that they have stopped being holy in our hands. And I have to be honest that I do not have a reliable cure,

because the very familiarity that is the disease resists every remedy, absorbs every fresh insight into the same tired categories, turns even the effort to recover awe into one more familiar routine. But I have found a few things that help, and I offer them as one struggling patient to another. It helps to seek out the new convert, to spend time with those for whom the faith is fresh and staggering, and to let their wonder rebuke and reawaken my own, because there is nothing like the sight of someone encountering for the first time what I have grown numb to, to remind me how astonishing it actually is. It helps to return to the parts of Scripture I understand least, the passages that still resist my mastery, the mysteries I cannot reduce, because familiarity feeds on mastery and starves on mystery, and the parts of God I cannot get my mind around are the parts most likely to restore my awe. And it helps, above all, to confess the familiarity itself, to name it before God as the sin it has become, to ask him to break through the film that my long knowledge of him has drawn across my sight, to pray the dangerous prayer that he would make himself strange to me again, unfamiliar, overwhelming, new, that he would undo the deadly accustoming and let me see him, for a moment, as if for the first time.

Because the great irony, the thing that should frighten every one of us who has been long in the faith, is that it is possible to know a great deal about God and to have lost God, to be an expert on a fire we have stopped being warmed by, to hold every right doctrine while worshipping, in the actual traffic of the heart, a familiar idol that our knowledge has slowly substituted for the living God. The Pharisees knew the Scriptures better than anyone alive, and they crucified the God the Scriptures were about, because their knowledge had become a familiarity and their familiarity had become a blindness and their blindness had become a hatred of the very glory they thought they were

defending. That is the terminal stage of the disease, and it began where I am, with knowledge, with familiarity, with the handling of holy things until they stopped being holy. I am closer to the Pharisee than I am comfortable admitting, and every mature believer is, and the recovery of the weight of God requires, for us, not the accumulation of more knowledge, of which we have plenty, but the shattering of the familiarity that our knowledge has bred, the breaking through of the living God past the film of our long acquaintance, the terrible mercy of being made to see, again, as strange and overwhelming and holy, the God we thought we knew.

Chapter Thirty-One: The Comfort on the Far Side of Fear

I want to gather up, near the very end, the promise that has been running underneath this whole book like a river under stone, the promise that the God who is not nice is not only the truer God and the greater God but, in the end, the more comforting God, the only God who can actually give us what the nice god merely pretended to offer. I have said this in pieces throughout, in the chapters on suffering and on forgiveness and on the God of the whirlwind, but I want to say it now as a whole, because if you take nothing else from this book I want you to take this. The comfort you have been seeking from the nice god was never available from the nice god. It is available only on the far side of the fear of the holy one, and the fear you have been fleeing is the very doorway to the comfort you have been craving, and you cannot reach the comfort except through the fear, and the fear, terrible as it is, is the price and the pathway of a comfort that actually holds.

The comfort that skips the fear is a comfort that will not hold. The only comfort that holds is the one you reach by walking through the fear and out the other side.

Consider the disciples in the boat, in the storm, when Jesus was asleep, and they woke him in terror, sure they were going to drown, and he stood and rebuked the wind and the waves, and there was a great calm. And notice what happens next, because it is the thing we always skip. The text says they were filled with

great fear, and they said to one another, who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him. They were afraid of the storm, and Jesus took away the storm, and then they were more afraid than before, not of the storm but of him, of the one who could command the storm, of the terrible power that had been sleeping in their boat. The removal of the small fear revealed the great fear. The calming of the storm they could understand gave way to the terror of the God they could not. And here is the point. Their comfort, their actual safety, was located precisely in the thing that now terrified them. The power that frightened them was the power that saved them. The one they now feared was the one in whose boat they were safest of all. Their new fear of Jesus was not the opposite of their comfort. It was the ground of it, because a Lord terrible enough to command the sea is a Lord powerful enough to keep you through any storm, and the fear of that Lord and the comfort of that Lord are the same thing, felt from the inside of the boat he is keeping.

This is the pattern of all real comfort, and it is the exact reverse of what the sentimental age teaches. The sentimental age teaches that comfort is the absence of fear, that to be comforted is to be soothed out of our fear, that the comforting god is the god who removes the fear and leaves us at ease. But the God of the Bible comforts by a stranger and deeper route. He does not remove the fear by making himself small and safe and unfrightening. He transforms the fear by revealing that the terrible power we feared is the very power that holds us, that the God whose greatness overwhelms us is the God whose greatness protects us, that the fear of the Lord, far from being the opposite of comfort, is the doorway into a comfort so deep and so unshakable that no storm can reach it. The person who fears the Lord rightly is the person who is finally beyond the reach of every lesser fear, because he has located his safety in a power greater than everything that

could threaten him, and a soul anchored to omnipotence is a soul that has nothing left to be afraid of. Fear the Lord, and you will fear nothing else. Refuse to fear the Lord, cling to the nice god who asks for no fear, and you will find yourself at the mercy of a thousand lesser fears, because you have anchored your safety to a god too small to hold you.

I have watched this reversal play out in the lives of the people I have pastored, and it is one of the most beautiful things I have ever seen, the moment when a soul stops fleeing the fear of God and walks through it into the comfort on the far side. It usually happens in suffering, because suffering is what strips away the nice god and forces the choice, and I have watched people arrive at the edge of the fear of God, the terrible awareness of his sovereignty over their catastrophe, the frightening recognition that the God they had thought was safe is in fact the Lord of the very thing destroying them. And I have watched some of them flee, retreat back into the nice god, insist that God could not have willed this, that he is as helpless as they are, that he is only a fellow sufferer, and I have watched that flight leave them without comfort, because a helpless god cannot comfort a helpless sufferer. And I have watched others walk through the fear, submit to the terrible sovereignty, say with Job though he slay me yet will I trust him, and I have watched them come out the other side into a comfort that the fleers never found, the comfort of resting the whole weight of an unbearable suffering on a God great enough to hold it, the peace that passes understanding, the calm on the far side of the storm and the far side of the fear. The comfort was always there, but it was on the far side of the fear, and only those who walked through the fear ever reached it.

This is why I cannot preach the nice god, though he is easier to preach and easier to hear, because the nice god offers a comfort

that stops short of the fear and therefore stops short of the comfort, a soothing that never reaches the depths where real comfort is needed. The nice god says, do not be afraid, God is not frightening, God is safe, God is nice, and he leaves the sufferer in a shallow ease that shatters the moment the suffering deepens. The holy God says something harder and infinitely better. He says, yes, I am frightening, yes, my power is terrible, yes, I am the Lord of the storm and the sovereign of your suffering, and you are right to tremble before me, and now, having trembled, having seen how great I am, rest, because the God who is great enough to frighten you is great enough to hold you, and the power that overwhelms you is the power that will carry you through the valley of the shadow of death and out the other side into a joy that no fear can touch. That is comfort. It is not the removal of fear but its transformation, not the shrinking of God but the resting of the whole self on a God great enough to be feared and therefore great enough to be trusted, and it is the only comfort that holds, and it is available only from the God who is not nice.

So I plead with you, at the end of this stretch of the book, to stop fleeing the fear, because in fleeing the fear you are fleeing the comfort, and the comfort is what you actually want, and it is on the far side of the fear, and there is no other way to it. Walk through the fear. Let the holy God be as terrible as he is. Let yourself tremble before his sovereignty and his holiness and his overwhelming greatness, and do not run to the nice god to make the trembling stop, because the trembling is the doorway, and on the far side of the trembling is a comfort so deep that it will hold you when everything else gives way, a peace that the world cannot give and cannot take away, the rest of a soul that has anchored itself, at last, to a God great enough to be feared and therefore great enough to be trusted with everything, including

the storm, including the suffering, including the fear itself. The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom, and it is also the beginning of comfort, the only comfort that holds, the comfort on the far side of the fear, waiting for everyone with the courage to walk through the trembling and out into the great calm of the God who is not nice.

Chapter Thirty-Two: The Grace That Grows the Fear

There is a final objection I have to answer before I can bring this book to its close, and it is the objection that the whole New Testament seems, at first glance, to raise against everything I have written, and I would be dishonest to end without facing it squarely. The objection is this. Does not the coming of Christ change all of it. Does not the New Covenant replace the terror of Sinai with the grace of Calvary, the trembling mountain with the open arms, the consuming fire with the gentle Shepherd. Have we not been given perfect love, and does not perfect love cast out fear, as the apostle John himself declares. Is not the whole movement of the gospel from fear to love, from the God who terrified Israel to the God who invites us to call him Abba, so that to keep insisting on the fear of the Lord after the cross is to drag us backward, to un-Christian the gospel, to rebuild the very wall that Christ tore down. This is a serious objection, made by serious people, and I have to answer it, because if it stands, my whole book falls.

Grace does not abolish the fear of God. Grace deepens it, because grace shows you at what cost you are held, and the cost is the measure of the holiness.

Here is my answer, and it is the hinge on which everything turns. Grace does not remove the fear of God. Grace transforms it, deepens it, and makes it, if anything, greater than before, and I will show you why from the very texts that seem to argue against

me. Yes, perfect love casts out fear, and John means it, but consider what fear he means. He means the fear of punishment, the cringing dread of the condemned, the terror of the one who does not know whether he is loved and lives in dread of judgment. That fear, the fear of the slave who does not know his master's heart, is indeed cast out by the perfect love revealed at the cross, and thank God for it, because it was a torment and it is gone. But that was never the fear of the Lord that the Scriptures call the beginning of wisdom. The fear of the Lord is not the cringing dread of the condemned. It is the reverent awe of the beloved child, and that fear is not cast out by love but deepened by it, because the more you know you are loved by the holy God, the more astonished you are at the holiness of the God who loves you, and the more you tremble, not with the dread of punishment, but with the awe of being held by a love so vast and so holy that it went to the cross to have you.

Consider what the cross actually reveals about the holiness of God, because this is the point the objection misses entirely. The sentimental reading of the cross says that the cross shows how nice God is, how he was willing to overlook our sin, how his love is so great that judgment simply melted away before it. But the true reading of the cross says the opposite. The cross shows how holy God is, how seriously he takes sin, how impossible it was for him simply to overlook our guilt, how the barrier between us and him was so absolute that only the death of the Son of God could remove it. The cross does not show that God's holiness was less than we feared. It shows that his holiness was greater than we ever imagined, so great that our forgiveness cost him everything, so great that the removal of our sin required the blood of God. And this means that the cross, rightly understood, does not diminish the fear of the Lord but magnifies it, because the cross is the ultimate revelation of exactly how holy God is,

exactly how much our sin demanded, exactly how terrible the fire that had to fall. The person who has truly seen the cross fears God more, not less, because he has seen at what unimaginable cost his access was purchased, and the cost is the measure of the holiness, and the holiness is the ground of the fear.

This is why the New Testament, far from abolishing the fear of God, actually intensifies it, and I pointed to this earlier in the consuming fire but it deserves to be gathered up here. It is the New Testament, not the Old, that says our God is a consuming fire, and says it to Christians. It is the New Testament that tells us to work out our salvation with fear and trembling. It is the New Testament that warns us not to refuse him who is speaking, that reminds us it is a fearful thing to fall into the hands of the living God, that tells us to conduct ourselves with fear throughout the time of our exile, knowing that we were ransomed not with silver or gold but with the precious blood of Christ. The ransom is the ground of the fear. Precisely because we were bought at such a price, precisely because our access cost the blood of God, we are to hold that access with fear and trembling, with reverence and awe, never casually, never presumptuously, never as though it were cheap. The grace that saved us is a costly grace, and the costliness of the grace is the measure of the holiness of the God who paid it, and the holiness of God is the ground of a fear that grace does not remove but deepens, transfigures, and fills with love, until the fear and the love are, once again, the same fire.

I have to confess that I spent years reading the gospel as the abolition of the fear of God, and I read it that way because I wanted to, because the fear of God was uncomfortable and the gospel gave me, or so I thought, permission to be rid of it. I took the tearing of the veil as an invitation to casualness, the open

arms of the Father as license to presume, the grace of Christ as the end of the trembling that Sinai had demanded. And I preached it that way, preached a gospel that was really the enthronement of the nice god, a Christ who had come to make God safe, a cross that had turned the consuming fire into a warm glow. And it was only when I began to see the cross for what it actually is, the most terrible display of the holiness of God ever given, the fire falling on the Son so that it would not fall on me, that I understood how completely I had gotten it backward, how the grace I had used to diminish the fear was in fact the very thing that should have deepened it beyond anything Sinai could produce. Sinai showed the holiness of God in thunder and smoke and a trembling mountain. The cross showed the holiness of God in the blood of his Son, and the cross is the greater revelation, and the fear it should produce is the greater fear, a fear now full of love, but no less a fear, a trembling now full of gratitude, but no less a trembling, the awe of a soul that has seen exactly what its salvation cost the holy God.

So the objection fails, and it fails in the most beautiful way, because it turns out that the coming of Christ does not give us a nicer God but shows us how much more than nice the true God has always been, how his love was never the thin sentiment we imagined but a holy love fierce enough to bear the cross, how his grace was never cheap but the costliest thing in the universe, how the fear of the Lord is not abolished by the gospel but fulfilled by it, deepened by it, filled with love and gratitude and wonder by it, and raised to a pitch of awe that the trembling Israelites at the foot of the mountain never reached, because they saw the holiness of God in fire and smoke, and we have seen it in the blood of the Son of God, poured out for us, so that we, who deserved the fire, might be held forever in the arms of the God who is not nice, the God who is holy, the God whose love and

whose holiness and whose fear are, at the cross, revealed to be one glorious and terrible and tender fire, the fire we were made to dwell in, the fire that will be our home and our joy and our worship forever.

Chapter Thirty-Three: The God Who Is Free

There is one more thing I have to say about the God who is not nice, and it may be the hardest of all for the modern soul to receive, harder even than the wrath and the jealousy and the consuming fire, because it strikes at the deepest assumption of the sentimental age, the assumption that God exists for us. The thing I have to say is that God is free. He is not obligated to us. He did not have to make us and he does not have to keep us and he owes us nothing, and his love, when he gives it, is not the payment of a debt or the fulfillment of an obligation but the free overflow of a fullness that needed nothing from us and would have been perfectly and infinitely happy without us. This is the doctrine the theologians call the aseity of God, his self-existence, his complete independence, the fact that he is from himself and needs nothing outside himself, and it is a doctrine the sentimental age cannot abide, because the sentimental age has built its entire theology on the assumption that God needs us, wants us, is somehow incomplete without us, exists in some sense for the sake of his relationship with us.

God did not make you because he was lonely. He made you out of a fullness that needed nothing, and that is why his love for you is a gift and not a transaction.

Consider how much of our popular theology quietly assumes that God needs us. We say that God was lonely and made us for companionship. We say that God's heart aches for us, longs for

us, is somehow incomplete until we come to him. We sing songs that portray a God pining for our love, waiting anxiously for our response, a God whose happiness depends on our reciprocation. And there is a grain of truth buried in all of this, because God does love us and does desire us and is not indifferent to whether we come to him. But the way we say it makes God small, makes him needy, makes him dependent on us, and a needy God, a God who requires us to complete him, is not the God of the Bible but a projection of our own need for significance, a God we have made in the image of our own emptiness. The God of the Bible is not empty. He is full, infinitely and eternally full, the three persons of the Trinity dwelling in a communion of love so complete that it lacked nothing, needed nothing, wanted for nothing, before ever a world was made. God did not make us because he was lonely. The Father, the Son, and the Spirit were never lonely, never incomplete, never in need of anything we could supply. God made us out of the overflow of a fullness, not the ache of an emptiness, and this changes everything about how we understand his love.

Because if God needed us, then his love for us would be, at bottom, a kind of self-interest, a reaching out to fill his own emptiness, a love that loved us for what we could give him. But if God did not need us, if he was already infinitely full and infinitely happy without us, then his love for us is something far greater and far more astonishing, a love that is pure gift, pure grace, pure overflow, a love that wanted us not because it needed us but simply because it is the nature of that infinite fullness to give, to create, to love, to pour itself out. The love of a needy God is a diminished love, because it is love that gets something back, love that fills a lack, love with a self-interested motive however hidden. The love of the free God, the God who needs nothing, is love in its purest form, love that could gain nothing

from us because it already had everything, love that reached out to us for no reason but the sheer generosity of a fullness that delights to give. When you understand that God did not need you, you understand for the first time how freely you are loved, how purely, how graciously, because a love that needed you would be partly about the lover's need, and a love that needed nothing is entirely about you, entirely gift, entirely grace.

This is why the freedom of God, terrible as it first appears, is the ground of the deepest security a soul can know, and here the doctrine turns from cold to warm in a way that only the holy God can accomplish. Think about it. If God loved you because he needed you, then your security in his love would depend on your remaining useful to him, on your continuing to supply the thing he needed, and the moment you failed to supply it, the moment you became a burden rather than a benefit, his love would have reason to fade. A love based on need is a love you can lose by ceasing to meet the need. But the love of the free God, the God who needs nothing from you, is a love you cannot lose by failing him, because it was never based on your usefulness in the first place. He did not love you for what you gave him, since you gave him nothing he lacked, and so you cannot forfeit his love by failing to give him what he never needed. The freedom of God, which seemed at first to make his love precarious, an unobligated gift he might withdraw, turns out to make his love the most secure thing in the universe, because a love that was never earned can never be unearned, a love that was pure gift can never be revoked for failure to pay, a love that needed nothing from you cannot be lost by your inability to provide. The free God loves you freely, and a free love is an unlosable love, and there is no security like it.

I have to confess how much I have wanted God to need me,

because the confession exposes something ugly and important in the sentimental impulse. I have wanted to matter to God in the way that makes me significant, indispensable, necessary, a person without whom God's own happiness would be diminished. And this wanting, dressed up as a desire for intimacy, is really a grasping for my own importance, a wish to be the center, a refusal to accept the humbling truth that God would be perfectly happy without me. It is a hard thing to accept that you are not necessary to God, that the universe would not be missing anything essential if you had never existed, that God's joy is complete with or without you. It wounds the pride. And the sentimental god, the god who needs us, is in part a construction of that wounded pride, a god remade to give us the significance we crave, a god who assures us that we matter so much that he would be incomplete without us. But that god is an idol of our own self-importance, and the true God, the free God, humbles that self-importance and then, in the same motion, gives us a significance far greater than the one we grasped for, because to be loved by a God who did not need you, to be wanted by a fullness that lacked nothing, to be chosen not out of necessity but out of sheer grace, is a significance infinitely higher than being needed. You are not necessary to God. You are something better. You are freely, graciously, unnecessarily loved, loved for no reason but love itself, and that is a glory that being needed could never give.

So the freedom of God is not the coldness we feared but the warmth we never dared hope for, the discovery that the love that holds us was never a transaction, never an obligation, never a payment for services rendered, but a free and unearnable and therefore unlosable gift, poured out on us by a God who needed nothing and gave everything, who was full and made us anyway, who was happy and loved us anyway, who owed us nothing and

went to the cross anyway. That is the God who is not nice, and you can see, I hope, by now, how far above nice he is, how the word nice cannot begin to hold him, how a nice god who loved us out of his need would be infinitely less than this free God who loves us out of his fullness. The nice god needs us and so his love is small. The holy God needs nothing and so his love is boundless, a free gift from an infinite fullness, and to be loved like that, freely, graciously, unnecessarily, by the God who needs nothing and gives everything, is the highest honor a creature can receive, and the securest ground a soul can stand on, and the deepest comfort a suffering heart can know. He did not have to love you. That is the terror of it, and that is the glory of it, and the two are the same, because a love that did not have to be given is the only love that can be fully trusted, the only love that is entirely, gloriously, freely yours.

Chapter Thirty-Four: The Weight That Remains

I have come to the end, and I do not want to resolve this book, because a book about the God who is not nice should not end with the tidy comfort that the nice god specializes in, and because the God I have been trying to describe is not a God who resolves. He is a God who remains, who abides, who stays weighty and holy and terrible and tender long after our words about him have run out. So I will not tie a bow on this. I will try, instead, to name what remains, to leave you with the weight rather than lift it, because the weight is the point, and a reader who reaches the end of a book about the weight of God feeling lighter has read a book that failed.

You will keep reaching for the small god. So will I. The whole of the Christian life is learning, again and again, to let him die.

Here is what remains, first, and I have to say it because it is the truest thing I know about myself and I suspect about you. The nice god does not die easily. I have written thirty-three chapters against him, and I will close my laptop and within the hour I will reach for him again, because he is the god of my fatigue and my fear and my preference for a manageable life, and no book, not even one I wrote myself, can kill him once and for all. The recovery of the weight of God is not a battle you win and then move on from. It is a battle you fight every day, a daily dying to the small god and a daily receiving of the great one, a lifelong

contending against your own preference for a deity you can carry in one hand. I am not writing to you from the far side of this struggle, as a man who has recovered the weight of God and now lives permanently in its blaze. I am writing from inside the struggle, as a man who catches glimpses of the weight and keeps losing them, who tastes the fear of the Lord and keeps fleeing back to the comfortable god, who knows the truth of everything in this book and lives it only in fragments. If you were hoping I would tell you that the small god can be defeated once and left behind, I cannot, because he cannot, at least not by me, and I would be lying to give you a victory I have not won.

But here is what else remains, and it is the thing that keeps me from despair. Every time I let the small god die, even for a moment, even for the length of a single true encounter, the great God proves to be everything I was promised and more, and the memory of that keeps me coming back, keeps me reaching past the comfortable deity toward the terrible and beautiful one, keeps me willing to be undone again because I have learned that the undoing is the doorway to a joy the small god could never give. I have stood in the weight of God, occasionally, really, and I have found that it is the only thing that has ever held me, that the fear of the Lord is the beginning of a comfort no lesser fear can touch, that the God who is not nice is the only God worth having, the only God who can save, the only God who can comfort, the only God who is, in the deepest sense, good. And that memory, that taste, that fragment of true encounter, is enough to keep me fighting the small god, enough to keep me reaching for the great one, enough to keep me writing books like this one that I know I will fail to live up to, because the God I am pointing to is real, and I have met him, and I would rather fail at knowing the real God than succeed at being comfortable with a false one.

And here is what remains, third, for you, and it is a warning and an invitation at once, and I will not soften either. If you have read this whole book and felt the pull of the weightier God, the ache for the holy one, the dissatisfaction with the comfortable deity you have been carrying, then something has begun in you that you did not begin and cannot control, and I have to warn you that it will not leave you where you are. The desire for the true God is itself the beginning of the true God's work in you, and it is a dangerous desire, because the God it reaches for is a God who will not be managed, who will remake you, who will demand everything, who will wound you in mercy and hide from you in love and refuse to be used and decline to be tamed. To want the holy God is to want to be undone, and the undoing is real, and it costs everything, and I will not pretend otherwise. But it is the only path to being remade, the only doorway to the joy and the comfort and the worship you were made for, the only way home to the God who made you for himself and will not rest, being the jealous God that he is, until he has all of you. Do not want him casually. But if you want him, want him fully, and know that the wanting will cost you the comfortable god you have been sheltering behind, and that the loss of that god will feel, at first, like grief, and that on the far side of the grief is the God you were made for, terrible and tender, holy and near, the consuming fire in which, by grace, you will find your home.

I think of Moses, at the end, coming down from the mountain with his face shining so terribly that the people could not look at him and he had to veil it, because he had been in the presence of the weight of God and the weight had marked him, had changed his very face, had left him bearing a glory that the people could not bear to see. That is what an encounter with the holy God does. It marks you. It changes your face. It leaves you bearing a weight that others can see even when you cannot see it yourself,

a gravity, a substance, a holiness borrowed from the God you have beheld. And I want that, more than I want the comfort I keep fleeing to, more than I want the manageable life I keep protecting, more than I want the approval of the comfortable and the safety of the small god. I want the shining face and the borrowed weight and the marked life of a man who has been in the presence of the holiness of God and has not entirely recovered, and never will, and does not want to. I want to be ruined for the nice god forever. I am not there. I keep coming down off the mountain and forgetting, keep letting the shine fade, keep reaching back for the comfortable deity. But I have been on the mountain, a few times, really, and the weight of it remains, and it is the weight of God, and it is the best thing I have ever carried, and I would not trade it for all the comfort the small god ever offered.

So I leave you with the weight. I will not lift it. What comes into your mind when you think about God is the most important thing about you, Tozer said, and I have spent this whole book trying to make what comes into your mind heavier, holier, more terrible and more tender, more like the God who actually is and less like the God we would prefer. Whether I have succeeded is not mine to know. But I know this. The God who is not nice is real, and he is holy, and he is a consuming fire, and he is the Father the fatherless need and the comfort the suffering require and the forgiveness the guilty are dying for and the beauty the soul was made to behold, and he will not be managed, and he will not be tamed, and he will not be used, and he will not be nice, and he is good, unimaginably good, good all the way down, good with a goodness so great it terrifies, and he is coming for all of you, and he will not stop until he has you, and the only wise thing, the only sane thing, the only thing worth doing with the one life you have been given, is to take off your shoes, and stop running, and

let the weight of the holy God fall on you at last, and be undone,
and be remade, and worship. The ground has been holy the
whole time. It is holy now. Take off your shoes.